

Player Design

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Player Visual Design:

Player Environment Interaction:

Ropes:

Climbing Nodes and Ledges:

Levers:

Rest Points:

Breakables:

Props and other cubes:

Player Mechanics:

Stamina:

Resting:

Jumping:

Basic Player Movement:

Climbing:

Swinging on Ropes and the Cube Cord:

Carrying:

Throwing:

Cube and Normal Rope Pulling:

Barging:

Player Progression and Goals:

User Skills:

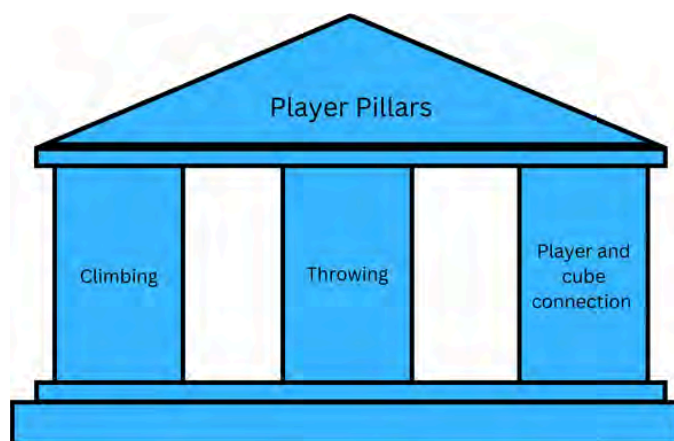
Fail state:

Verb diagram:

Design Philosophy:

Our main philosophy towards player design is to invoke feelings of weakness and reliance on the cube. Throughout the experience players should feel as though they are at a disadvantage or barely surviving in the perilous city. This feeling should be reinforced through player specific mechanics and game elements such as animations and their reliance on the cube's mechanics and abilities for protection. Players should not feel as though they are the main character or central focus of the game, the spotlight should be shared between both the player and the cube. This should be further reflected through the players progression throughout the experience. As the cube grows in weight and power the player should also start to feel more powerful, however this power fantasy is experienced purely because of the cube, the player character has not changed at all which should then be reflected throughout specific level sequences to further reinforce the player and cube relationship

Design Pillars:



Climbing:

Our first pillar is climbing, this refers to how the player will explore the environment, throughout each state of the cubes life, the player will climb with it, help it climb or use it to reach higher places as a way of exploring the terrain and levels. Climbing will

also be used as a mechanic for puzzles forcing the player to climb over obstacles during continuous puzzle sequences, but also as a difficulty intensifier during discrete puzzle sequences.

Throwing:

Our next pillar is throwing. This is a main mechanic the player will use throughout the game with it being the players main form of combat and defence, as well as being utilised in both continuous and discrete puzzles. During the first 2 states of the cubes life, the player can pick up the cube and throw it, allowing them to damage enemies but also solve puzzles which require the cube or rope to be in a certain spot.

Player and Cube Connection:

Finally, our main player pillar; player and cube connection, this is at the heart of everything in [Don't] Let Go from narrative design to puzzle and level design, and gameplay. The players connection to the cube will be a heavy focus with the player requiring the cube to do anything, whether that be combat, solving puzzles, traversing the environment, or even just surviving. We want everything the player does in gameplay to require the cube and thus helping to strengthen the emotional bond the player feels towards the cube.

Player Visual Design:

In order to further our focus on making the player feel weak the visual design of the player character should serve that theme. The player character in [Don't] Let Go should appear more child like in both appearance and animations, moving with inexperience and a lack of precision. The character should also reflect feelings of loneliness and anxiety, appearing cowardly and small through both animations and visual design/character model. In order to match our PS2 art style the character model should be low poly and reflect character model techniques used during the PS2 generation of game development. This ensures we do not waste time developing high quality assets, stay in line with our minimalist approach and ensure that the character fits with the PS2 art style and the rest of the environment. The player character should have a human like silhouette, allowing players to recognise and sympathise with the character whilst still retaining feelings of abstraction.

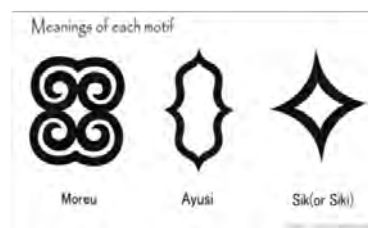
Concept art and inspiration images can be found on the mood board by following this link: [Mood board/art style ideas](#)

Alongside this the player model should aid in creating a mysterious and fantastical feeling atmosphere. The main way we will do this is through the tattoos found on the character model. The tattoos should be reminiscent of Ainu textile patterns. This helps increase the players curiosity, making them question where the main character is from and what their society looks like.

Examples of these patterns/tattoos can be viewed below:



Examples of Ainu pattern tattoos



Examples of the different types of Ainu patterns

The concept images above provide an accurate depiction of what the player characters 3D model could look like in its most basic form however in order to fit within [Don't] Let Go the 3D model needs to be made adhering to the PS2 inspired art style that is used throughout the experience.

Alongside this the players character model should progressively change throughout the experience in tandem with the cube and their relationship to it. As the player progresses the cubes black colour should slowly start to overwhelm the player, appearing to corrupt their player model each time the player increases or upgrades the cubes state. Simultaneously, the cube should gradually become more colourful as though it was sucking the colour from the player and consuming it. A similar mechanic can be found in Shadow of the Colossus, pictured below:



Image detailing the changes in the Wander player model as the game progresses [Shadow of the Colossus]

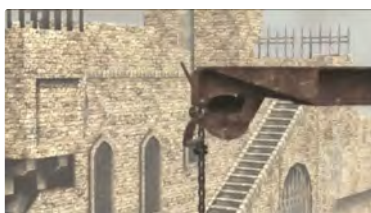
Player Environment Interaction:

Player and environment interaction is an important aspect of [Don't] Let Go's puzzles and overall gameplay, players should be able to interact with the environment in diverse ways in order to simulate a real underground city and provide the player with emergent gameplay possibilities when interacting with multiple gameplay systems. A list of the player and environment interactions can be seen below accompanied by an explanation of the mechanic:

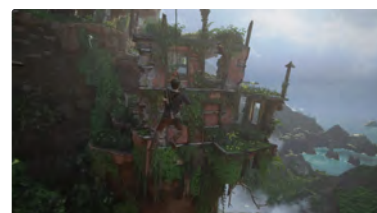
Ropes:

Throughout the levels, the player will find ropes in the environment which they can go up to, interact with and climb up or down. This will act as a way to incorporate more verticality into our levels while allowing the player to explore what's above and below them.

When in cube state 1 and 2, the player will climb the rope with the cube either dangling down and being carried up by the player, or the player placing the cube on its back and giving it a lift up as the player climbs these ropes.



Rope based climbing found in Ico



Rope based climbing and swinging found in Uncharted 4

Climbing Nodes and Ledges:

Across the [Don't] Let Go environment the player will have the ability to climb aiding in their traversal and escape of the city. Players can only climb on specific assets or nodes in this case. These climbable nodes range from ledges to holes in walls and ladders. Players have the ability to climb or jump from node to node allowing them to scale the environment in a linear fashion similar to games like Ico and the Uncharted series. An example of this climbing system can be seen below:



Node based climbing system found in Ico



Node based climbing system found in Uncharted 4

Much like the games above certain climbable nodes should break under the player's weight. These nodes should look different to the others indicating their danger. Once the player attaches to one of these breakable nodes it should not break for a few seconds giving the player a chance to jump off it and onto a safe node.

Levers:

Players will have to interact with levers to solve puzzles, open doors and other potential road blocks. Players can interact with the lever by walking up to the lever and pressing the interact button. This allows them to turn an environment element on or off. Another way players can interact with levers is by throwing the state 1 or 2 cube at the lever when they have locked onto it which allows the player to switch the state the lever is in from a distance.

This mechanic can be used in sequences where the team want to test players on two puzzles at once. For example, to open a door the player might need to stand on a pressure plate which moves a stone down, revealing a lever. They cannot step off the pressure plate otherwise the stone will return to its origin, blocking the lever. Therefore, they must throw the cube at the lever to interact with it whilst standing on the pressure plate.

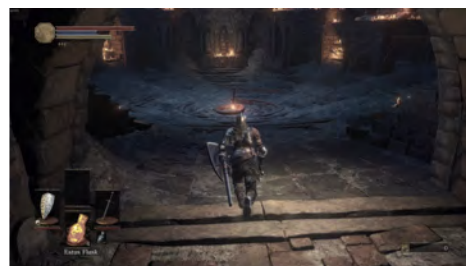
Another example would be if the team continues development of the cart section, challenging players with throwing the cube at levers on the track to change the course their cart is on. This will allow them to avoid dead ends, enemies, and other obstacles that may trigger a fail state.

Rest Points:

Another environmental mechanic players can interact with are the rest points. Rest points as the name implies provides an area for players to rest in-between intense combat and puzzle sequences, playing soothing music and allowing players to bond with the cube. The rest points in [Don't] Let Go are inspired by similar systems found in games like Ico and Dark Souls



The GIF above demonstrates the rest point system found in Ico



The GIF above demonstrates the rest point system found in Dark Souls III

The main rest point function the system offers is allowing players to save and load their progress data. Rest points allow the player to save their progress, ensuring they do not lose it upon closing and reopening the game. This places more emphasis on the rest points within players minds and ensures the experience retains its intensity through the players inability to save and load data, preventing them from breaking the experience. Importantly players should be able to pause the experience wherever they are in the game however they cannot load or save their progress via this menu.

Breakables:

Breakables are another form of player and environment interaction, as the name suggests these environmental props can be broken by the player either in a scripted sequence or when the player throws the cube or other specific environment props at them. Players will be able to “lock onto” the breakable props, enabling them to then throw the cube at it easier. An example of these breakable props within gameplay could be a crate or the support of a bridge. Breakable objects are a major aspect of the environmental augmentation puzzles players will need so solve throughout [Don't] Let Go, an example of this type of puzzle can be found below:



The GIF above demonstrates the destructible environments/gameplay elements found in Ico that we are using as inspiration

Props and other cubes:

The player can pick up items and other cubes which will offer them similar abilities to picking up their cube in the early states; meaning the player can throw the item at enemies to stun them or throw it at other interactable objects (such as levers or breakables).

Player Mechanics:

The section of the player design documentation will focus on explaining how specific player mechanics work, how they interact with other systems and how the player interacts with them:

Stamina:

The player should have a stamina limit of 100 points that is activated by specific actions. Importantly, the players should lose stamina at a steady rate immediately after they drop the cube/stop holding it. The stamina consumption for specific actions within each state can be found below:

Maximum Stamina = 100

Universal	State 1	State 2	State 3
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barging - 10	2 stamina per second away from the cube	3 stamina per second away from the cube	5 stamina per second away from the cube
	Climbing - 10 per jump (same with the ropes)	Climbing - 20 per jump (same with the ropes)	Climbing - 25 per jump (same with the ropes)
	Throwing cube - 15	Throwing cube - 25	N/A
	Pulling - 10 per pull	Pulling - 15 per pull	Pulling - 30 per pull
	Quick interact - 50 limit	Quick interact - 70 limit	Quick interact - 80 limit

The player can get stamina back in two different ways:

Quick interact action:

The first is the quick interact action. When the cube is on the ground the player can initiate a quick interaction. This will play a brief animation where the player will be shown to touch the cube. This will give the player a set amount of stamina back immediately. Importantly, this quick interact has a stamina limit, the player cannot pass that limit by using the quick interact function.

To do this quick stamina interact action, the player must walk up to the cube while it is on the floor and press “△” on a playstation controller.



A GIF showcasing the bandage healing item from Fortnite Battle Royale



A GIF showcasing the capped bandage healing when using bandages in Fortnite Battle Royale

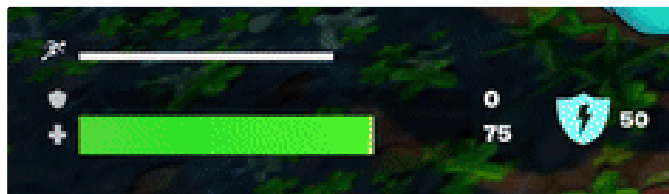
Full regen action:

This is where the second way the player can get stamina back comes into play. To regenerate to full stamina the player will need to hold the cube. After holding the cube for a short duration (1-2 seconds) the players stamina will start to regenerate at a steady pace until it reaches the maximum.

To do this full regen action, the player must pick up and the cube and hold it by holding down the “R2” on a playstation controller when next to the cube.



A GIF showcasing the campfire healing item from Fortnite Battle Royale



A GIF showcasing the slow healing when using a campfire in Fortnite Battle Royale

What happens when the player runs out of stamina and can't reach the cube to get more:

When the player runs out of stamina they should be prevented from jumping and should move at a drastically decreased speed. Furthermore the players stamina should slowly increase to the “pull the cube” limit depending on the state they are in. Their stamina cannot go above this limit until they quick interact with the cube or begin holding it.

Alongside the stamina system other mechanics should be triggered. When the player is running out of stamina the game should slowly become more desaturated until finally resting on black and white when the player is out of stamina. Importantly the player and the cube should be ignored in this desaturation, they should remain coloured. Similarly, when the player is gaining stamina back the colours should increase in their saturation creating a more colourful image when the player has full stamina.

Furthermore, when the player is just about to run out of stamina two things should happen. The players controller should begin rumbling aggressively (this rumbling should get more aggressive as the player reaches 0. This should stop when the player runs out of stamina. In addition, the cube should flash and play a warning sound effect that signals to the player their stamina is extremely low.

Resting:

Resting is a mechanic that the player can interact with once they have reached a rest point. In order to interact with the resting mechanic players will need to press the interact button whilst within the rest points proximity, this will transition players into the resting game state. When in the resting game state the game world will pause/freeze, the resting background music will begin playing and the resting user interface will appear. This interface allows the player to save their progress, quit back to the main menu and importantly, “rest”. The “rest” option will trigger an animation to play showing the player falling asleep with the cube. From a gameplay point of view, the “rest” option will allow the player to set a checkpoint at their current rest point, allowing them to respawn there if they trigger a fail state later into the game. This mechanic is similar to the bonfire system found within the Dark Souls series which can be seen below:



A GIF showcasing the bonfire resting mechanic found in Dark Souls III

Jumping:

Jumping is a basic movement mechanic players will need to use extensively across the experience, it is fundamental to the games systems and the player progress through those systems. Players can jump using the south button (A or X depending on their controller of choice). Within [Don't] Let Go there are 3 different forms of jumping that all act similarly but are found and utilised in diverse situations, these 3 forms can be seen below accompanied by an explanation.

Standard Jumping:

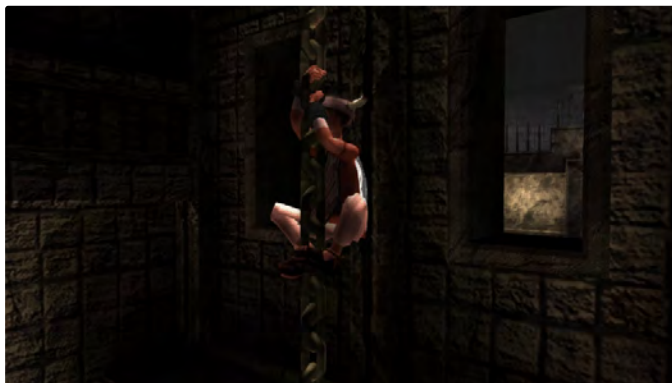
Standard jumping, as the name implies, is the most basic form of the jumping mechanic at the players disposal. Simply, upon pressing the south button the player character will jump directly upwards. When inputting a direction and the south button at the same time the player character will jump in that direction. This system is similar to many other games however we take more inspiration from games like Ico. The players standard jump should feel laboured and heavy in order to emphasise the weak nature of the player character and reinforce our themes of the player being dependant on the cube. We achieve this through our usage of the camera effect and reactive feedback as well as the player controller within Unity. A video demonstrating what the standard jump found in Ico can be viewed below:



GIF demonstrating the standard jump mechanic found in Ico

Jumping off rope nodes:

Alongside the standard jump mechanics players have the ability to jump whilst interacting with a rope node, this includes both the environmental rope node and the cube rope node. When swinging or idling on these rope nodes players will have the ability to jump off the rope by pressing the south button and moving the directional stick. Much like the standard jump, jumping off a rope node should feel laboured and serve as a way to further emphasise the player characters weakness. The Ico demonstration video below is an example of how this system could work:



GIF demonstrating the player jumping off a rope in Ico

Jumping off climb nodes:

The final variation of the jump mechanic within [Don't] Let Go is the players ability to jump off climb nodes. This is functionally similar to the jumping off rope node mechanic however instead of allowing the player to jump off a rope they are holding onto they can instead jump off the wall they are climbing. Much like the previous two jump mechanics, players can do this by pushing their directional stick in their intended direction and pressing the south button (A or X) to jump. Furthermore, this jump mechanic should also appear laboured and weighty in order to further our intended emotional experience of making players feel weak.

Basic Player Movement:

Players will also have access to basic movement mechanics. As the name suggests these basic mechanics are quite standard and similar to other 3D action adventure games. Players will have the ability to move in all 8 cardinal directions using their directional or joy stick. Players will move at a set movement speed removing the need for a sprint or speed boosting mechanic, however players have the ability to walk slowly by slightly pushing the directional stick forward but not all the way. This movement should feel laboured and weighted through the basic controller, animations and the camera. We do this in order to further make the player feel weak and reliant on the cube. The video below demonstrates the movement system found in Ico which captures what we envision for movement within [Don't] Let Go:



The GIF above demonstrates the basic movement mechanics found in Ico

Climbing:

Climbing is another movement based mechanic players can utilise in varying ways across [Don't] Let Go's environments. Climbing in [Don't] Let Go is node based (as mentioned in the **Player and Environment Interaction** section of the player design document) instead of free climbing being more similar to how the player climbs in Uncharted 4 than compared to climbing in The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild. Much like other aspects of the players movement mechanics the climbing should feel laboured and heavy throughout via animations, movement speed and the camera in a similar vain to Ico. The videos below showcase the differences between the two systems whilst highlighting the one that climbing in [Don't] Let Go most resembles:



Video demonstrating the node based climbing system in Uncharted 4, a similar system is used in [Don't] Let Go



*Video demonstrating the free climbing system found in The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild, this is **not** the climbing system [Don't] Let Go will utilise*

In order to begin climbing players will need to jump in the direction of a climbable node. If the node the player has jumped towards is climbable, their character should attach to it automatically, players will not need to press an interact button in order to begin climbing. Once attached to the climbable node the players game state should switch to the “climbing” state. This climbing state subtly affects the camera (the full camera changes can be viewed within the Camera Design Document [Camera Design](#)) and the players movement abilities.

To begin climbing players will need to push their joystick in the direction of another climbable node, whilst pushing the stick towards this node players must press the jump button (X or A). This allows the player character to jump from one node to another in a similar fashion to the Uncharted 4 video in the section prior. The distance players can climb between nodes should be limited giving the player a radius and forcing them to determine which points they can reach and which ones they cannot. If the player jumps to a node that is outside of their reach radius they should miss it and fall either leading to a fail state or attaching to another node that is in their fall path.

However, jumping from node to node is not the only movement option offered to players when they are in the “climbing” state. Players should be able to move horizontally whilst hanging onto ledge nodes. This diversifies the climbing mechanic and offers players multiple ways to traverse a level. Players should be able to let go of this ledge by pressing the A or X button depending on their control scheme, allowing them to drop onto the ground. When players jump towards these ledges they should automatically attach to them similar to the climbable nodes. The Uncharted 4 and Ico videos below demonstrate what this ledge based horizontal movement could look like within [Don't] Let Go:



Video demonstrating the player moving horizontally across a ledge in Uncharted 4

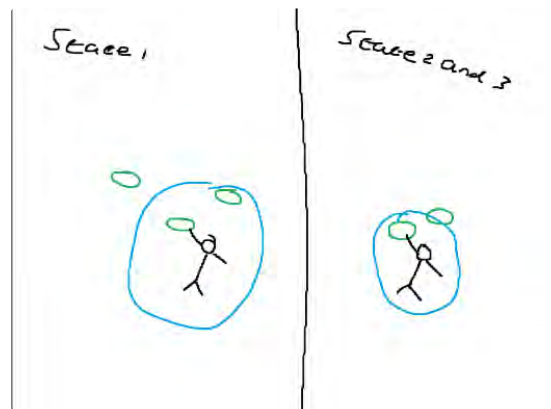


Video demonstrating the player moving horizontally across a ledge in Ico

Similar to other gameplay mechanics, the cube should affect the players climbing ability in different ways depending on its current state. The effects the cube has on the players climbing ability can be viewed below:

All states interaction:

When climbing the player should have the ability to pull the cube towards them if they remain still on a stable climbing node. This allows the player to increase their climbing range and reach spots they previously could not. When pulling the cube should only move slightly, requiring a lot from the player to get it to move a large distance and ensuring they are cognitive with where they leave the cube before climbing. Furthermore, the player cannot pull the cube off a ledge or platform whilst climbing. If they do so the cube will fall and they will be ripped off the climbing node and fall to the platform below or fail state that awaits. The basic diagram below should help to explain this concept:



Basic diagram showing how the climbing limit placed on the player could work

State 1:

When the cube is in state one it should affect the players climbing ability heavily due to the short cord length. When players begin climbing the cube will remain exactly where they left it placing a limit on how far they can go before they reach the maximum cord length and are stopped.

State 2:

When the cube is in state 2 it should also affect the players climbing ability. The cube should remain exactly where they dropped it when the player attaches to a wall and enters the climbing state. If the player reaches the maximum cord length they should be stopped from climbing further instead falling to the platform below. Due to the increased cord length the player will have more freedom over where they can go.

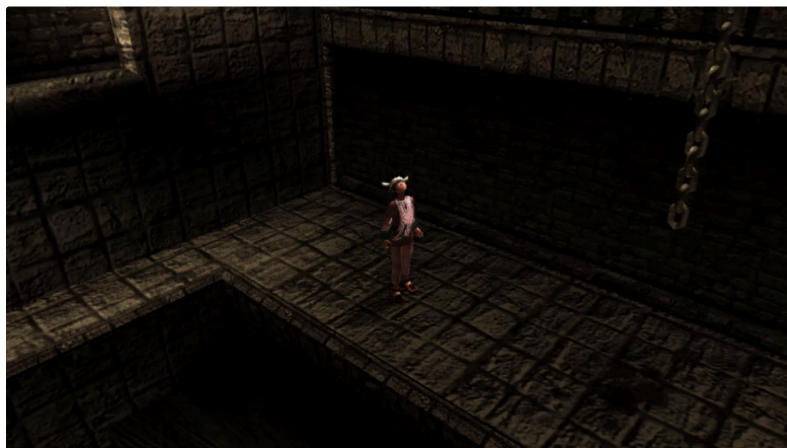
State 3:

When the cube is in state 3 it should also affect the players climbing ability. The cube should remain exactly where they dropped it when the player attaches to a wall and enters the climbing state. If the player reaches the maximum cord length they should be stopped from climbing further instead falling to the platform below. The state 3 cord length is the longest giving the player the most freedom during climbing sequences however pulling the cube is much more difficult to notice, it should not move by a lot.

Swinging on Ropes and the Cube Cord:

Alongside climbable nodes the player can also climb and interact with both environment ropes and the cube cord. Much like the climbable nodes players can interact with the ropes by jumping into them, automatically attaching the player to them and transitioning into the “swinging” state. Much like other player movement mechanics the rope and cube cord swinging should feel heavy, clearly demonstrating that the player character is inexperienced and weak.

Whilst the player is attached to the rope they can use the directional stick and the right trigger to begin swinging in their chosen direction. Whilst players are swinging they should build momentum allowing them to swing faster and further. Momentum plays a large role in determining where the player will land once they jump off the rope. If they have a lot of momentum and jump off the rope they should travel further than they would if they jumped off with little to no momentum. Players can jump off the rope by pressing the jump button (A or X) whilst holding their joystick in the direction they want to jump, however it is important to note the player cannot jump off a rope backwards or to the side, they will only jump in the direction that their character is facing/the rope face they are currently attached to. The Ico video below demonstrates an example of how this system could function:



Video demonstrating the player jumping onto an environmental rope, swinging and jumping off it from Ico

Whilst attached to a rope players have the ability to rotate the player character around the rope in four directions. This rotation allows the player to orient their character ready to swing or jump off the rope and reach new areas of a level. Players can rotate to different points on the rope using the left analogue/joystick stick. This system works similarly to Ico as seen in the gif below:



Video demonstrating the player rotating on a rope found in Ico

When the player is climbing or interacting with a rope node the cube should react identically to how it does when the player interacts with climbing nodes and enters the “climbing” state. A state by state breakdown detailing what the cube does whilst the player is interacting with rope nodes can be seen below:

All states interaction:

When interacting with a rope the player should have the ability to pull the cube towards them if they remain still on the rope. This allows the player to increase their range and reach spots they previously could not. When pulling the cube should only move slightly, requiring a lot from the player to get it to move a large distance and ensuring they are cognitive with where they leave the cube before interacting with a rope. Furthermore, the player cannot pull the cube off a ledge or platform whilst climbing. If they do so the cube will fall and they will be ripped off the rope and fall to the platform below or fail state that awaits.

State 1:

When the cube is in state one it should affect the players rope climbing ability heavily due to the short cord length. When players begin climbing the cube will remain exactly where they left it placing a limit on how far they can go before they reach the maximum cord length and are stopped.

State 2:

When the cube is in state 2 it should also affect the players rope climbing ability. The cube should remain exactly where they dropped it when the player attaches to a rope and enters the rope interaction state. If the player reaches the maximum cord length they should be stopped from climbing further instead falling to the platform below. Due to the increased cord length the player will have more freedom over where they can go.

State 3:

When the cube is in state 3 it should also affect the players rope climbing ability. The cube should remain exactly where they dropped it when the player attaches to a rope and enters the rope interaction state. If the player reaches the maximum cord length they should be stopped from climbing further instead falling to the platform below. The state 3 cord length is the longest giving the player the most freedom during rope climbing sequences however pulling the cube is much more difficult to notice, it should not move by a lot.

Carrying:

Players have the ability to pickup and carry both objects found within the environment as well as the state 1 and state 2 cubes. Players can carry an interactable object by holding the RT (right trigger) button. This should switch the players game state into the “carrying” state. Once the player has entered the “carrying” state the jump function should be disabled until they have switched game state again. Furthermore, depending on the object, the “carrying” game state will affect the player in different ways. Heavy objects such as the state 2 cube or large environment elements should slow the player down once they have been picked up. In addition, heavy objects should not be thrown as far as light ones in order to emphasise their weight and its effect

on the player character. A different set of carrying animations should play depending on the weight of the object the player has picked up in order to improve the overall user experience.

Throwing:

Alongside being able to pickup the cube and environment interactable items players also have the ability to throw both of the objects mentioned. Players can throw an object after they have picked it up via the LT button. Players should be able to throw the cube whilst moving however they should **not** be able to whilst they are jumping. Depending on the players game state this throwing action will be completed differently which can be viewed below:

Locked on throw:

The first type of throw players can conduct is the locked on throw. As the name implies, this version of the throwing mechanic is only triggered when the player is within the “locked on” game state. If the player throws an object whilst locked onto another, the object they threw will hit the element they are locked onto automatically, the player does not need to do any manual aiming. If the locked on object is too far away or moves after the player has thrown their object it will miss them, there should be an extremely low magnetism effect applied to the locked on throwing mechanic as to increase challenge and test the players timing and positioning skills.

Free throwing:

Free throwing is the second way players can throw an environment object or the cube. The trajectory of the thrown object is dependant on the player characters forward facing position, similarly to the locked on throw there is no explicit manual aiming offered to the player. Once the player presses the LT button the object should be thrown in the direction the player character is facing. The object should be thrown at maximum force/reach the maximum cord length as to avoid player frustration and improve the user experience.

Cube and Normal Rope Pulling:

Alongside climbing ropes players should be able to pull ropes and the objects attached to them. This mechanic is primarily applicable to the cube and its cord however there may be instances throughout the environment where rope pulling may be necessary. As the name suggests the rope pulling mechanic should simply pull whatever is attached to the rope closer to the player. Players can do this by holding up on the Dpad switching their game state into the “rope interacting/pulling” state. This will gradually bring the object closer to the player. This should act like an invisible progress bar (this bar should **not** be shown to the player, all of the visual feedback they need should be displayed through the rope getting shorter and the object closer that the player gradually fills by pressing the pull button, if they stop holding the Dpad or move they will drop the object/cube. If the object is heavy (such as the state 2 cube) the time it takes to reel the cube in/pull it to the player will be increased, this aids us in demonstrating the cubes hinderance on the player and their characters weak state.

Barging:

Finally players can have the ability to barging throughout the environment in [Don't] Let Go. Barging should boost the players speed temporarily and provide them with a limited number of “I-frames” in order to protect them from enemy attacks and environment hazards. Barging will allow players to fit under environment objects thus increasing their mobility and prompting exploration.

However, barging is most importantly used to prevent enemies from carrying the cube away to a death state trigger (more information on fail states can be found later in the player design document). When the player slides into an enemy they should be staggered or stunned temporarily. If this enemy happens to be holding the cube they should be stunned/staggered for a slightly

increased time alongside dropping the cube exactly where they are. This allows the player to save the cube and prevent a fail state.

Barging will be used as the player primary defensive mechanic without the cube as it will allow them to attack enemies and stun them without the cube. Furthermore, later in the game, players will combine the use of barging with throwing the cube as a combo attack to defeat enemies. Enemies who have been barged and stunned, will be temporarily marked, this mark allows the state 3 cube to suck that enemy in and consume it.

Alongside combat uses, the barging mechanic will be used as a way of breaking objects, clearing paths, and solving puzzles. Players will be given the option to break objects such as vines, chairs, tables etc. with the barging mechanic or get the same result from throwing the cube.

Player Progression and Goals:

The players objectives are split into two different categories across [Don't] Let Go, these being overall objectives and continuous objectives.

Overall Objective:

The primary and overall objective players will be working towards is escaping the underground city and from a gameplay point of view, finishing the experience. However, before the player can achieve this overall objective they must first achieve all of the continuous objectives.

Continuous Objectives:

Continuous objectives can also be viewed as secondary objectives however they are essential to the players progress, they are continuous due to their constantly evolving (thus continuous) nature. Players will need to achieve 5 different continuous objectives before they are able to achieve their overall goal of escaping the city and completing the game. These 5 objectives are split between each act of the game and can be viewed in the diagram below:

<u>Continuous Objective 1:</u>	<u>Continuous Objective</u>	<u>Continuous Objective</u>	<u>Continuous Objective</u>
Players must learn the basic controls of the game and beat the tutorial sequence	<u>2:</u> Players must find a way to upgrade the cube to state 2	<u>3:</u> Players must find a way to upgrade the cube to state 3	<u>4:</u> Players must find their way back to the main hall, exiting the city Players must sever their connection to the cube

Throughout the experience the players main understanding of progression is centred around the cube and the hub room which both show a different type of progression that will be covered in the section below:

Escape based progression:

The first form of progression is escape based progression. This refers to the progress made towards the players overall objective of escaping the underground city. The [Don't] Let Go environment centres around a hub room that players will consistently return back to in order to access new areas. Within the hub room, players will be able to see the exit door being held down by 2 tentacle like objects. Throughout the experience players will find a way to break these tentacles clearly demonstrating the players progress each time they return back to the hub room. This diegetic progression impacts players more heavily than it would if a checklist or UI element was being altered due to its noticeable and drastic effect on the environment.

Furthermore, the hub room quantifies and demonstrates the players progress through its hub and spoke design. Each time the player returns to the hub room they will unlock a new path or spoke that springs off the hub. This demonstrates progression to the player through the feeling of unlocking new areas and enabling further exploration of the environment. By the end of the game the player should feel as though they have learnt an understood the environment like they would when moving to a new city in the real world allowing us to further immerse the player and ground them within the experience. For example, Shadow of the Colossus achieves a similar environmental and visual based method of conveying progression through the idols that are destroyed each time the player defeats a colossus, an image of this can be viewed below:



Image of the first Idol in the hub room of Shadow of the Colossus before it is destroyed



Image of the first Idol in the hub room of Shadow of the Colossus after the player defeated the first colossus

Cube based progression:

The second form of progression players will notice is cube based progression. Throughout the game players will need to upgrade the cube at specific points. This unlocks new abilities for the cube demonstrating the players progression through tangible gameplay parameters and experience. However, the most important form of progression tied to the cube is the players relationship with the cube. As mentioned on the Game Design Overview page ([Game Design Overview](#)) [Don't] Let Go centres around the players feelings towards and relationship with the cube. As the game progresses and the cube becomes more burdensome to travel with the players relationship should progress from one of fondness to one of annoyance and frustration. This allows us to convey our primary narrative theme of wanting to let go of a changing friend via the players own experience and emotions towards the cube.

User Skills:

The player will require a range of real world and gaming related skills in order to complete[Don't] Let Go. These skills are listed below and are tested via different game elements such as level design, enemy design and puzzle design:

- 3D navigational and spatial awareness skills
- Environmental problem solving and reasoning skills
- Mental map skills
- Positioning skills
- Problem solving skills

- 3D movement and platforming skills
-

Fail state:

Much like other video game experiences within the action adventure genre, [Don't] Let Go will have a death or fail state tied closely to the enemy design and cube design.

In order for a fail state to trigger the enemies must drag the cube to the tentacles they came from or throw the cube and by extension the player into a large pit. If the enemies are able to complete one of the two actions a fail state will be triggered. When a fail state is triggered the players state should switch to the "fail" state. Upon this change in state a death interface should be displayed prompting the player to restart from the last save point or exit the experience.

Furthermore, when a fail state is triggered or when the player is respawned the environment and their puzzle progress should reset. They should revert back to the state it was in when the player first rested/interacted with the rest point they have just respawned back at. This ensures [Don't] Let Go challenges players and increases the stakes during combat encounters, in turn developing and expanding the players relationship with the cube

Verb diagram:

Due to the changing nature of the core mechanics and verbs during the prototyping stages a solidified verb diagram has not been created however a list of all the verbs offered to players can be viewed below:

- Walk/run
- Jump
- Grab
- Pickup
- Roll
- Push
- Throw
- Pull
- Swing
- Climb
- Kick
- Zipline
- Activate/Deactivate
- Climb
- Break

Cube Design

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Cube Visual Design:

Cube metrics (cord length and cube size in each state):

Cube Essentiality:

Puzzle Solving:

Game State Saving:

Combat and Death:

Cube Progression:

Cube States:

State One:

State Two:

State Three:

Additional Mechanics:

Cube communication:

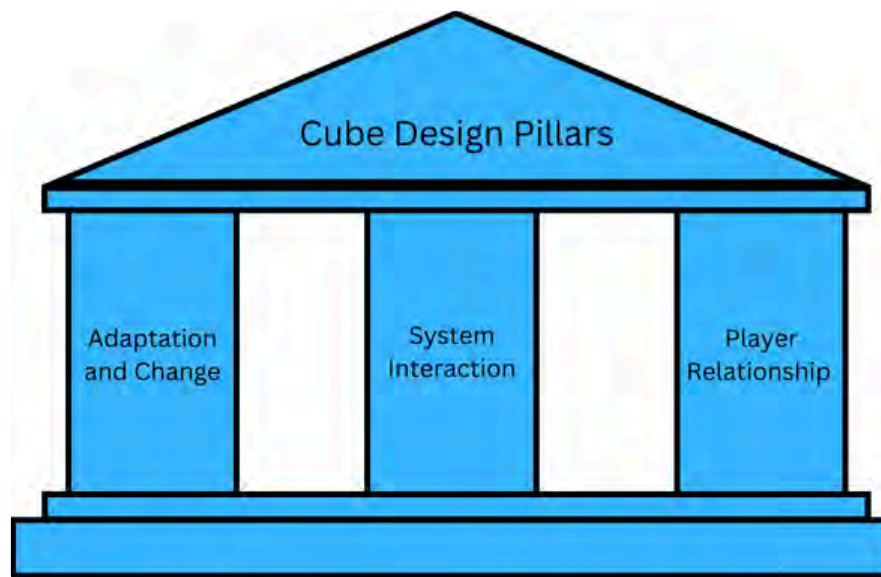
Cube Cord Pulling:

Cube Locked Doors:

Design Philosophy:

The main design philosophy we apply to the cube is an emotional one. Throughout the duration of [Don't] Let Go we want the player to form a strong and intense companionship with the cube, relying on it to help them escape the city and survive the perilous journey. The primary way this relationship should be developed is through gameplay necessity and interactions. Every game mechanic, system and element should be linked to or interacted with via the cube. This ensures that the cube becomes extremely important to the player from a gameplay point of view whilst also keeping the team aligned with the overall subtractive and minimalist approach towards [Don't] Let Go's design. Other secondary aspects of the cubes design such as audio usage and visual design should be used to further reinforce feelings of companionship and importance to the player.

Design Pillars:



Adaptation and Change:

The first design pillar, “adaptation and change”, refers to how the cube, its visual style and mechanics will change throughout [Don’t] Let Go. As the player progresses the cube will subtly change each time they upgrade its state increasing in both size and weight whilst also unlocking new mechanics such as automatic enemy attacking in state 3. The changes made to the cube will also affect the players relationship with it allowing the team to further expand upon and explore the primary narrative theme of “letting go of a friend that has changed/is changing” & “letting go of something that is bad for you”

System Interaction:

The second pillar, “system interaction”, refers to the overall approach the team is taking towards the cube and its design. The cube should be an essential pillar of the game and its basic gameplay loop. Therefore, every mechanic in the game should have interaction with or link to the cube and the player ensuring the cube becomes an essential aspect of the experience and maintaining the teams design by subtraction philosophy.

Player Relationship:

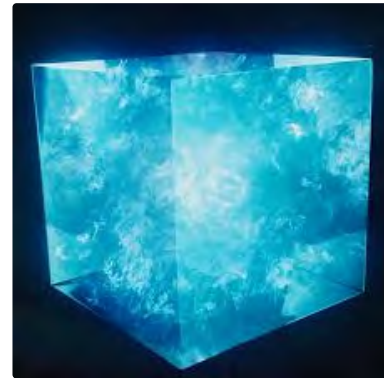
The final pillar, “player relationship”, refers to the strong emotional connection we want players to form with the cube. By the end of the experience the player should feel like the cube is a trusted companion and friend, making the ending sequence where the player will need to abandon the cube more impactful and heart-breaking. Furthermore, this pillar refers to the basic gameplay loop, ensuring the cube is an essential aspect of the players gameplay loop they must interact with consistently across the experience in order to progress.

Cube Visual Design:

Similarly to the player characters visual design, the cube should also be extremely simple and reminiscent of a PS2 game. This ensures that our art style stays consistent throughout the game. The cube should start as a primarily black object with a mist or smoke like appearance within it similar to the concept images below:



An image of the Palantir from Lord of the Rings



An image of the Tesseract from Avengers

As the game progresses this black mist within the cube should slowly transfer from the cube and onto the player, demonstrating its life sucking effect on the player and their relationship. Alongside this, when the cube is touching the environment it should suck the colour out of whatever it touched. For example, when the cube is in state 3 and pushed across a large distance it should leave behind a line of black and white in an otherwise colourful environment, appearing similarly to the trail left behind by a snail. At the same time the inner mist should transition from a black colouring to being more colourful, reflecting the environment it has been dragged over.

Whilst the cube should not contain fine details as to ensure compatibility with the PS2 art direction the cube should be designed in a way that takes advantage of the pareidolia effect. The pareidolia effect is a commonly experienced psychological phenomenon that makes people see faces in ordinary objects, an example of this effect can be viewed below. The cube should be designed in a way that takes advantage of this effect, allowing players to form a stronger bond to the cube through personifying it despite it still being an object. Furthermore, as the game progresses the cubes perceived “face” should change in emotion, going from weak and desperate in state 1 to angry and intimidating in state 3.



An example of the pareidolia effect



An example image showing how a persons eyes can communicate the emotion they are feeling. The cube should utilise a similar approach being more implicit and vague than explicit

To further personify the cube it should flash each time it “talks” to the player. This offers the player visual feedback whilst also allowing them to build a stronger connection to the cube via its attempted communication and subsequent personification. Each time the cube flashes it should do so in an off white hue in order to contrast its normal black appearance and stand out to the player.

In addition, the cube and its corners should change as its states increase. In state one the cubes corners should be rounded and appear soft in order to communicate feelings of companionship and safety. However, each time the player upgrades the cubes state these corners should become sharper with the state 3 cube having normal cube corners to communicate feelings of danger and demonstrate the cubes subtle personality shift with each state.

Cube Essentiality:

In order for players to form a strong bond with the cube it must be essential to them in many gameplay aspects such as puzzle solving, combat and even outer game mechanics such as saving. The cube and its essentiality towards the previously mentioned systems can be read in the section below:

Puzzle Solving:

The primary challenge players will encounter in [Don't] Let Go are the puzzles spread throughout the environment, attempting to prevent the player from going any further and escaping the city. However, the cube can be used to help solve these puzzles allowing the player to progress and begin to build a strong relationship with it. In order to adhere to our overall design pillars the cube should be utilised in every puzzle across the game as a major or essential aspect that leads to the solution. A list of examples outlining the way the cube can be used in puzzle environments and situations can be viewed below:

- The Cube could be used as an anchor point, allowing players to swing or abseil to an objective
- The Cube could be used to activate or flick a lever from a distance
- The Cube could be used to destroy part of the environment (such as a pillar) to create a path to the objective
- The Cube could be used to block a door from closing
- The Cube could be used to activate pressure plates

The list above is not exhaustive, it should only provide the reader with examples of the way the cube and its abilities can be used and further expanded upon through puzzle sequences

Game State Saving:

Saving is an extremely important aspect of a players overall user experience in any and all games. In [Don't] Let Go we take a slightly different approach to saving than the typical systems found in other action adventure experiences. In [Don't] Let Go, the player should not be able to save anywhere or at anytime, the pause menu should not offer players the ability to save. Instead, the player should only be allowed to save when they reach specific “rest points” spread periodically throughout the environment. Furthermore, players must bring the cube inside of the rest point in order to activate it and enable saving. Once both conditions have been met the player should be able to interact with the rest point and gain access to the saving user interface. We believe that this will help the player form a stronger bond with the cube through saving and its nature as an “external” mechanic. Saving and its importance to the players progress and user experience should increase their reliance on the cube.

Combat and Death:

Finally, the cube should be an essential tool the player must utilise to protect themselves from enemies and prevent fail states from triggering. This section will be split into the following two categories: combat and fail state dependence. Both sections will explore how the cube becomes an essential aspect of the game when the player is in combat scenarios.

Combat:

The Cube is the only way the player can defend themselves from enemies in [Don't] Let Go. Players must use the cube as a weapon, throwing it at enemies to defeat them until it grows into the state 3 cube and can defeat enemies autonomously. We believe that this will further increase the connection players form with the cube via its direct participation in defending the player from fail states and progress loss.

Fail State Dependence:

Alongside its importance in combat, the cube is also the only way a fail state can be triggered. In [Don't] Let Go the enemies attempt to grab the cube and steal it from the player. If they are successful in stealing the cube and taking it to the tentacle they spawned from the fail state will trigger and the player will be sent to their last checkpoint. Due to this the cube becomes an extremely essential gameplay element the player needs to protect in order to prevent a fail state from triggering. The importance placed on protecting the cube ensures that the player begins to form a stronger bond with it through both the feelings of protection and aid they need to provide alongside the gameplay based consequences of losing the cube and the subsequent fail state and potential loss of progress that occurs.

Cube Progression:

The cube is the primary form of progression within [Don't] Let Go with it changing both visually and mechanically throughout the experience to demonstrate the changing relationship between the player and the cube. These changes can only be triggered when the player reaches a specific location in the game world. Once the player reaches this specific location the cube and its properties will change in front of the player through the two previously mentioned aspects: visuals and mechanics.

Starting with the visual progression, providing players with an easily understandable way to visualise their progress is extremely important in keeping the player motivated and to help them in understanding their reward for completing gameplay challenges. The cube and its progress throughout [Don't] Let Go is shown through two different aspects: its size and its colour. Starting with size, each time the player upgrades the cube its size and weight will increase going from a

being smaller than the player to towering above them. This provides the player with an extremely clear and quantifiable progression whilst also demonstrating the cubes growing power. The second way progress is shown is through the cubes changing colour. Each time the player upgrades the cube it should slowly switch from being a void like black to sucking the colouring from the player and the environment. This not only shows progression through the cubes visuals but also through the players visuals achieving a similar foreboding and fearful feeling that players get in Shadow of the Colossus as they slowly watch Wander and his features change as the souls of the dead colossi infect him.



The image above showcases the changes in Wander's character model as the player progresses through Shadow of the Colossus thus providing them with a visually understandable representation of their progression through the game.

Furthermore, the cube and the game mechanics linked to it subtly change throughout the experience in order to give players a sense of progression that they can feel and quantify via gameplay. In the beginning the cube should be quite unobtrusive and weak, not offering the player much other than aid in defeating enemies and accessing game elements that may be far away such as levers. However, the way the player interacts with the cube should be extremely simple with them being able to pick it up and throw it. As the player continues their journey the cube and its interaction with game elements such as enemies and the player should change. For example, in state three the player should not be able to carry the cube, instead being forced to push it and enemies should be automatically killed by the cube to demonstrate its now increased power and the players progress through its gameplay mechanics. Furthermore, as the game progresses the cube should unlock new abilities such as its anchor ability players can use as a way to swing across a chasm or from ledge to ledge. These subtle changes demonstrate the players progress via gameplay aiding in making this progress feel more impactful and understandable, players can feel how far they have progressed through the change in the game

mechanics not just through visual changes that do not permeate deep into the players understanding of the game.

These changes link back to the overall cube design pillar of “player relationship”. Each time one of these changes occur whether it is mechanical or visual they directly affect the players relationship and feelings towards the cube. This is important as it achieves and demonstrates the primary narrative theme of a friend slowly changing for the worse and hints at the players eventual need to let go of the cube. As the weight increases and the cube sucks the players colour from their character their relationship should slowly progress from one of caring and companionship to weariness and betrayal. In this sense, the players feelings towards the cube are also an essential aspect of the games progression providing them with feedback they can understand through their underlying emotions towards the cube.

Cube States:

The Cube in [Don't] Let Go is split into three different states that each contain and outline different gameplay mechanics, interactions and visuals specific to that state. The section below will breakdown these changes in all three states exploring all of the gameplay and visual changes each state brings:

State One:

State one is the first cube state of the three. The cube should start on this state once the player finds it in the environment. Overall, the cube should be unobtrusive and provide the player with many uses despite its weak and small nature

Player Interaction:

Starting with player and state one cube interaction, the player should be able to pick the cube up with ease due to its low weight. Once they pick the cube up it should not restrict their movement allowing them to move quickly and easily. Furthermore, when the player throws the cube it should be thrown at maximum power, reaching the maximum cord length easily due to its light weight. In addition, the player should be able to pick the cube back up and be ready to throw it again (“reload” it) extremely quickly due to its small size. However, due to this being the first state the cube’s cord length should be short, keeping it nearby the player at all times. Furthermore, pulling the cube via its cord should be easy in state one.

Environment Interaction:

Moving onto environment interaction, the state one cube and its interaction with environment elements should be restricted and mostly non-existent. This is primarily due to the cube's size and weight alongside its nature as a tutorial or introduction to the cube and its mechanics. However, the state one cube should be able to interact with basic and puzzle-centric environment elements such as pressure plates, levers and buttons enabling the player to activate them from a distance via the cube.

Enemy Interaction:

The state one cube should be able to interact with enemies much more than the environment; however, these interactions should again be basic and emphasise the cube's lack of power at this point in the game. Players should be able to throw the cube at enemies in order to defeat them; however, due to the cube's size and weight, it should take 2 throws/hits to defeat a single enemy. Furthermore, only one enemy is needed to lift the state one cube and take it to a fail state trigger such as a door or pit.

Visual Changes:

When in the first state, the cube should be half the size of the player character and covered in a void-like black colouring that does not immediately invoke feelings of warmth and friendship. At this point, the player should be their normal blue colouring.

Emotion and Relationship Changes:

As the player starts their journey with the state one cube, they should feel an urge to protect it and a growing companionship due to the cube's small size and usefulness in solving puzzles and defeating enemies. These feelings should also be enhanced via the cube's lack of obtrusion in normal gameplay mechanics such as movement and climbing.

State Two:

The Cube should switch into its State Two form once the player finds the upgrade point in the environment. Overall, the state two cube should start to restrict the player slightly and begin to introduce the primary theme of a friend changing. Alongside this, the cube should be shown to

grow in power and provide the player with more gameplay abilities to demonstrate its new found strength.

Player Interaction:

The way that players interact with the state two cube is different to how they interact with the state one cube. One of the similarities is in the the verbs attached to the state 2 cube, players can still pick it up, carry it and throw it however each of these should appear more laboured and should be slower to complete. For example, carrying the cube should decrease the players movement speed slightly. In addition, when the player throws the cube it should take longer for them to pick it back up again and be ready for another throw (the “reload” time should be increased slightly). However, to compensate for these two restrictions the state two cube cord should be longer. Furthermore, whilst the cube should still be placed on the players back when they are in the “climbing” state it should decrease their movement speed to match the decrease in normal movement speed.

Environment Interaction:

The state two cube should have much more environment interaction mechanics than the state one cube. The state two cube due to its increased size, weight and power should be able to destroy the structures it has been thrown at such as an unstable pillar in order to provide deeper and more thoughtful puzzle solving sequences. Furthermore, the state two cube should be able to interact with heavier pressure plates and weight based puzzle elements such as a seesaw much easier.

Enemy Interaction:

The state two cube interacts with enemies in a similar way to the state one cube. Players will still need to throw the cube at an enemy in order to defeat it however in state two the cube should do more damage, defeating the enemy in a single hit. Much like the state one cube, only one enemy is needed to lift the state two cube however the enemy that is holding it should move slower as to demonstrate its increased weight and provide the player with the chance to save the cube.

Visual Changes:

In state two the cube and its colour should subtly change. Instead of being a void like black it should appear to be sucking the blue colouring from the player character with that same blue colouring slowly consuming or switching places with the black. In a similar vain, the player character should appear to be losing its colour and getting infected by the cubes previously black colouring. Importantly, the transition between the two colours needs to be shown in this state with both game elements not being a solid colour yet.

Furthermore, the cube should grow in size being almost the same height as the players character model.

Emotion and Relationship Changes:

Finally, the state two cube should make the player feel slightly differently. Whilst the feeling of companionship and growing friendship should still be there, subtle emotions of distrust and doubt should be present ensuring the player is recognising and feeling the more sinister changes the cube is going through and how that is affecting them however it is important to note that feelings of distrust should be kept at a minimum during state two.

State Three:

State three is the final cube state and as such it should function vastly differently to its previous states. Overall, the state three cube should fill the player with distrust and annoyance, demonstrating the duo's now waning relationship and revealing the primary theme of "letting go of a changing friend" for the player to see clearly. Alongside this, the cube should be at its most powerful in order to intimidate the player but also provide them with great functionality, making letting go a more difficult task.

Player Interaction:

The way the player and state three cube interact should be vastly different to how the player has interacted with the previous two states. To start, the player should now need to push or pull the cube in order to move it due to its large weight and size, this in turn slows the player down when they are moving with the cube. In addition, they cannot pick the cube up at all however they are now able to climb on top of the cube allowing them to reach higher environment elements.

Importantly, the cube now acts as a major anchor to the player causing both negative and positive side effects. This anchor like weight now means the cubes will also limit the players movement and climbing mechanics heavily, preventing them from going far away and holding

them back via the cord connecting the two. As a result, the cube cord length should be increased drastically however a sense of restriction should remain present despite this increase in order to continue exploring and furthering [Don't] Let Go's narrative themes.

Environment Interaction:

Alongside the movement difficulties players experience, navigating the state three cube through the environment and its many obstacles should also prove to be a great challenge and restrictor of progress. However, whilst the state three cube is difficult to move through the environment it should also grant the player with navigational aid through its large size. For example, players should be able to climb on top of the cube and gain access to a higher level.

Enemy Interaction:

Enemy interaction is another area where the state three cube sees massive changes. In state three the cube should attack enemies on its own, appearing to grab them and eat them in front of the player, this mechanic should be placed on a short cooldown as to maintain game balance. Furthermore, two enemies are required to lift the state three cube to a fail state trigger to further demonstrate its heavily increased weight and size. In addition, the state three cube should be able to block the death wave, creating a bubble like shield and protecting the player within. This means that the player will no longer need to frantically run away from the death wave in an attempt to find a safe rest point that will protect them.

Visual Changes:

Visually the state three cube should also experience vast changes to its previous states. In state three the cube and player should have swapped colours completely with the player now being a void like black and the cube being an energetic blue. Furthermore, the state three cube should be shown to consume the colour in the environment elements it touches leaving behind a line of grey wherever the player pushes it to further [Don't] Let Go overall narrative themes. Finally, the state three cube should tower over the player being almost double their size.

Relationship Changes:

By this point in the game the player should feel extremely distrustful of the cube and their companionship, they should feel that the cube is a completely different object or person forming a large rift between the two. Whilst the player should feel ready to let go of the cube and move

on this should be difficult for them via the state three cubes increased usefulness as well as the emotional connection they formed with it during the previous two states. The player should let go of their friend by the end of the state three cube sequence however this should be extremely difficult for them to do.

Additional Mechanics:

Cube communication:

As mentioned prior in the document, the cube has the ability to “talk” to the player. Exploring this feature further, the cube should appear to “talk” or communicate with the player at specific points or after specific events. For example, when the cube has been picked up by an enemy it should sound as though it is screaming and should start flashing rapidly in order to convey its panic and fear. Another example is after the player solves a puzzle or saves it from enemies the cube should sound congratulatory or grateful. This communication helps the player personify the cube and build a deeper relationship to thus enabling [Don’t] Let Go to be a more impactful and investing experience. The cube should also beep almost like a metal detector when a rest point is nearby, guiding the player towards it in a helpful manner to aid in further developing the relationship between the two.

After the player has upgraded the cube to its third and final state the cube should stop communicating with the player in order to start building distance and distrust between the two parties helping to serve [Don’t] Let Go’s narrative themes.

Cube Cord Pulling:

Alongside being able to pick the cube up and carry it the player can also pull the cord that attaches them to the cube. This enables the player to pull the cube towards them aiding in navigating the environment and preventing enemies from stealing the cube. The player should be able to pull the cube cord by holding up on the d-pad. If they stop holding the pull button the cube should stop moving immediately. The stamina cost of pulling the cube should increase with each cube state making it more difficult for the player to pull the cube as its size and weight increases.

Cube Locked Doors:

In specific areas of a level there should be doors that block the player from progressing unless they have the cube with them. This prevents the player from leaving the cube far away and

potentially breaking or ruining gameplay sequences. As a result, these doors can only be opened when both the player and the cube are near them with this mechanic working similarly to the doors that are unlocked by Yorda in Ico. This further increases the cubes essentiality and importance to the player and their progress through [Don't] Let Go.

Enemy Design

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Enemy Visual Design:

Enemy Types and Statistics:

Normal Enemy:

Brute Enemy:

Flying Enemy:

Fail State Trigger:

Enemy and Player Interaction:

Enemy and Cube Interaction:

State One Cube:

State Two Cube:

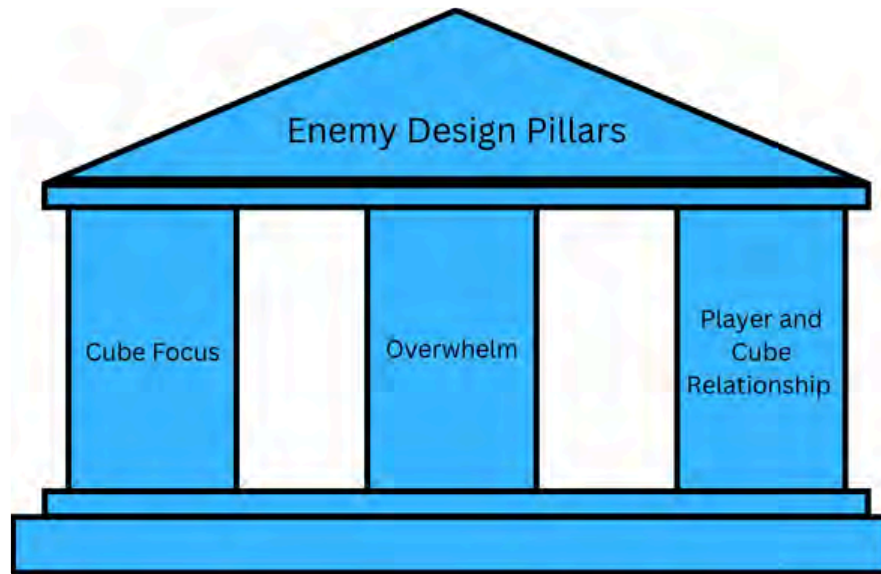
State Three Cube:

Spawn Mechanics:

Design Philosophy:

The design philosophy/approach we take towards the enemy and its design in [Don't] Let Go is one centred around the players relationship with the cube. Enemies in [Don't] Let Go should be viewed more like tools to enhance and test this relationship. They should not be considered an essential pillar or core aspect of the [Don't] Let Go experience and as such they should not be extremely difficult challenges for players to overcome instead exploring and expanding upon the players relationship with the cube through specific combat encounter sequences. Furthermore, the enemy encounters should be used as tools to help the team increase the pacing and intensity of the gameplay loop and specific levels in order to create an engaging and exciting experience for players.

Design Pillars:



Player and Cube Relationship:

As mentioned in the design philosophy, a core aspect of the enemy design in [Don't] Let Go is its exploration and expansion of the players relationship with the cube. Enemies should serve as a way for the player to feel both reliant on and protective of the cube through the enemies and their objective to steal the cube from the player. Furthermore, the enemies should be used as a way for the player to feel connected to the cube via using it as a weapon to defeat enemies, increasing its importance to the player.

Overwhelm:

The second enemy design pillar is “overwhelm” which refers to the central emotion the team wants enemy encounters to trigger. Enemies should intimidate and overwhelm players through both their large numbers and superior strength over the players character. Each encounter should invoke feelings of panic and distress in order to disorient players and create gameplay sequences that are more intense to contrast other aspects of the game like puzzle and exploration sequences.

Cube Centric:

The final design pillar refers to the enemy’s target. Throughout the experience the enemies should target the cube to further expand upon the players feelings of protection towards the cube. The enemies should have minimal interaction with the player ensuring they do not feel in as much danger as the cube, switching their mind from one of survival to one of protection and selflessness, emphasising their strong bond with the cube.

Enemy Visual Design:

The enemy visual design should follow a similar approach to the cube and player visual designs to ensure [Don't] Let Go has a consistent art style throughout the experience, preventing breaks in immersion. The enemies should also be minimal in their asset detail, instead being more like vague silhouettes and solid colours in a similar vein to the player characters visual design. The enemies should be a solid black colour with minimal greys used as highlights or when the enemy is near a light source. Importantly, this colour should not change with enemies remaining a solid black for the entire experience. We use black for the enemy visual design due to its connotations with death and destruction, outlining the destructive nature of the enemies immediately which is then reinforced by its gameplay mechanics.

Alongside its basic colour being similar to the player, the enemy's visual design should be humanoid like in a similar vein to the player's visual design. However, where the two differ is in the enemy visual designs Lovecraftian and Alien inspirations. The enemy models should appear to have sharp, claw like appendages as well as multiple intimidating tentacles that attach to the models back. This should be done to create a model that feels intimidating and otherworldly, striking fear into players through its unnatural design. Example inspiration images can be viewed below:



Examples of Lovecraftian creature silhouettes



Example of the Alien's visual design, notice its sharp appendages and threatening design

Enemy Types and Statistics:

Normal Enemy:

Behaviour:

The normal enemies should act as an overwhelming force attempting to send the player into a panicked state. The normal enemies should behave and attack the player in stages/states. In stage one the enemies should attempt to knock down/stun the player, targeting and attack them primarily. If the enemies manage to stun/knock down the player then they should switch into the second state. In the second state one enemy should be selected to pick up the cube and begin dragging it to the fail state trigger. Whilst this enemy is dragging the cube, 2 more enemies (depending on how many are in the scene) should try to attack the player, stopping them from saving the cube. The remaining enemies who do not have one of these two jobs should step back, appearing as though they are watching the battle until the player saves the cube and reverts the enemies back to state 1.

Statistics:

Cube State 1 Enemy Statistics:

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Three times	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 3 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 2 seconds	Slightly decreased player speed	Slightly decreased player speed (fast)

Cube State 2 Enemy Statistics:

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube

Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Twice	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 3.5 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 2 seconds	Slightly decreased player speed	More decreased player speed (medium)
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Cube State 3 Enemy Statistics:

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Once	2 Enemy	No stagger	Enemy should stagger the player for 2 seconds	Slightly decreased player speed	Heavily decreased player speed (slow)

Brute Enemy:

Behaviour:

The Brute enemy should have the exact same behaviour as the normal enemy (refer to the sequence above) except there should be some basic statistic changes to alter how the player will interact with enemies and increase the tension of the combat encounters.

However, where the brutes differ in behaviour is in regards to the players ability to stun/knock them to the ground. In order to knock a brute to the ground players will need to tackle or throw an environment object at them twice. On the first hit the brute should appear to lose balance and on the second hit the brute should fall over and enter the stunned state.

Statistics:

Cube State 1 Brute Statistics:

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Four times	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 3.5 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 3 seconds	Slightly decreased player speed	Slightly decreased player speed (fast)

Cube State 2 Brute Statistics:

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Three times	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 3.5 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 3 seconds	Slightly decreased player speed	More decreased player speed (medium)

Cube State 3 Brute Statistics:

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst
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				Holding	Holding
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Once	2 Enemy	No stagger	Enemy should stagger the player for 3 seconds	Slightly decreased player speed	Cube decreased player speed (slow)

Flying Enemy:

Behaviour:

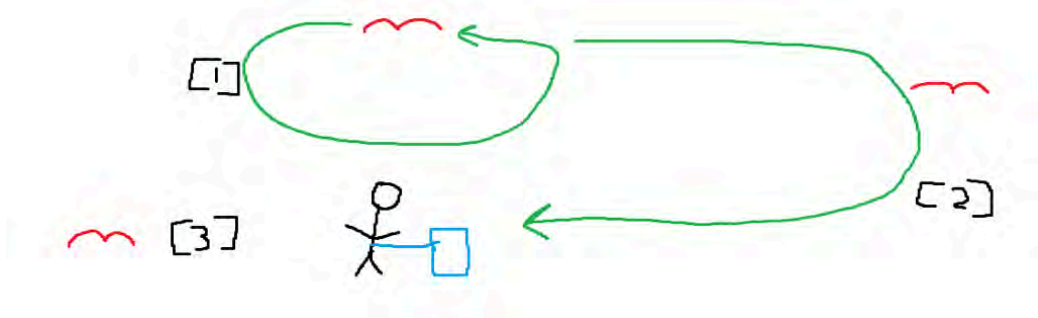
The flying enemy and its behaviour should be split into three different states those being, waiting, attacking and recovering. These states will be explained below:

In the waiting state the flying enemy should appear to circle above the player in a similar manner to a vulture. This circling should be above and locked onto the players transform so wherever they move to the flying enemy will still appear above them.

In the attacking state the flying enemy should stop circling the player and fly in a straight direction before turning around and swooping towards the player. Half way through swooping towards the player the enemy should stop tracking the cubes movements, instead flying straight and allowing the player or the cube to dodge the attack. If the cube is hit by the enemy it should pick the cube up, regardless of whether the player is holding it or not. Once the enemy has grabbed the cube the player should transition into a tug of war sequence where they will need to rapidly press the pull cube button to force the flying enemy to drop the cube. If the player is successful the flying enemy should be stunned for a few seconds, falling to the ground and giving the player a chance to attack it.

In the recovering state the enemy should land briefly (4 seconds). This time frame gives the player an opportunity to attack or stun the enemy. After the recovering state has ended the enemy should fly upwards again and return to the waiting state, repeating the behaviour cycle

Additionally, when the cube reaches state 3 the flying enemies should stop targeting the cube and instead target the player, attempting to stun them and providing the ground enemies with a chance to attack the cube and take it to the tentacles they came from.



The image above outlines the basics of how the flying enemy behaviours should function

Cube state 1 Flying Enemy Statistics

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Twice	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 5 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 2 seconds	Slightly increased player speed	Slightly decreased player speed (fast)

Cube state 2 Flying Enemy Statistics

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube

Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Once	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 5 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 2 seconds	Slightly increased player speed	More decreased player speed (medium)
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Cube state 3 Flying Enemy Statistics

Health	Enemies needed to carry cube	Staggered time	Player Stagger Time	Enemy Movement Speed Before Holding Cube	Enemy Movement Speed Whilst Holding Cube
Enemy should die after being hit by the cube Once	1 Enemy	Enemy should be stunned for 5 seconds	Enemy should stagger the player for 2 seconds	Slightly increased player speed	Cannot pick up cube

Fail State Trigger:

Adhering to the overall enemy design pillars, a combat based game over or fail state can only be triggered via the cube and the enemy's interaction with it. The enemies attempt to grab the cube and steal it from the player. If they are successful in stealing the cube and taking it to the tentacles the enemies spawned from or throwing it down a pit/hole the fail state will trigger and the player will be sent to their last checkpoint.

Enemy and Player Interaction:

Moving onto the enemy and player interactions they can be split into the following 2 categories: inflicting and inflicted with these two categories referring to the way that enemies will interact with the player. An explanation of the mechanics and types of interactions within these categories will be explored in the sections below:

Inflicting Interaction:

Inflicting interaction refers to all of the mechanics or behaviours an enemy will use to attack and challenge the player.

Enemies have the ability to stun/stagger the player. This staggering attack is triggered when the enemy dives into or swings at the player. If the enemy does manage to hit the player with this attack they should be stunned for 2-3 seconds before regaining control over their character. This provides the enemies with a window to grab the cube and helps increase game pacing and tension. Importantly, the player cannot die from this stun attack nor can a fail state be triggered, ensuring the cube remains an important aspect of combat encounters.

Inflicted Interaction:

Inflicted interaction refers to all of the player and enemy based interaction that the enemy will receive from the player.

The player should have the ability to stun and knock down the enemies that they face using two differing methods, tackling and throwing environment props.

Firstly, players should be able to tackle enemies using the circle button. The players model should appear to jump into and tackle the enemies which, if successful, will stun/knock the enemy to the ground for the specified amount of time (this can be found in the tables above)

Players can also stun/knock down enemies using props found throughout the environment. For example, players could pick up a barrel and throw it at an enemy. This will stun them in the exact same way as the tackle except it is now ranged.

Enemy and Cube Interaction:

The enemy and cube will also have specific interactions that aid in creating the desired overall gameplay loop.

The first interaction the cube has with enemies is an offensive one. The cube can be used to defeat enemies being either thrown at them or attacking them automatically. These combat based interactions change depending on the state the cube is in.

The second interaction the cube has with enemies is heavily linked to how [Don't] Let Go's fail state is triggered. Enemies will need to carry the cube to the tentacles they came from or throw it into a pit, however much like the first interaction this also changes based on the cubes state.

A breakdown of the state based changes in both interactions can be viewed in the section below:

State One Cube:

Players should be able to throw the state one cube at enemies, allowing them to deal damage and defeat them however due to the cubes size and weight it should take 3 throws/hits to defeat a normal enemy. Furthermore, only one enemy is needed to lift the state one cube and take it to a fail state trigger such as a door or pit.

State Two Cube:

The state two cube interacts with enemies in a similar way to the state one cube. Players will still need to throw the cube at an enemy in order to defeat it however in state two the cube should do more damage. Much like the state one cube, only one enemy is needed to lift the state two cube however the enemy that is holding it should move slower as to demonstrate its increased weight and provide the player with the chance to save the cube.

State Three Cube:

In state three the cube should kill enemies automatically, this range should be large circular collider around the cube. In order to kill the enemies the player will need to stun/knock down an enemy first. Once they have been stunned the enemy should be killed also immediately. Once the state three cube has attacked there should be a short (maximum 5 seconds) cooldown time before the cube can kill an enemy again. In addition, two normal enemies will be required to push/pickup the cube and take it to a fail state trigger, the flying enemies will be unable to pick up the state three cube, instead they should attack and stun the player.

Spawn Mechanics:

Spawning enemies in [Don't] Let Go is simple and could be compared to how enemies spawn in a game like Ico. Enemies will spawn from the tentacles throughout the environment which they also need to take the cube to once they grab it. This ensures the player understands and perceives the doorway as being on the enemies side whilst also enabling them to begin positioning themselves as far away from the door as possible.

The number of enemies being spawned is variable and depends heavily on the level and the design of the combat encounter. However, if a large number of enemies is required they should spawn in a staggered or wave like fashion. This ensures the player does not become too overwhelmed whilst also preventing the environments from becoming too clustered. Whilst a wave like structure should be used it should not be explicit like it is in games like Call Of Duty. Instead, each time an enemy dies another one should spawn ensuring pressure is still placed on the player without overwhelming them too heavily or introducing a pacing breaking intermission between wave spawns.

Puzzle Design

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Puzzle Archetypes:

Individual Puzzle Types:

Weight Puzzles:

Parkour/Climbing Puzzles:

Cube Separation Based Puzzles:

Timing Based Puzzles:

Environment Augmentation Puzzles:

Environment Navigation Puzzles:

Lock and Key Puzzles:

How Puzzles Fit into Levels:

Puzzle Elements:

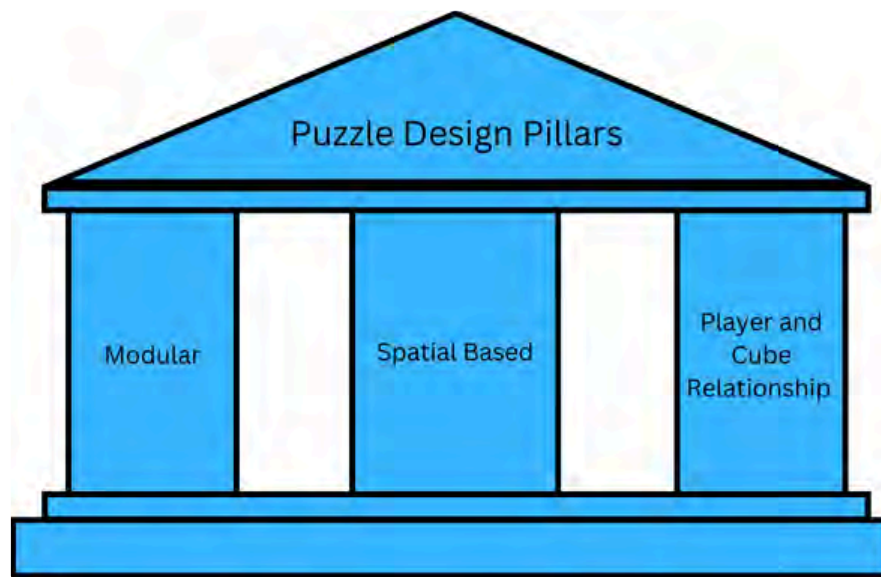
Puzzle Rewards:

Design Philosophy:

Our main philosophy/approach we take towards puzzle design is similar to all other aspects of the game, primarily the puzzles and their design should further reinforced and test the players relationship with the cube through its essentiality to puzzle solving. Interaction with the cube should be required during each puzzle sequence in order to further reinforce its importance in the players mind and improve their bond. As a result, each puzzle should test or build upon a different cube mechanic in order to keep puzzles engaging and challenging, limiting puzzle repeats as much as possible.

Additionally, puzzles should be designed to test the players spatial awareness and navigational skills. Majority of the puzzles in [Don't] Let Go should test the players ability to understand 3D spaces and how rooms or other areas connect to each other, aiding in creating a maze like underground city environment to further immerse players and link to the games overall narrative.

Design Pillars:



Spatial Based:

The first puzzle pillar “spatial based” refers to how puzzles should be designed within [Don’t] Let Go. Puzzles should challenge the players understanding of the environment, testing their spatial awareness and navigational skills in order to provide and create a complex, maze like environment to enhance the players immersion and deliver the intended experience.

Player and Cube Relationship:

The second pillar “player and cube relationship” links to the overall design pillars. The puzzles within [Don’t] Let Go should primarily reinforce and test the players relationship with the cube through the its essentiality towards solving puzzles and progressing through the experience. Each puzzle should involve some sort of player interaction with the cube to further this relationship.

Modularity:

Finally, a major design pillar of the puzzles in [Don’t] Let Go is “modularity”. Each puzzle type and element should be modular, allowing it to connect to other systems and increase interactivity between the player and the game systems. Each puzzle type should also be modular regarding the cube states and their interaction with the puzzle system, aiding in creating a varied and engaging puzzle solving experience.

Puzzle Archetypes:

There are two different types of puzzles the player will encounter throughout [Don’t] Let Go these being the continuous and discrete puzzles. These categories were created in order to

better organise the different types of puzzles and help the game designers pace them throughout the experience. An explanation of these two puzzle categories can be found below:

Continuous:

Continuous puzzles should be blended into the environment, appearing as though they are apart of the environment. They should be low in cognitive load, being easily understood and solved quickly. They should centre around the players interaction with the cube with many of the continuous puzzles tasking the player with using the environment to find a way to get the cube past an obstacle. For example, the player may need to climb a wall and then pull the cube up and over it with them. This slows the players progress without completely stopping it, introducing a brief spike in player engagement and cognitive load to enhance the levels pacing.



An example of a continuous puzzle from Ico that we are using as inspiration

Discrete:

Discrete puzzles are more basic in their design, being what players will likely think about when puzzles are mentioned. Discrete puzzles are ones that block the players progress completely unless a specific condition is met or the player solves the puzzle. These puzzles should be a major focus in the environment, often being the focus of an entire level or room similar way to how puzzles within Zelda dungeons are structured in relation to the environment. Discrete puzzles should be challenging, forcing players to use everything they have learned and placing a high cognitive load on players.



An example of a discrete puzzle from The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time we are using as inspiration



Another example of a discrete puzzle from The Legend of Zelda: Twilight Princess we are using as inspiration

An example of how these two puzzle archetypes fit within a level sequence can be viewed below:



An example of how puzzle sequences fit within the levels and the overall experience

Individual Puzzle Types:

- introduce all 7 puzzle types and why we designed it this way, explain that they should be modular and repeatable to fit with game pillars and create a varied experience
- Each puzzle should have multiple different variants that work with each different cube state
- List all 7 puzzles and explain how they work

Weight Puzzles:

Weight based puzzles are challenges that require the player to use their characters body, the cube or other objects to achieve certain goals such as balancing scales, activating pressure plates or using see saws. These puzzles are discrete puzzles as they would have a proprietary object the player must interact with to solve the puzzle and they would take centre stage of the players attention throughout the puzzle.

These puzzles will change drastically depending on which state the cube is in, for example, in state 1 the cube will be small and light, therefore weight based puzzles during this early stage of the game would require them to find other objects in the environment to help weight down a see saw so the player and the cube can reach higher grounds or a new area.

In state 2 the cube will be bigger and heavier than the previous state, and now the cube can be used in weight puzzles alongside other objects in the environment. And finally, in state 3, the cube is huge and much heavier and it will be used as the main interactable in these weight based puzzles, from balancing scales to being dropped on a seesaw to shoot the player to higher grounds.

Parkour/Climbing Puzzles:

Parkour and climbing puzzles could be either continuous or discrete, from jumping across platforms to knocking down objects to climb to progress. The player must figure out where they need to go and how they can get there. In state 1 these puzzles could be knocking down something to use as a ramp or ladder or jumping over gaps and hazards. In state 2 the player will use the ability to throw the cube up onto ledges to allow them to climb higher. In state 3 the cube will be too heavy to throw and lift up so the player will need to find other ways to get the cube to higher places such as elevators. The player may also need to use other objects such as minecarts to get the cube around in state 3.

Cube Separation Based Puzzles:

These puzzles will require the player to complete certain segments without their cube. Due to how small the cube is and how short the rope is in state 1, the player cannot leave the cube so these puzzles won't show up during this stage of the game. In state 2 the player will be able to leave the cube. This ability can be tied into other puzzle types such as weight based puzzles as the player may need to leave the cube on a pressure plate while they do something else in order to unlock a door or access a new area. Cube separation puzzles will be at their most unique during state 3, as the cube is so heavy and big it will restrict the player in a few ways. Therefore, the player will find it useful to leave the cube down while they complete other tasks regularly. For example, leaving the cube while the player abseils down a pipe to retrieve a key item. These puzzles will make for a unique break from normal gameplay as everything else revolves around the cube so when the player has to leave it to complete something on their own it will create for a different experience.

Timing Based Puzzles:

Timing based puzzles can be either continuous or discrete from simple things such as jumping off a moving or rotating platform at the right time, to throwing the cube at a target which sets off a timer for the player to reach the objective by, before it runs out. In state 1, the player would throw the cube at a switch to activate it (which could briefly unlock a door or move an obstacle) and then run to the goal before the timer runs out and the puzzle resets to the start. In state 2 the player may encounter a door which as they approach starts closing slowly, they would need to throw the cube in the path of the door and keep it propped open so they can get through. Another timing based puzzle the player might encounter is a path of crumbling tiles and the player would need to throw the cube at them to see if they fall or are safe to walk on in order to find the correct path, while the walls are closing in so they have to be quick in decision making.

and planning and fast in reacting. Finally, in state 3 the player would need to push the cube onto a pressure plate at a specific time in order to stop or activate something. We could also reuse the door closing puzzle but this time the cube would need to be pushed into the doors path to block it open, rather than thrown.

Environment Augmentation Puzzles:

Taking inspiration from the dungeons in 3D Legend of Zelda games, we want to test the players ability to interact with the environment as this will create for a memorable unique puzzle experience from the player's point of view but, also test soft skills such as memory and pattern recognition. Some of the ways we might have the player change the environment includes; pillars or platforms collapsing, stair cases moving, doors and barricades being destroyed, bridges collapsing or moving, rooms flipping upside down, and bridges and pathways raising or spawning to create new pathways. These puzzles may reoccur in similar fashion no matter what state the cube is in, however the difference each time would be how the player causes the augmentation or changes the environment with the cube. For example, the cube is state 1 would be too small to break a pillar that it would be able to break in state 2, so instead the player would need to search around the area for an object they can use to break the pillar.

Environment Navigation Puzzles:

Environment navigation puzzles will typically be continuous puzzles and serve to briefly test the players ability to move themselves and the cube around the environment. These could include throwing the cube over a fence and then climbing over it after, or throwing the cube over a large gap and then jumping after. Or these puzzles could be the simple act of pulling the cube up to higher ground or throwing it across a gap. Finally, in state 3 the cube could be used to plug holes and gaps so that the player can cross safely, or climbing the cube and using it as a way to reach higher platforms.

Lock and Key Puzzles:

Lock and key puzzles refers to any type of puzzle where the player must find or interact with something which will then unlock somewhere else either as the overarching puzzle of the room, or as a mini puzzle as part of a larger one. The player may need to find a physical key item in order to unlock a door, or they may need to interact with a switch or lever which would unlock a door or allow access to a new area. These puzzles could start out simple with one key and one lock to progress, but could be modified and expanded upon as the game progress to keep the difficulty rising with the players skill level. For example, multiple locks and keys for one puzzle or mixing the lock and key type with another puzzle type for example a timed based lock and key puzzle, where the player has to throw the cube at a switch which unlocks a door but they only

have a few seconds to reach the door before it closes again, so they must throw the cube at the door before it closes so they can get through. Turning a simple lock and key puzzle into a fast paced 3 step puzzle that would require the player to be quick, decisive and show the ability to plan ahead.

How Puzzles Fit into Levels:



An example of how puzzle sequences fit within the levels and the overall experience

By using a varied combination of these puzzles in each area, we hope to create a challenging and fun experience which is constantly testing the players skills and ability to use everything they have been taught at once. Furthermore, by having multiple puzzle types, as designers we can mix and match them in our levels to make each one feel different from the last and have more control over the difficulty of each level.

Puzzle Elements:

Zooming further into the puzzles each one is made up of “elements” that are modularly designed to work and interact with each other. This provides the level and puzzle designers with more freedom to create engaging and varied puzzle solving sequences. Below a list of the puzzle “elements” can be found with each one being accompanied by a brief explanation of its function:

- **Environment Cube** - Players can pick up other cubes spread throughout the environment using the right trigger. These cubes allow players to reach higher ledges/areas of a level as well as activate pressure plates and interact with weight based elements like seesaws or scales.
- **Weight Based Elements** - Weight based elements refers to any game object that is affected by the players or environment objects weight. Objects such as seesaws and scales fit within this category and can be used by players to reach new areas.

- **Pressure Plates** - Pressure plates are simple puzzle elements that react to the players, environment objects and the cubes weight. Once these pressure plates have been pushed down they should activate or enable another game element. If the object holding the pressure plate down is moved off it the other game element should deactivate.
- **Levers/buttons** - Much like the pressure plates, players can interact with levers and buttons. Both of which will activate or deactivate the game element that they are linked to such as activating and deactivating a platform.
- **Destructible Objects** - Within specific sections of the environment players will be able to destroy pillars and other structural game objects like walls. This allows them to augment the environment, aiding them in solving puzzles and allowing the game designers to create more varied puzzle sequences that adequately test the players spatial awareness and 3D reasoning skills.
- **Locked Doors** - As the name suggests, locked doors will prevent the player from entering an area unless that have a key or have met another game condition. These doors can be unlocked by finding a key within the environment or by pulling a lever. Furthermore, some doors can only be unlocked by using the cube in a similar manner to the doors that Yorda unlocks in Ico.
- **Ropes that move** - again as the name suggests, these ropes should move. This movement could be continuous (the rope moves on its own continually as the game plays) or activated (the rope moves when the player jumps onto it).

Puzzle Rewards:

The main rewards players get from completing a puzzle (continuous or discrete) is the ability to continue progressing through the game and upgrade the cube to the next state. However, to enhance the sense of reward and accomplishment the player feels once they solve a puzzle the cube should congratulate them via its beeping and flashing language mentioned in the

Additional Mechanics section of the **Cube Design Page** (linked here: [Cube Design](#)). This should give the player immediate feedback upon solving a puzzle, acting as a satisfying reward

they can quantify and feel straight away. Furthermore, this reward should help deepen the players bond with the cube.

However, the player will not get any physical reward (unless they are upgrading the cube) after solving a puzzle. This allows us to stay inline with our design by subtraction approach, ensuring we do not have items or upgradable aspects of the player character. The reward for solving puzzles should be predominantly intrinsic and emotional, linking to the overall intended experience for [Don't] Let Go.

Level Design Hub Page

[Design Philosophy:](#)

[Design Pillars:](#)

[Universal Level Metrics:](#)

[Level Linking/Structure:](#)

[Overall Level Pacing:](#)

[Links to Level Layouts:](#)

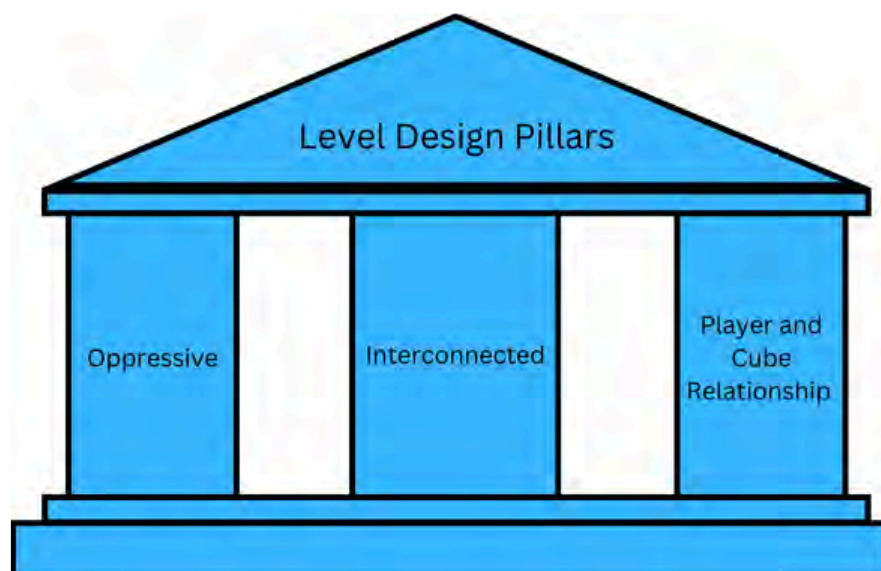
[Visual language:](#)

Design Philosophy:

Our main goal/philosophy regarding level design is to create an environment that simulates and captures feelings of expansion and complexity through the interconnected nature of the games areas/levels. The environment should simulate an underground city with areas connecting to each other in a believable manner. Every area of the game should be connected in multiple ways to another whether that is through the hub room or connecting corridors/areas. The player should be able to see areas they have both conquered and are still yet to reach to further simulate a large and intimidating environment.

Alongside this, the level design should continually test and further the players relationship with the cube through both gameplay at atmospheric means. The levels should feel oppressive and continually build upon the players reliance on the cube through the hazards and challenges found within each level. The environment should feel like a third neutral entity, neither aiding nor attacking the player but being wholly unpleasant to venture through in order to improve the bond players have with the cube.

Design Pillars:



Interconnected:

The first design pillar is interconnected. This design pillar refers to how the environment and the levels should be designed in a high level and overall sense. Each level or area should connect to another whether that is through sight lines or through movement/gameplay, the player should always be able to see the next area they need to reach or an area they have just beat in order to provide both a sense of progression and a landmark to use as a way to progress. Furthermore, each level or area should be connected to the hub room, providing the player with a central environment they can use to access new areas/levels to further demonstrate their progress.

Intimidating:

The second design pillar is intimidating. This pillar refers to the overall atmosphere and tone the levels and their design should elicit within players. The environments should feel large, intimidating and oppressive in order to make the player feel weak and more reliant on the cube for protection and companionship. As mentioned in the design philosophy section, the environment should feel uncomfortable to traverse with it feeling like neither an enemy nor an ally to the player.

Player and Cube relationship:

The final pillar is player and cube relationship. Much like other aspects of the game the levels and their design should aid in furthering or testing the players relationship with the cube through the design of the challenges and hazards within as well as the overall feeling the environments elicit through lighting, atmosphere, tone and environment art.

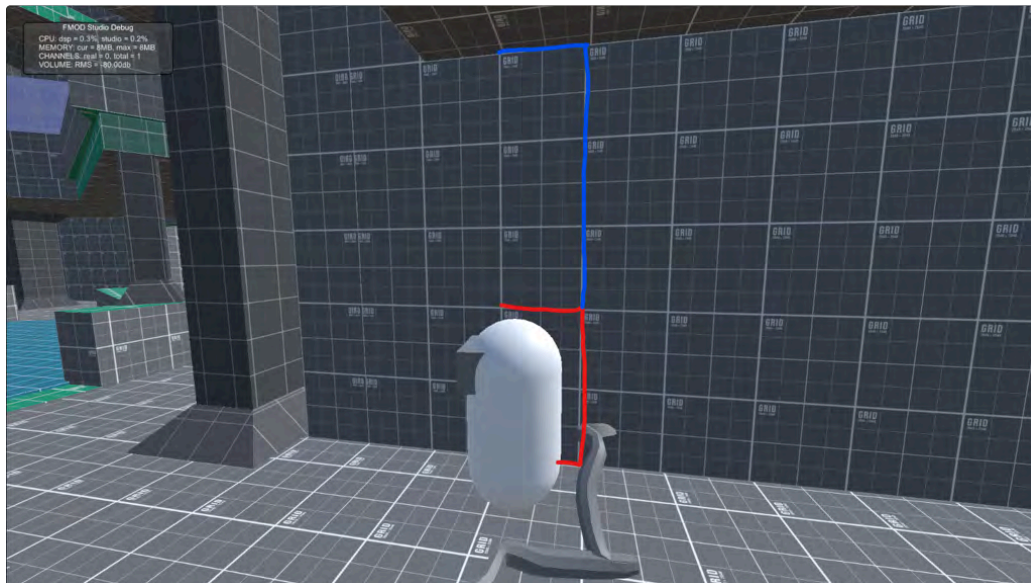
Universal Level Metrics:

During this prototyping phase universal level metrics have not be solidified due to the lack of a defined player model and player metrics.

Currently, the players capsule collider is the height of 2 unity grids/units and the width of 1 unity grid/unit. This information should be used to make prototyping environments that fit around the player.

Adhering to the information above, ceilings should be 3-4 unity grids/units higher than the player capsules maximum height in order to provide enough space for the camera to move comfortably and allow the player to jump to their maximum height without colliding with game objects.

An example image can be viewed below showcasing the height of game elements during this prototyping phase:



Level Linking/Structure:

Similarly to the previous sections, the way levels link together is still largely undefined. During the prototyping stage we created the basic bubble diagram found below. It demonstrates how levels in the final product could connect to each other however this is a work in progress diagram. The diagram below can also be viewed on the Brainstorming Ideas page (linked here: [link](#)):

Brainstorming Ideas)



However the hub room and its design is a largely defined aspect of [Don't] Let Go's environment. Levels in the final product should be linked via the hub room in the centre of the environment in order to provide players with a way to understand the environment and access new areas/levels

Furthermore, whilst we are largely undefined with how specific levels link to another we will be using a continuous level design approach. This means that each level should connect to another in a continuous manner, there should not be a loading screen or cutscene that acts as an intermission in-between levels/rooms. The player should be able to walk from one level and into another in an uninterrupted fashion to adhere to our overall philosophy of creating an interconnected and city like environment.

Overall Level Pacing:

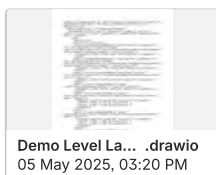
Similarly to other aspects of [Don't] Let Go's level design, the overall pacing between levels in the final product is still a work in progress design element that will be defined more heavily during the alpha and beta stages of the project

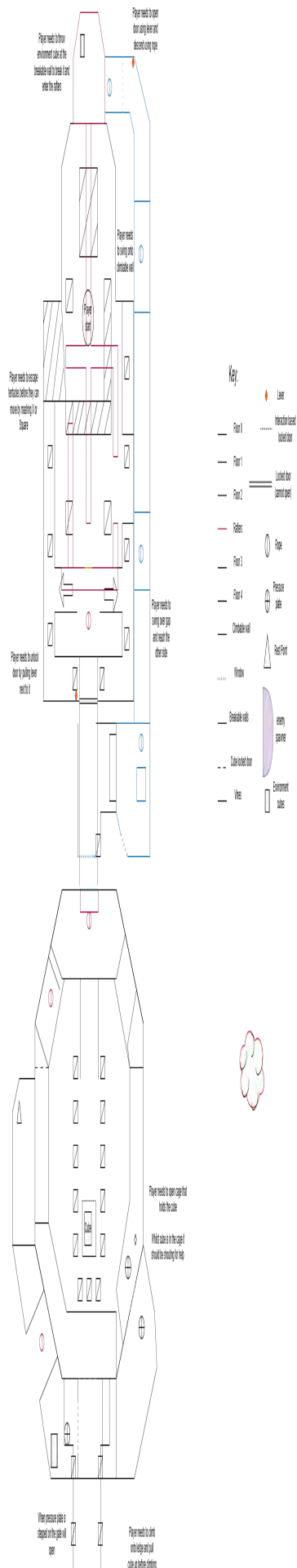
Links to Level Layouts:

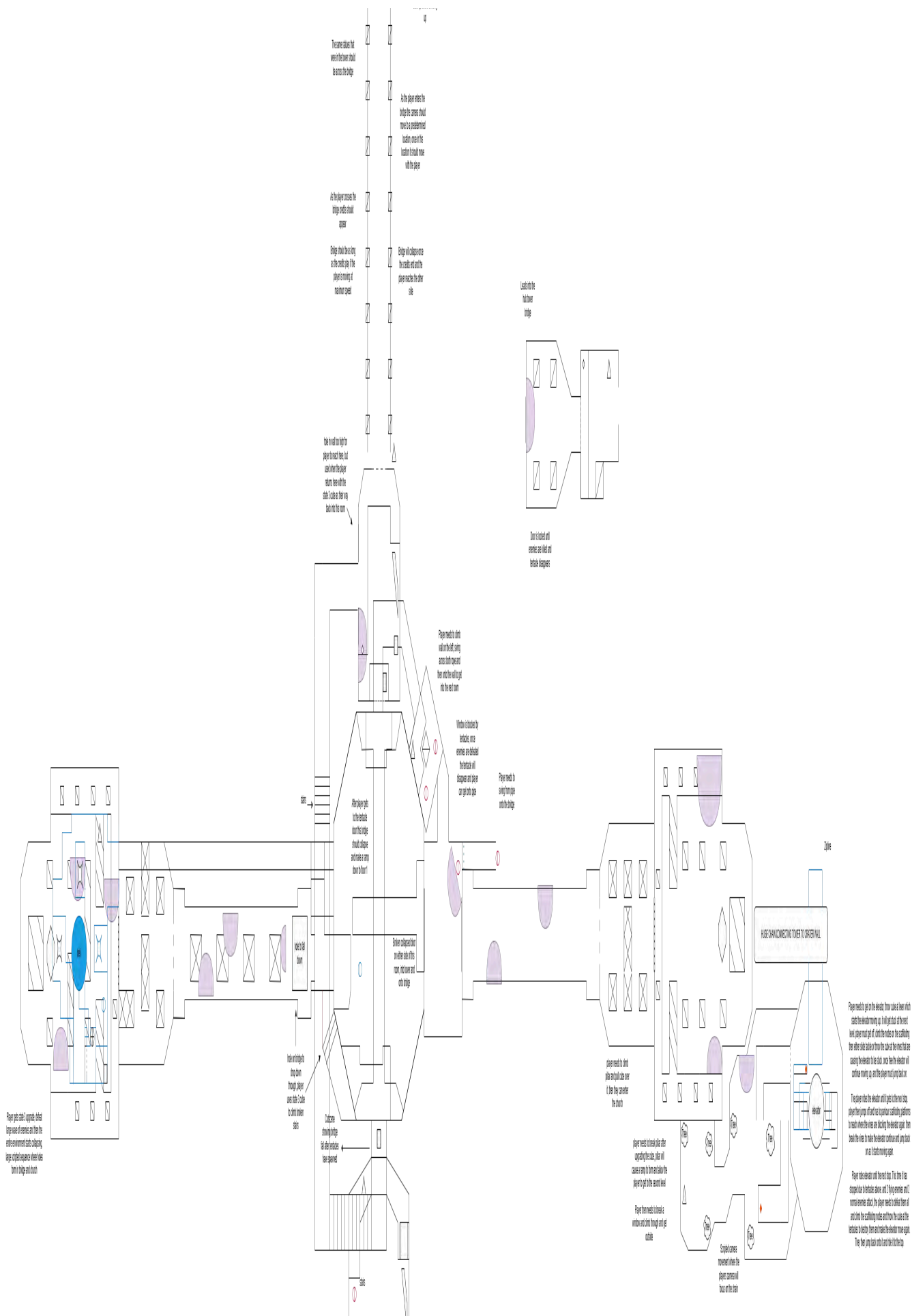
A link to the level layout diagrams can be opened below:

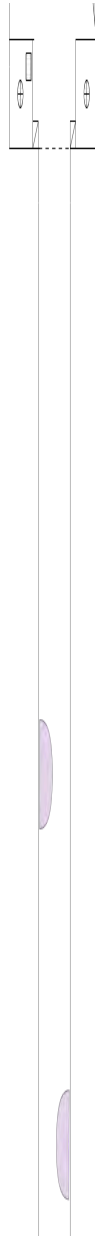
In order to open the diagram, download it and open the file through the [Draw.io](https://draw.io) website.

Prototype Demo Level Layout:









Paper needs to be
plotted to create a map
about how to get to the
base and open the gate

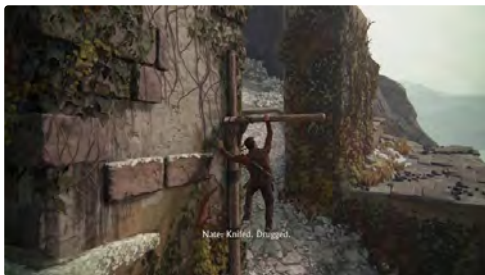
Visual language:

The overall visual language used throughout [Don't] Let Go's environments has yet to be defined and will not be during this prototyping phase. The visual language should work harmoniously with [Don't] Let Go's overall art style and direction, this is currently undefined and as such so is the visual language.

However, the team has considered what the visual language in [Don't] Let Go could be, whilst basic, the information below should give other team members a sense of the direction [Don't] Let Go's visual language is moving in

Game elements that are climbable such as ropes and climbable nodes should feature a white paint scratch across its surface. This enables the climbable point to stand out against the mostly dull background environment and visual style whilst also adhering to more universal visual

language used in other experiences like Uncharted 4, allowing players to quickly and easily understand what the climbable point is via pattern recognition.



An example of white highlighting being used to denote a climbable surface in Uncharted 4



Another example of white highlighting being used to denote a climbable surface in Uncharted 4

Furthermore, interactable objects such as levers, buttons and environment props should be a purple or dark blue colour in order to stand out against the environment and communicate feelings of usefulness through the connotations both colours have to such feelings.

Finally, environment objects that can be destroyed such as pillars or walls should be an orange or yellow colour in order to communicate feelings of destruction and align [Don't] Let Go's visual language with other similar experiences. In addition, these destructible objects should contain textures that simulate cracks and breaks within the object to further communicate the objects destructible nature.



An example of a texture denoting a breakable game element (Silent Hill 2 Remake)



An example of a texture denoting a breakable game element (The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild)



An example of a texture denoting a breakable game element (The Legend of Zelda: Majora's Mask 3D)

Alongside the aforementioned visual language indicators the visual language of [Don't] Let Go should also rely on shape theory heavily with useful and safe objects being more square and cubic in their design whilst objects that can be destroyed or pose a threat to the player should be triangular and sharp in their design.

Gameplay Demo Level Design

Level Name: Gameplay Demo

Pre-production:

Narrative Location:

Mechanics List:

Level Narrative and Link to the Overarching Story:

Experience Goals:

Player Primary Goals:

Length Estimates:

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Puzzle Design:

Cube State 2 Environment Puzzle:

Cube State 3 Weight Based Scales Puzzle:

Cube State 3 Crumbling Platform Statue Puzzle:

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Intro Level Layout and Blockout Images:

State 2 Puzzle Room Level Layout and Blockout Images:

State 3 Puzzle Room Level Layout and Blockout Images:

Hub Room Level Layout and Blockout Images:

Pacing:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Hard Gates:

Soft Gates:

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Hub Room Guidance:

Visual Language:

Teasing/Breadcrumbs:

Level Name: Gameplay Demo

Pre-production:

Narrative Location:

Underground City, bridge and entrance to the underground city

Mechanics List:

A list of all the mechanics used throughout the level can be found below

Movement Mechanics:

Cube Mechanics:

- | | | |
|--|--|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Climbing • Jumping • Rolling • Swinging on rope and cube cord | <u>Environment Based Mechanics:</u> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Elevator travel • Breakable pillars/objects • Seesaw and scales (weight effected environment objects) • Resting/saving at rest points • Switch/lever interaction | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Cube throwing • Cube pulling • State 3 automatic attacks |
|--|--|--|

Level Narrative and Link to the Overarching Story:

- There is not an explicit narrative link in the gameplay demo. This level should be used as a showcase of game mechanics, level design and puzzle design only.
- Throughout the demo the player should gain a sense of companionship and friendship between themselves and the cube via the puzzles they solve and specific gameplay sequences/scripted events

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Feel a sense of companionship between themselves and the cube
- Learn and understand fundamental game mechanics such as jumping, cube throwing and climbing
- Play a complete MVP that demonstrates the game in its most basic form giving them a vague outline of the finished product, allowing them to understand how development will progress.

Player Primary Goals:

- Defeat enemies in the hub room and secure it as a safe location
- Upgrade the cube to state 3
- Complete the demo

Length Estimates:

Critical path - 7 minutes

Golden Path - 10 minutes

Average/first playthrough - 12 minutes

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Bridge collapse sequence:

Shortly after starting the demo players should encounter the bridge collapse sequence. This is a heavily scripted set piece that modifies game elements such as the camera.

Once the player steps onto the bridge the camera should automatically pull back and zoom outwards, placing the player on left most third line and focusing on the structure on the other side of the bridge heavily. As the player moves the camera should too in an on rails fashion. During this sequence the player should not have control of the camera.

When the player reaches the midpoint of the bridge it should collapse, creating a small hole that splits the bridge in two and prevents the player from backtracking. When the midpoint of the bridge begins to collapse the camera should automatically pan above the hole in order to emphasise the height of the bridge.

When the bridge collapses the cube should fall into the hole however it is important to note that the player must make it over to the other side before the bridge collapses. Players must pull the cube up and out of the hole caused by the collapsed bridge section in order to save it from falling.

A similar sequence from Ico can be used to visualise and understand the sequence described above:



A video demonstrating the bridge sequence from Ico

Puzzle Design:

Cube State 2 Environment Puzzle:

Before the player can upgrade to the cube to its third and final state they must first solve the state 2 puzzle. This puzzle requires players to augment/alter the environment via an elevator found in the centre of the puzzle environment. Players must find a way to move this elevator to the second floor, enabling them to grab onto the rope attached to the underneath of the elevator and abseil down to the state 3 upgrade. Players can accomplish this by pulling a lever on the second floor, moving the elevator upwards and then using a now accessible side room to return back to floor 1.

However, in order to reach the second floor players will need to solve a weight based seesaw puzzle. Players will need to find and move three cubes from various places in the environment onto the seesaw, this provides enough weight for the seesaw to create a ramp like structure thus enabling the player to access the second floor.

Cube State 3 Weight Based Scales Puzzle:

This level should be one of the first levels the player can access after receiving the state 3 cube upgrade. It should test the player skills and poise a challenge due to it taking place late in the game but should introduce them to new mechanics as it is one of the introduction levels to the state 3 cube. The player will be tested in a small enclosed building which will contrast from the wide open hub and prior state 1 and 2 levels. The player will face multiple discrete and

continuous puzzles in a short span of time, broken up by set pieces to challenge the player while rewarding them with a changing environment to showcase the progress they have made solving each part of the puzzle to unlock a path to progress.

The player will enter the top floor of the pantheon building and walk to statue in the middle of the room holding up 2 weight scales. The floor of the building is surrounded by spikes instantly killing the player if they fall and touch the floor. The player must push the cube onto the first scale which will then drop down due to the weight of the player, rope and cube. They must then climb onto the cube, and jump over to the second scale, the rope and player weight on will balance out the two scales making them both at the same height, which is the right height for the player to hit the switch to unlock the door below. After opening the door, the player must swing off a rope down to the newly opened doorway which features a new switch to raise a bridge across to the exit of the building. The player must then reel the cube in and carry it across the bridge and leave the building.

This Level has been altered due to changes to mechanics and the new updated version is explained in the section below

Cube State 3 Crumbling Platform Statue Puzzle:

This level should be one of the first levels the player can access after receiving the state 3 cube upgrade. It should test the player skills and poise a challenge due to it taking place late in the game but should introduce them to new mechanics as it is one of the introduction levels to the state 3 cube. The player will be tested in a small enclosed building which will contrast from the wide open hub and prior state 1 and 2 levels. The player will face multiple discrete and continuous puzzles in a short span of time, broken up by set pieces to challenge the player while rewarding them with a changing environment to showcase the progress they have made solving each part of the puzzle to unlock a path to progress.

The player will re-enter the hub with the newly gained state 3 cube, they will then have access to this level which starts at a bridge, the bridge features a crumbling section which the player must quickly run over otherwise they risk falling to their death if they are too slow. This reminds the player of the crumbling floor mechanic in a low risk area as it's right next to the hub and a rest point so the consequence for death is a small amount of time. It also prepares them for the upcoming puzzle which features the crumbling floor.

After the bridge section they enter the pantheon building on the top floor where there is a statue in the middle of the room that is holding up two crumbling floor platforms. The player must quickly jump across the platforms and hit the switch on the statue to unlock the door on the ground floor on the left of the statue. The player can then jump off the platform as it crumbles,

and aim to land in the newly opened hallway. Here is a switch which, when pressed, knocks the statue over breaking it in half and giving the player platforms to jump across to reach the newly opened exit which broke open as the top of the statue hit the door wide open. The player must parkour over the broken statue to reach the exit of the pantheon building.

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

In order to design the gameplay demo levels we split the environment into 4 different sequences or scenes with these 4 scenes being the: intro and bridge, hub room, state 2 puzzle room and state 3 puzzle room. We then designed each scene individually and connect them together in a jigsaw like fashion. This enabled us to design demo levels faster and with a more structured approach. Due to this the following section will be split into each scene, covering the level layouts and blockouts of each scene individually:

The overall gameplay demo level layout can be found by downloading the file here: [Demo Level Layouts.drawio](#) and opening it via the [Draw.io](#) website.

The universal keys found below can be used to identify game elements in both the level layouts and blockout images

Level Layout Key:

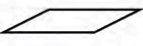
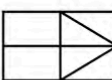
Demo Level Key:					
	Floor 1		Seesaw		Rest Point
	Floor 2		Interactable crate		Stairs
	Floor 3		Rope		State 3 upgrade
	Floor 4		Climbable wall		
	Switch/Lever				

Image of the key used within the level layout drawings

Blockout Key:

Orange - Breakable objects

Blue - interactable object such as a door, elevator or lever

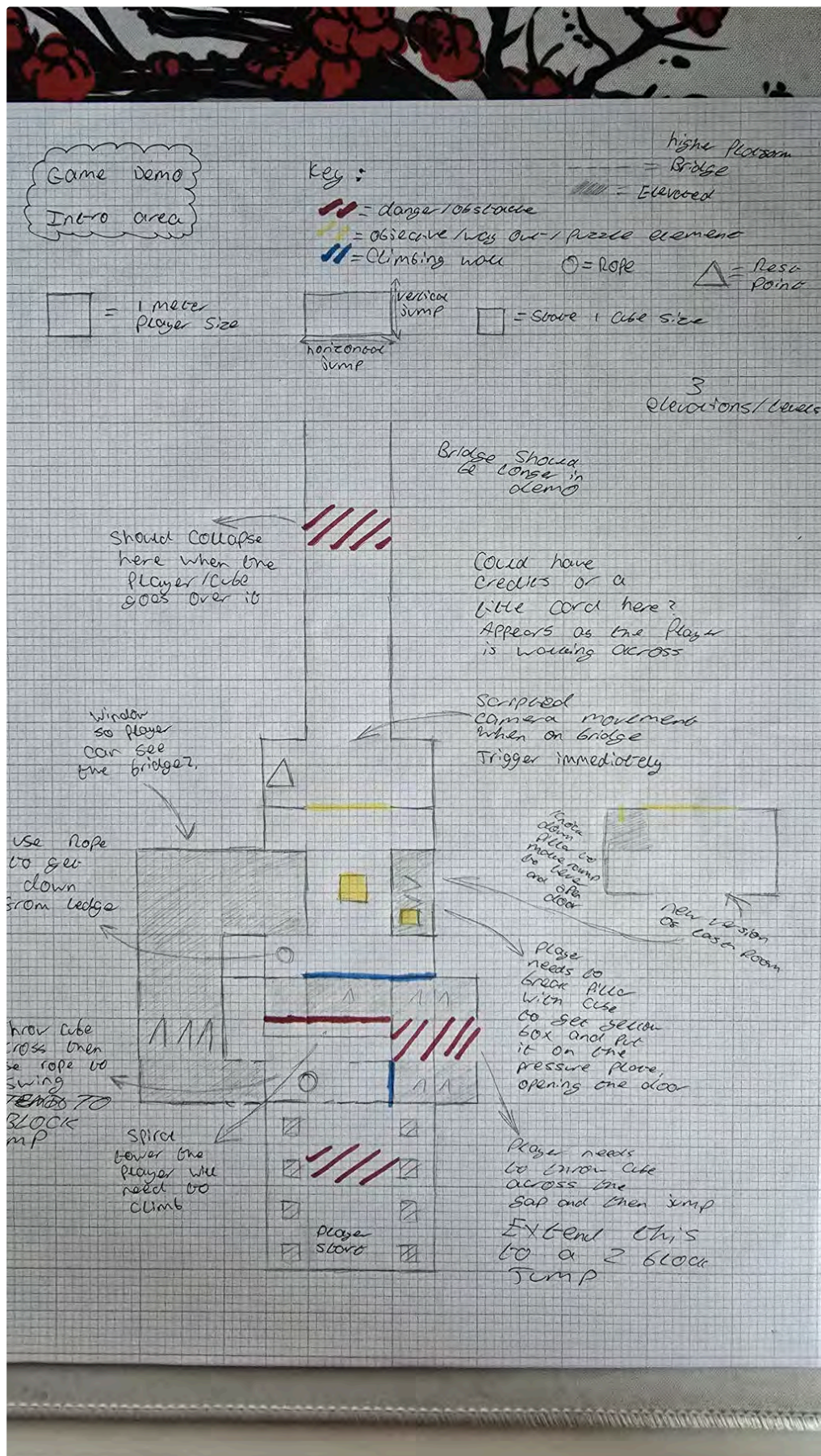
Purple - Climbable surface/wall

Triangles - Rest points

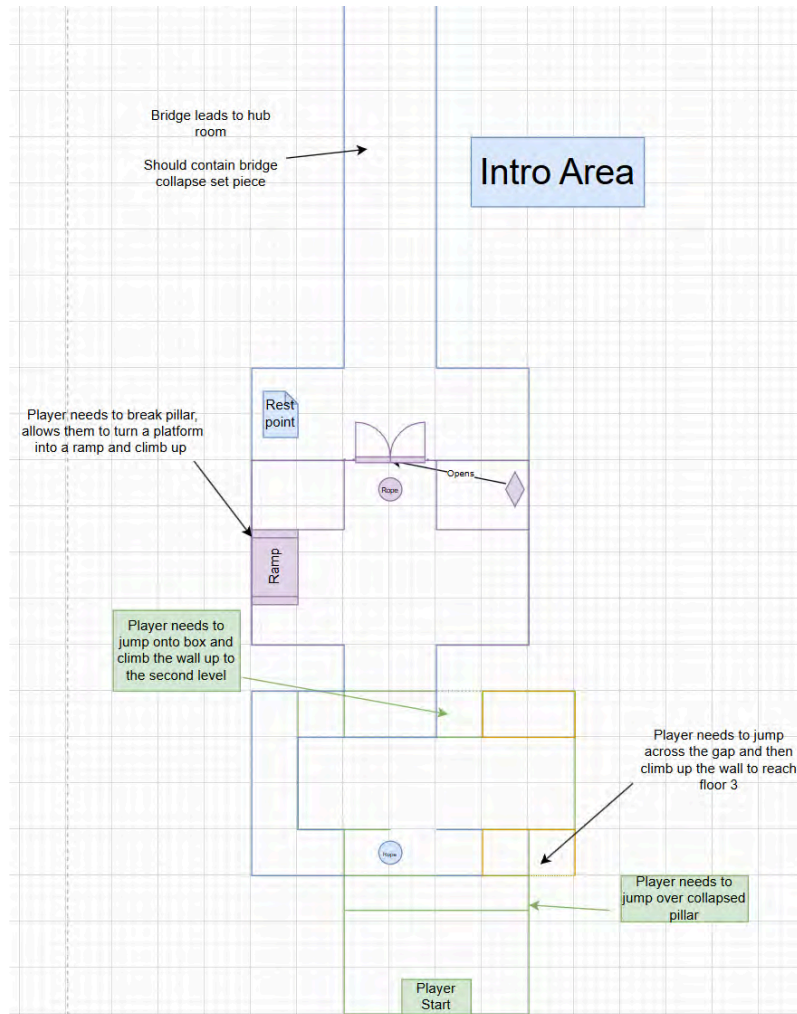
Intro Level Layout and Blockout Images:

All level layout images for the intro scene can be found by expanding the drop down below or via opening the [draw.io](#) file found in the previous section:

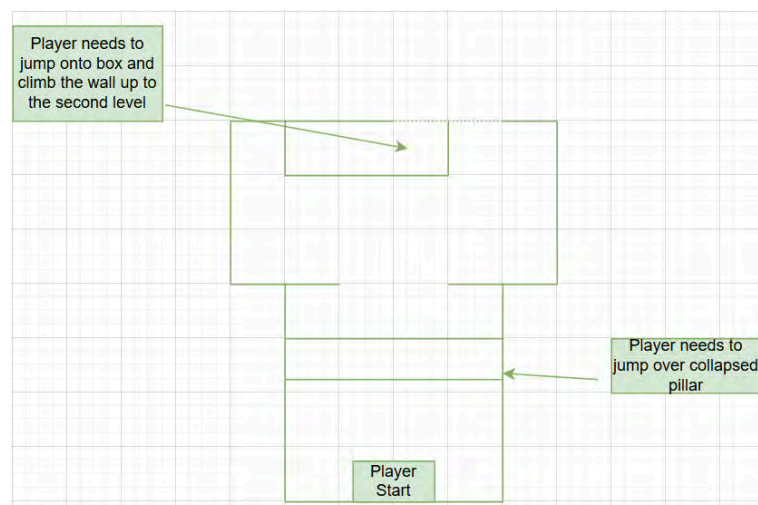
✓ Intro Area Level Layout Images



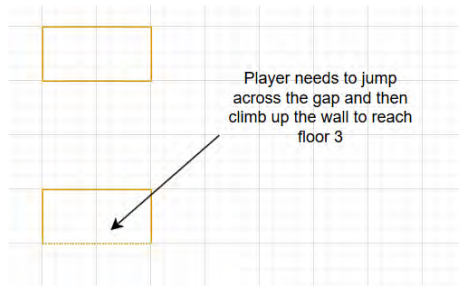
Initial paper layout of the intro area



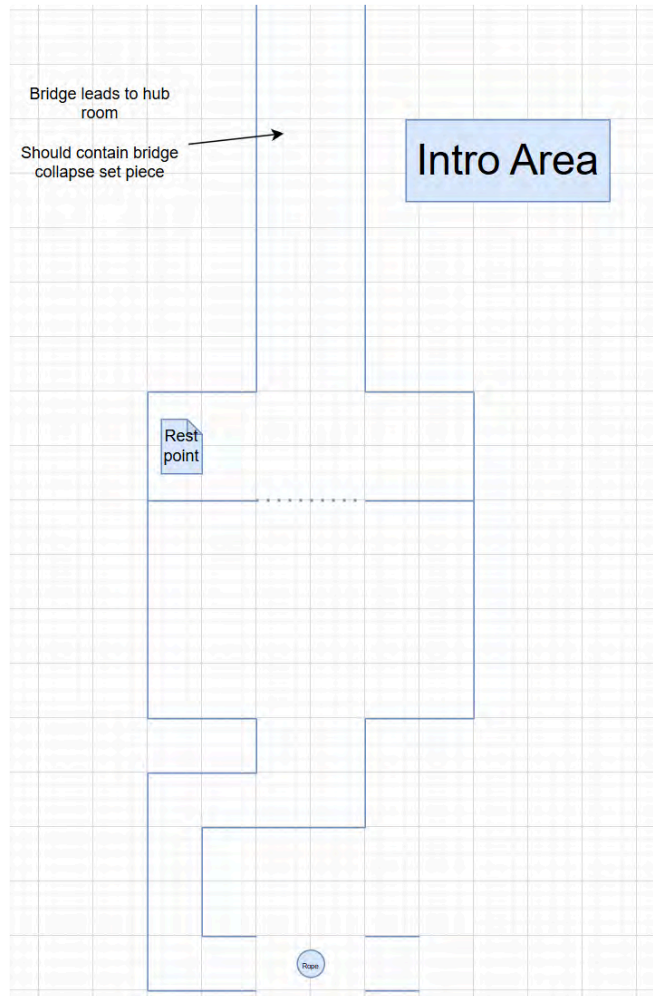
Overall Intro level layout image



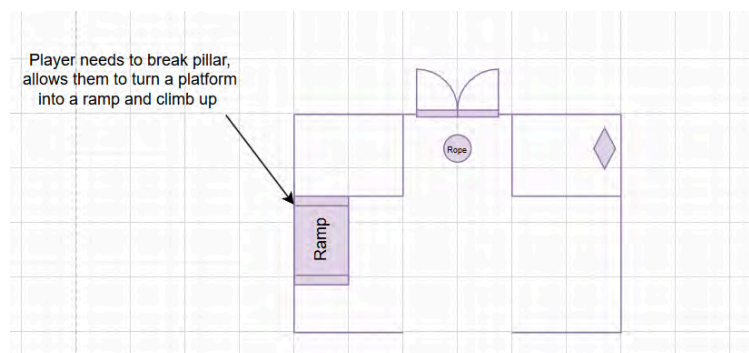
Floor 1 of intro level layout



Floor 2 of intro level layout



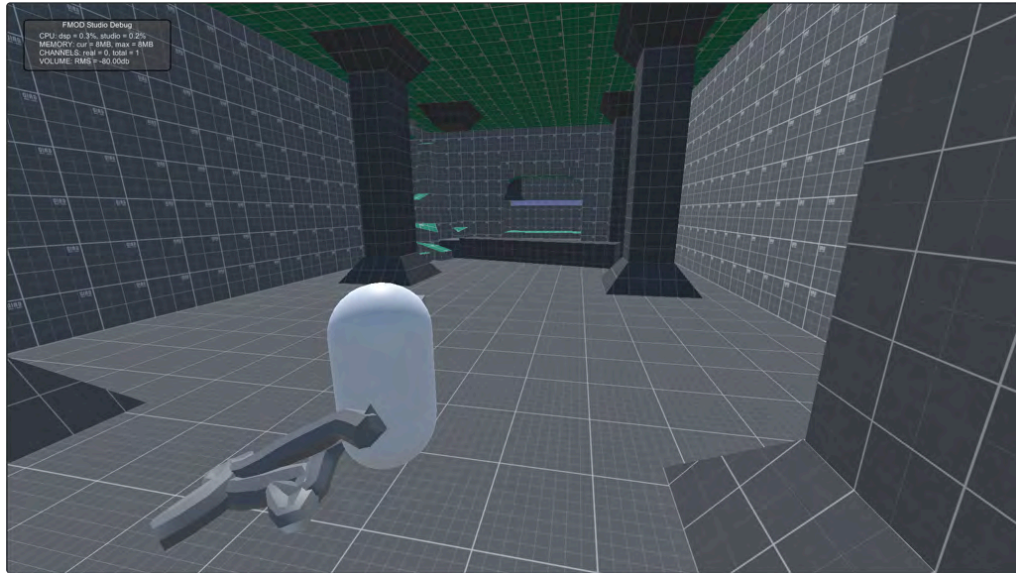
Floor 3 of intro level layout



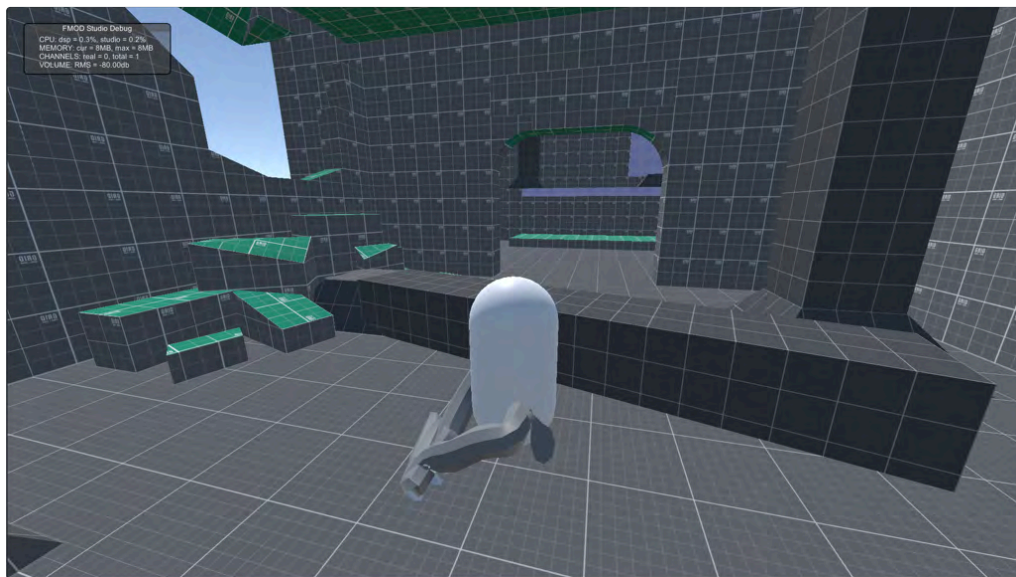
Floor 4 of intro level layout

All blackout images for the intro environment can be found below by expanding the drop down box

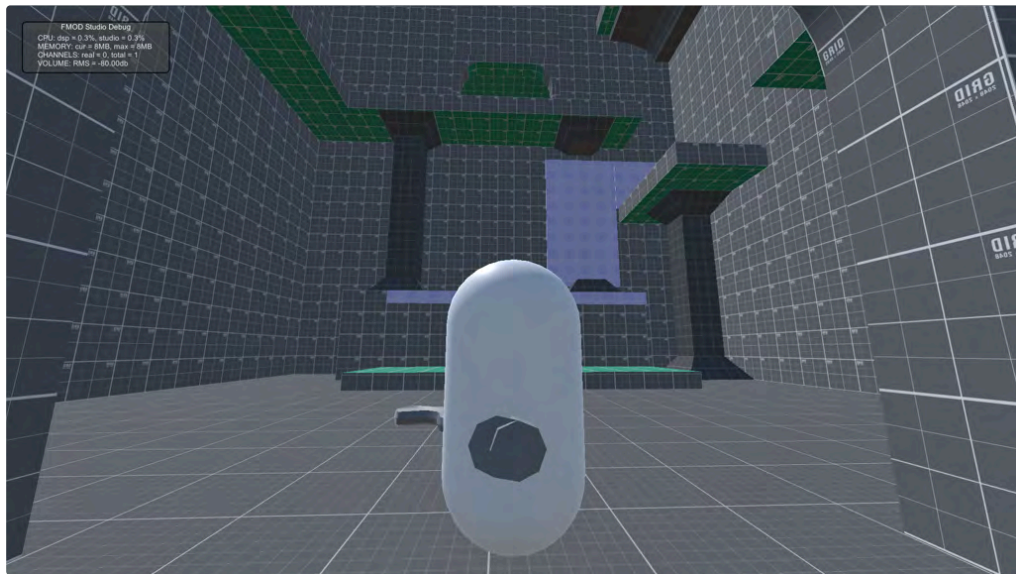
▼ Intro Area Blockout Images



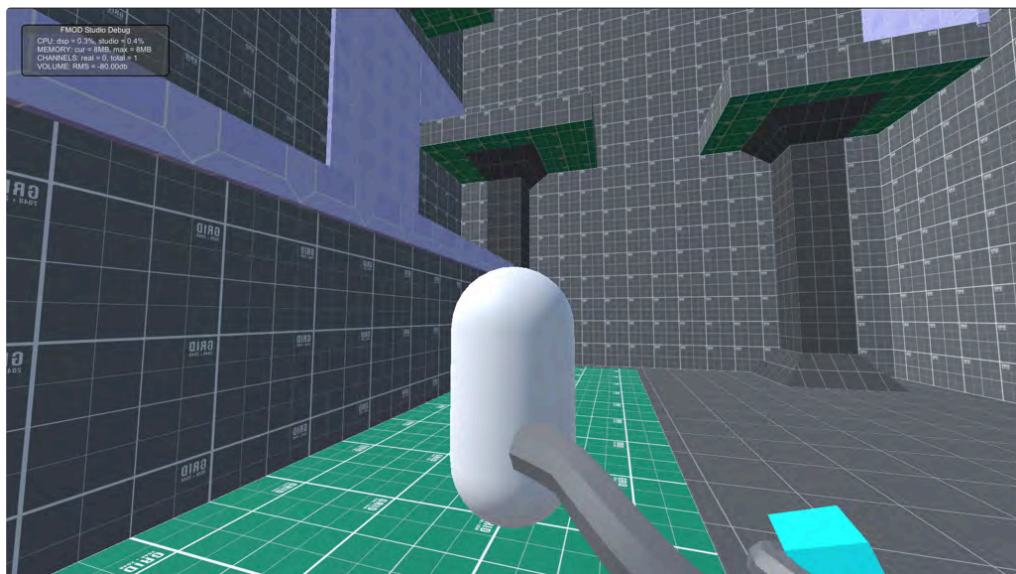
Player start room blockout



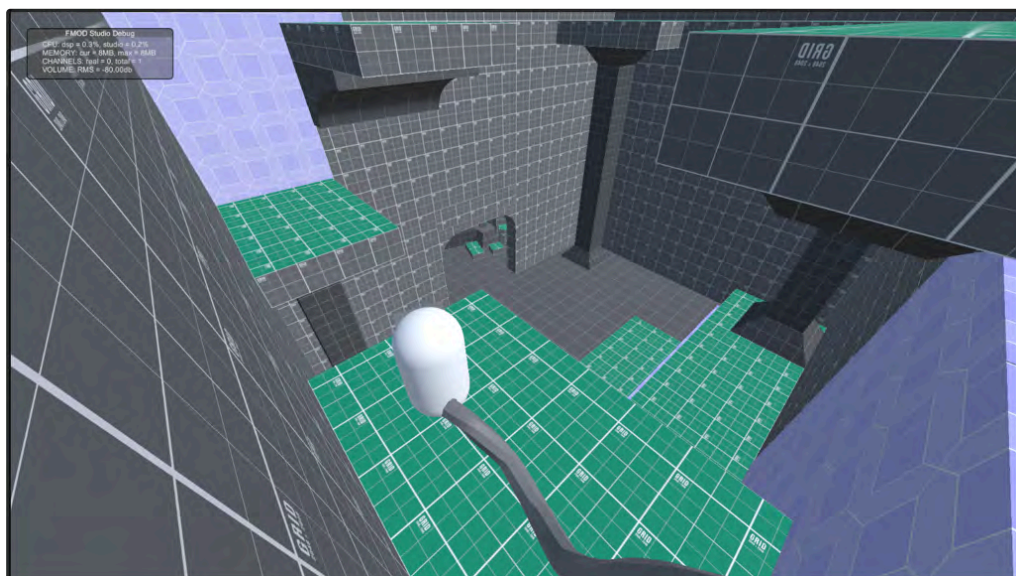
Pillar obstacle found in player start room blockout



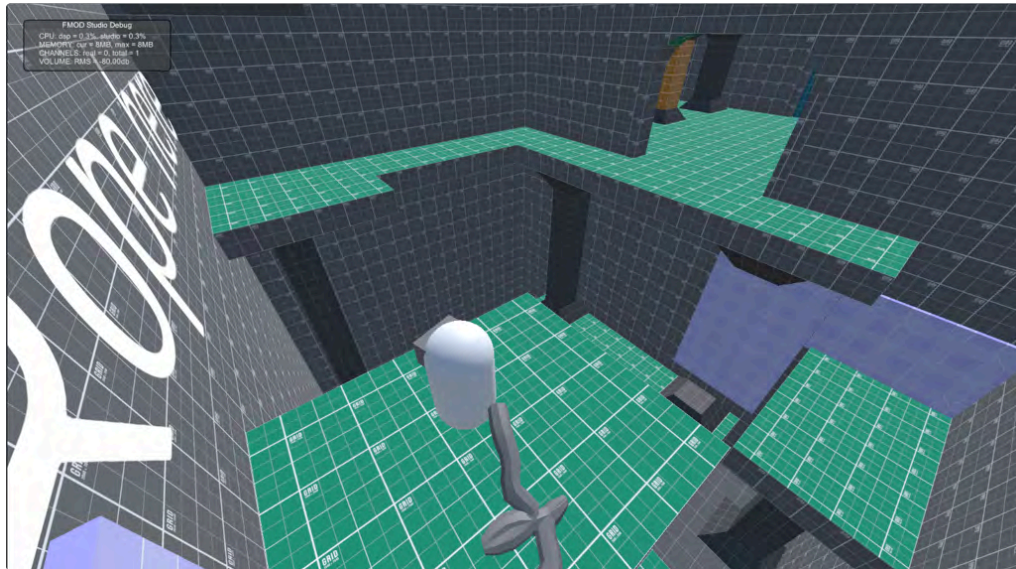
Second room intro level blackout



Second room intro level blackout



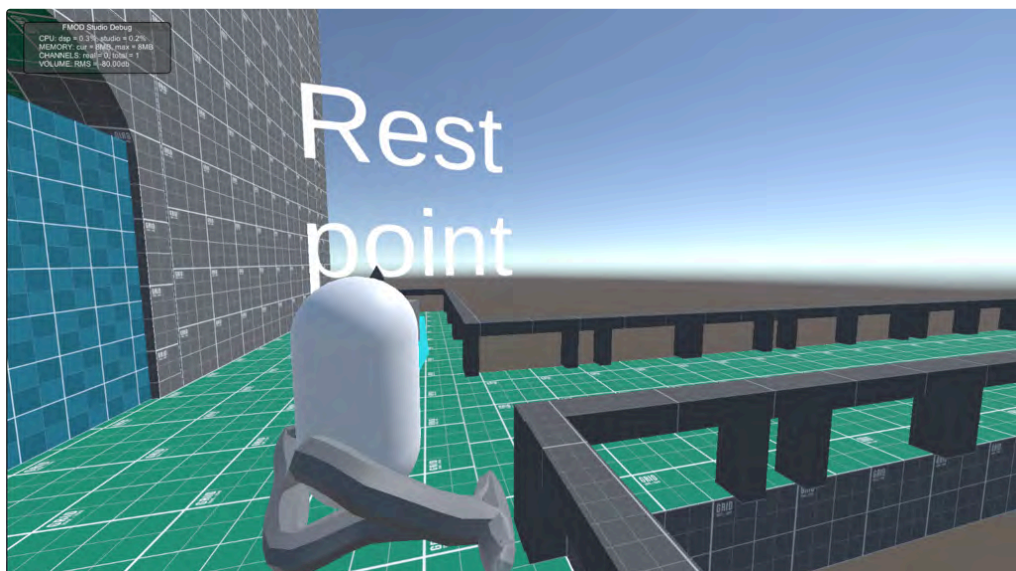
Player on the second floor of the second intro room



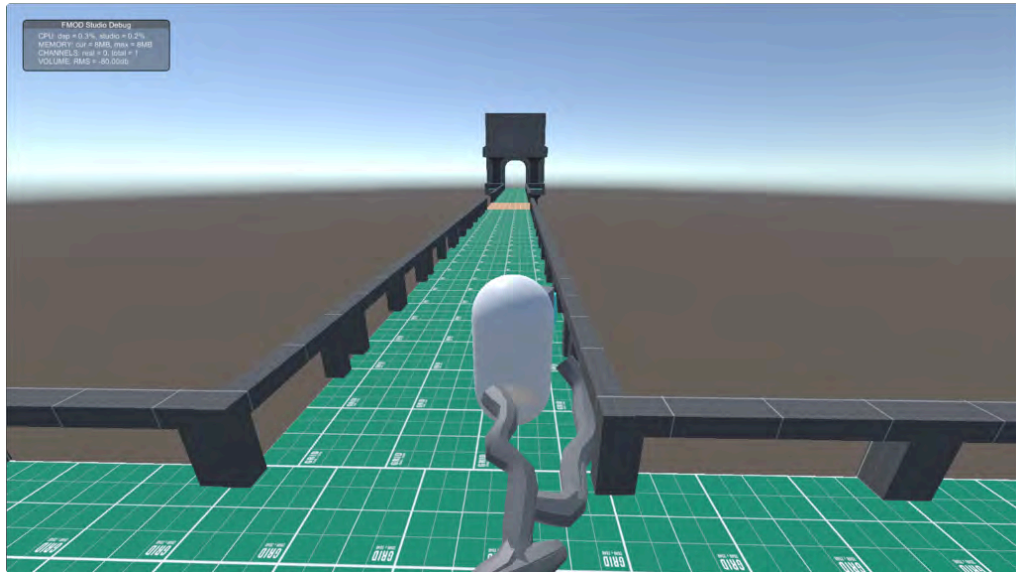
Player on the third floor of the second intro room



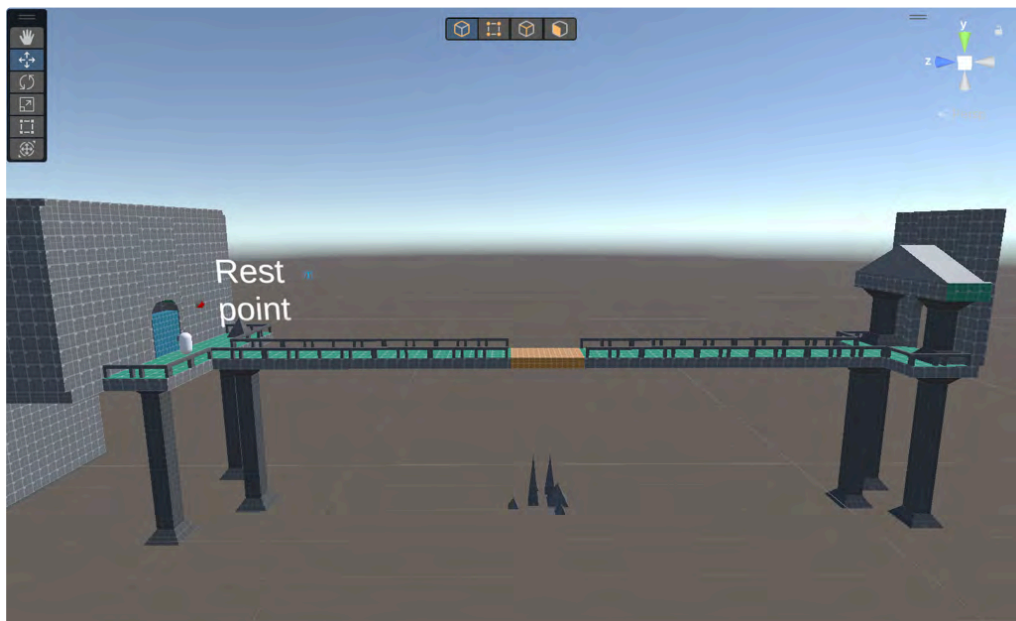
Player in intro level puzzle room



Rest point found before the bridge in the intro level



Intro level bridge blackout

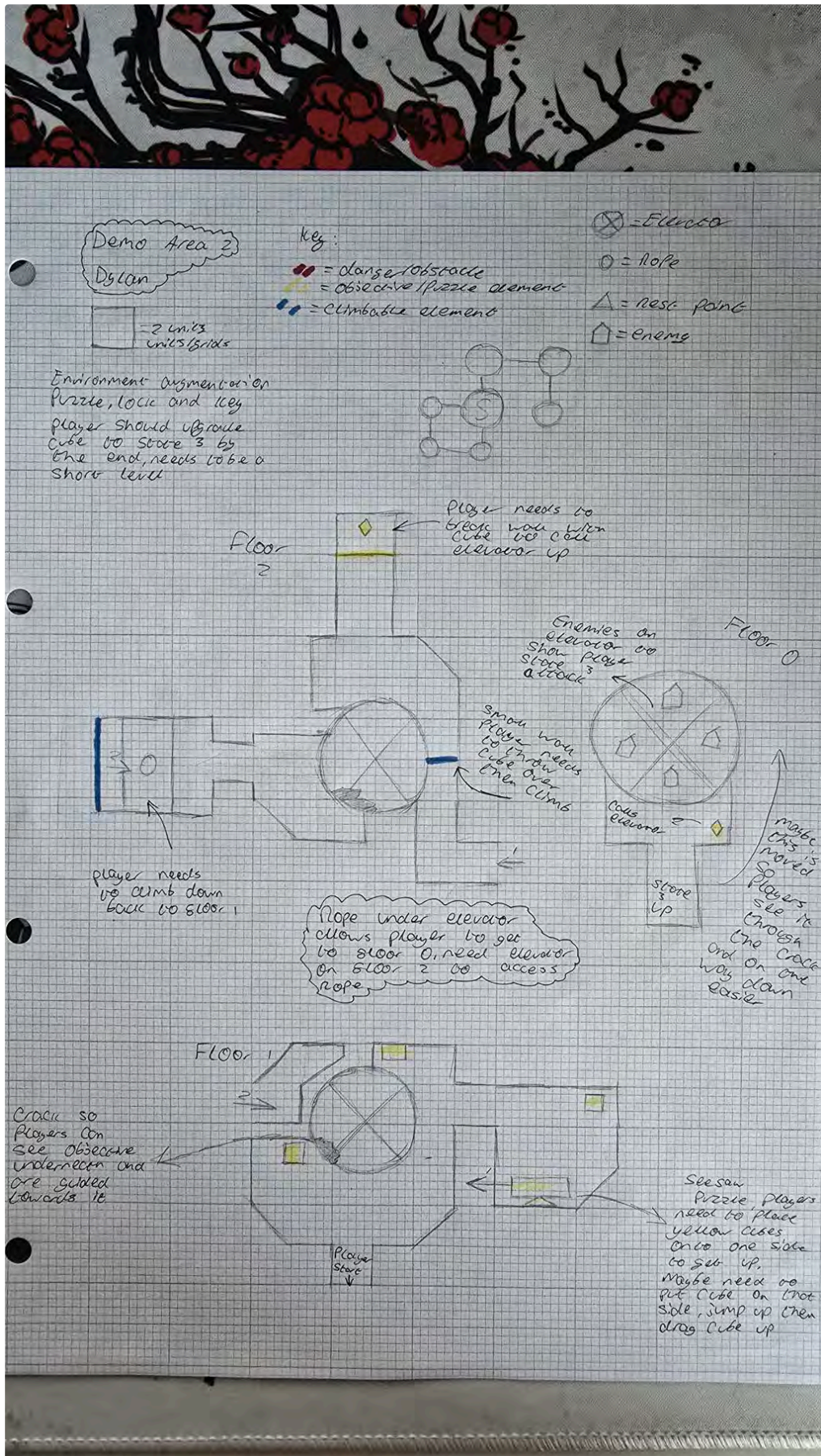


Intro level bridge blackout shown in editor view

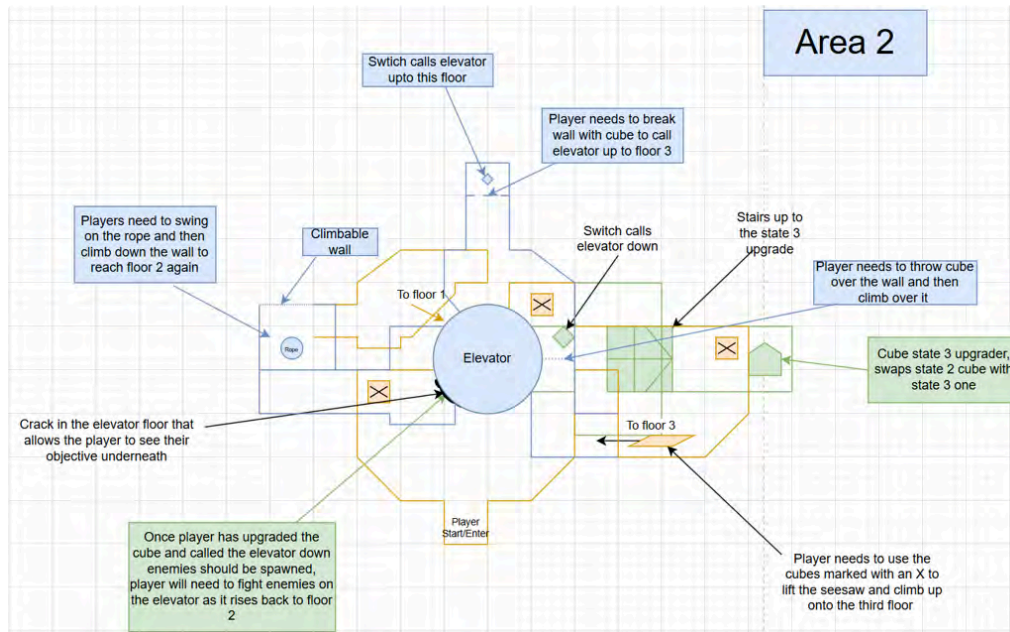
State 2 Puzzle Room Level Layout and Blockout Images:

All level layout images for the intro scene can be found by expanding the drop down below or via opening the draw.io file found in the previous section:

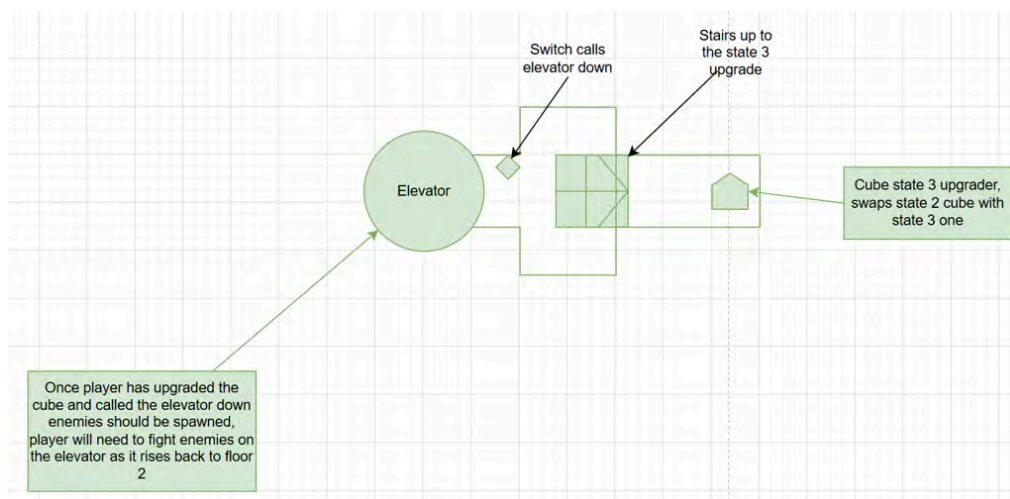
- State 2 Puzzle Room Level Layout Images



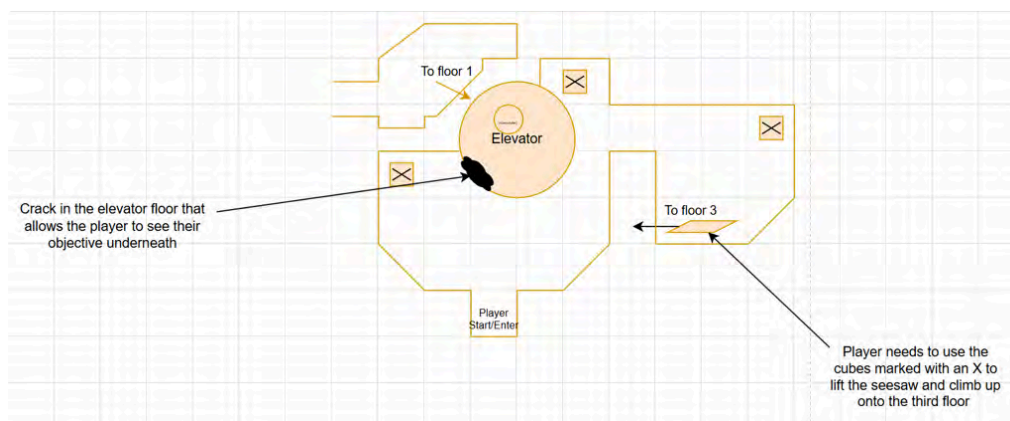
Initial paper layout of area 2



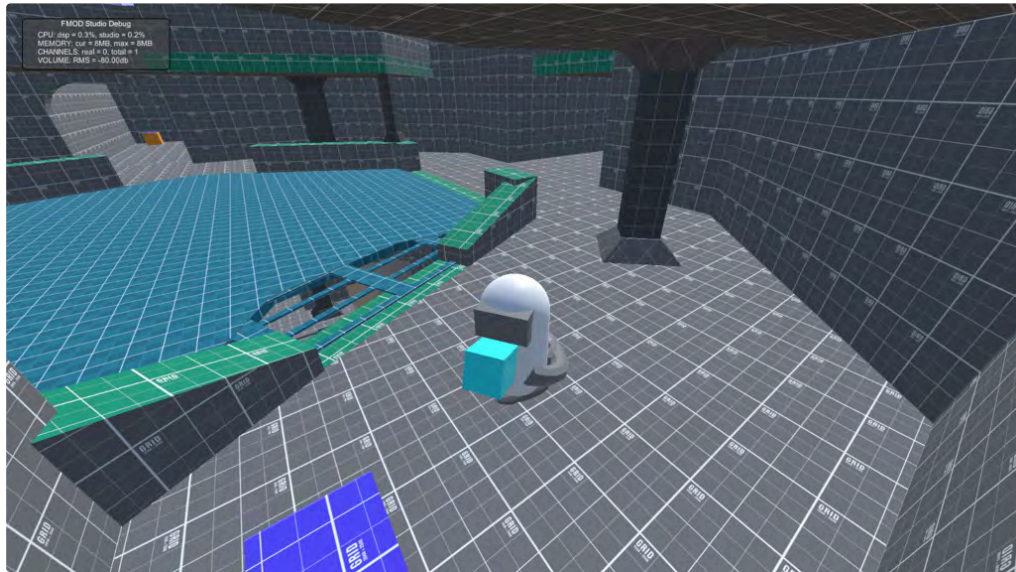
Overall state 2 puzzle room level layout



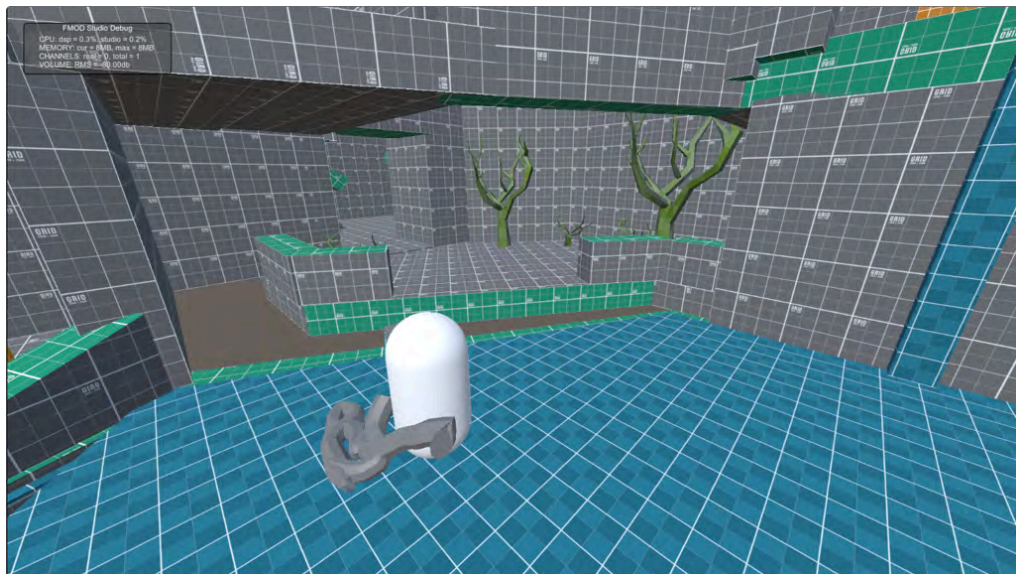
Floor 1 of state 2 puzzle room level layout



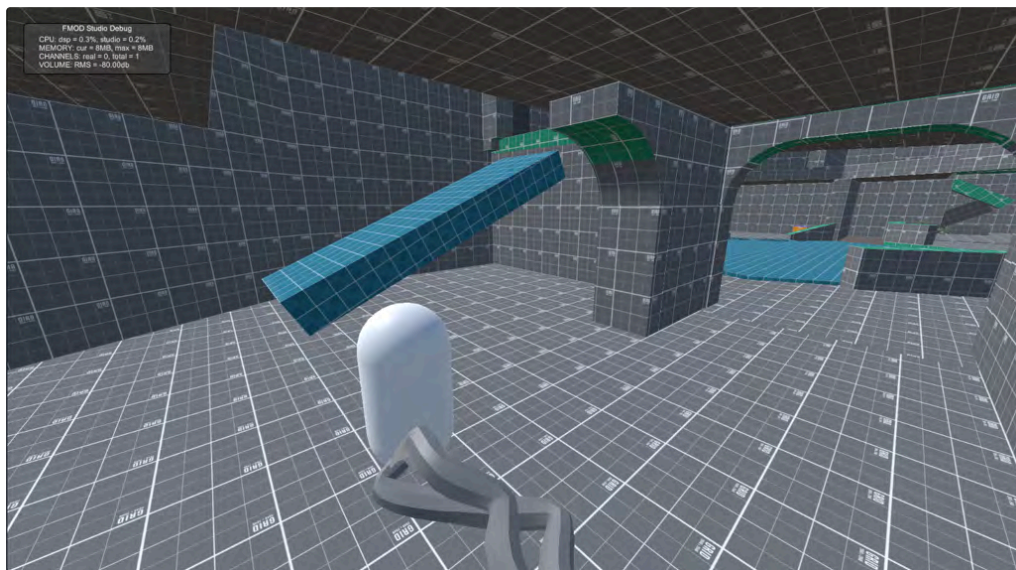
Floor 2 of state 2 puzzle room level layout



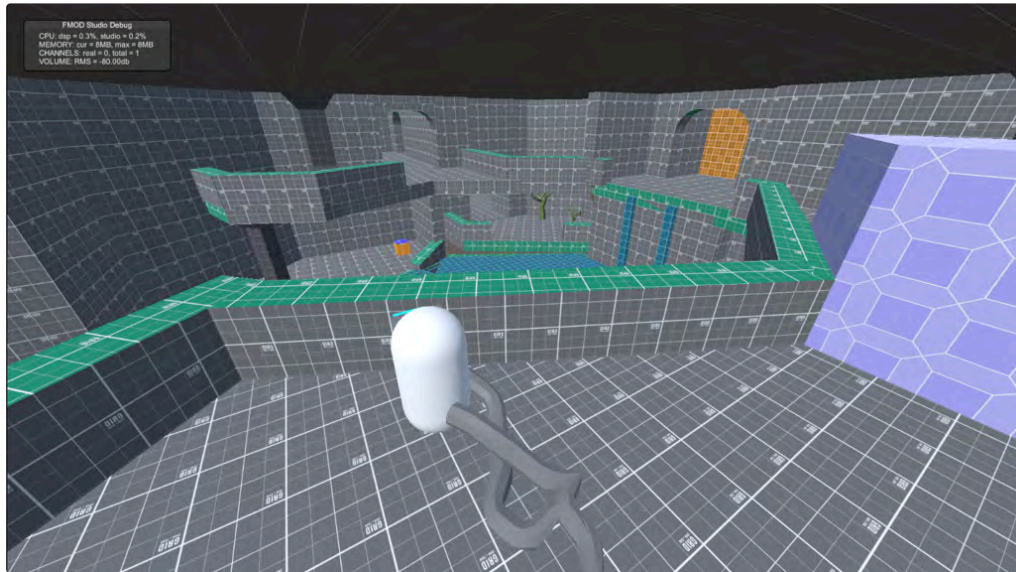
Player at one of the interactable cubes and hole in elevator



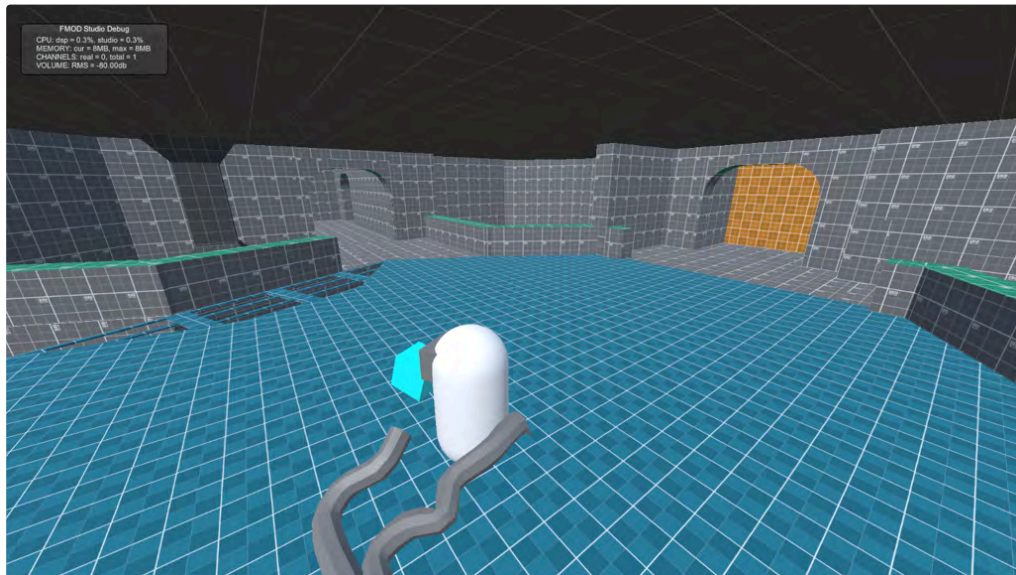
Player in front of garden and access to elevator rope area



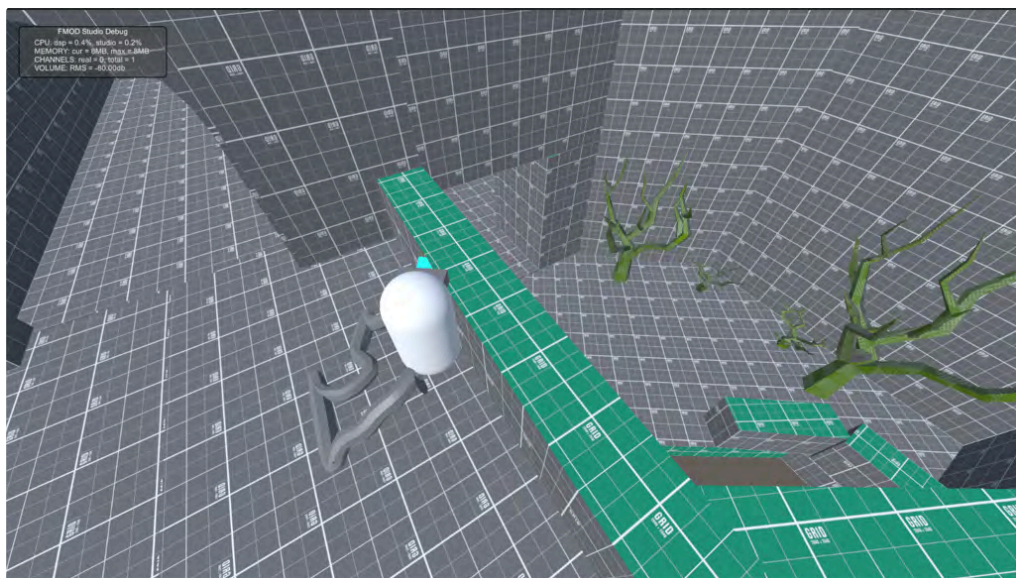
Player in seesaw puzzle room



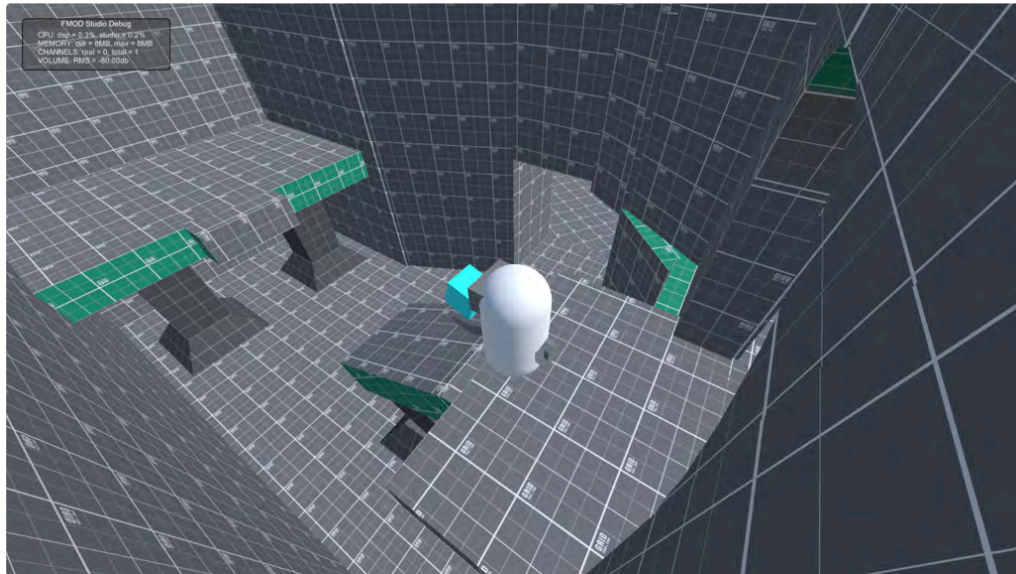
Player on third floor of the state 2 puzzle room blackout



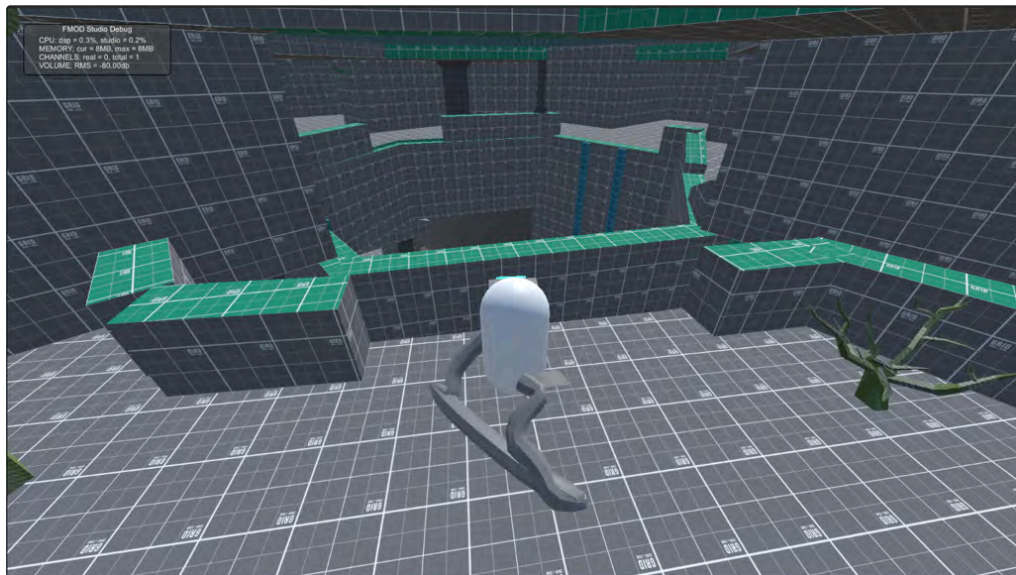
Player on elevator after it has been called to the third floor



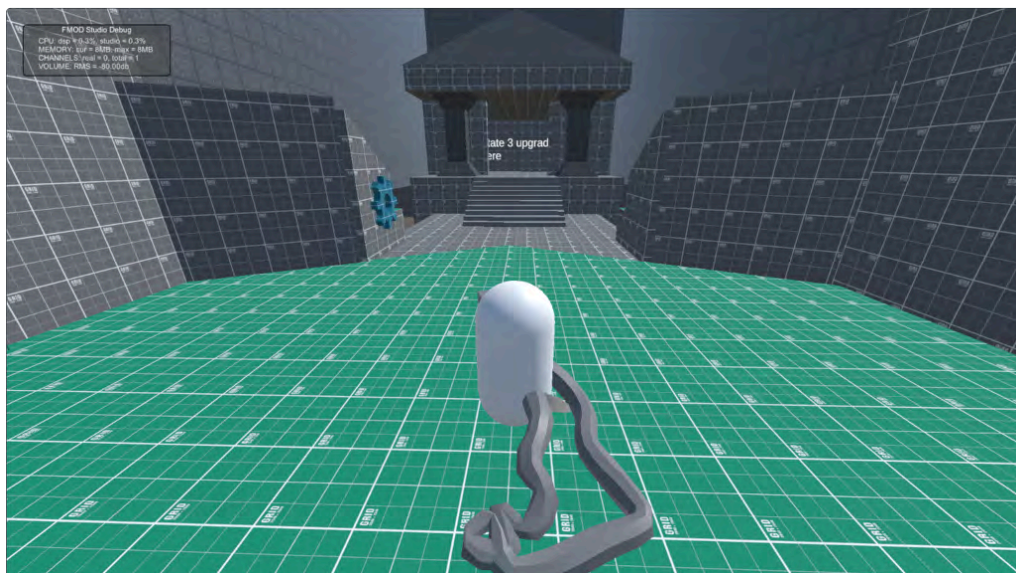
Player above the garden area



Player in the drop down/loop area linking the garden area and the third floor together



Player in the garden area before jumping down the elevator shaft

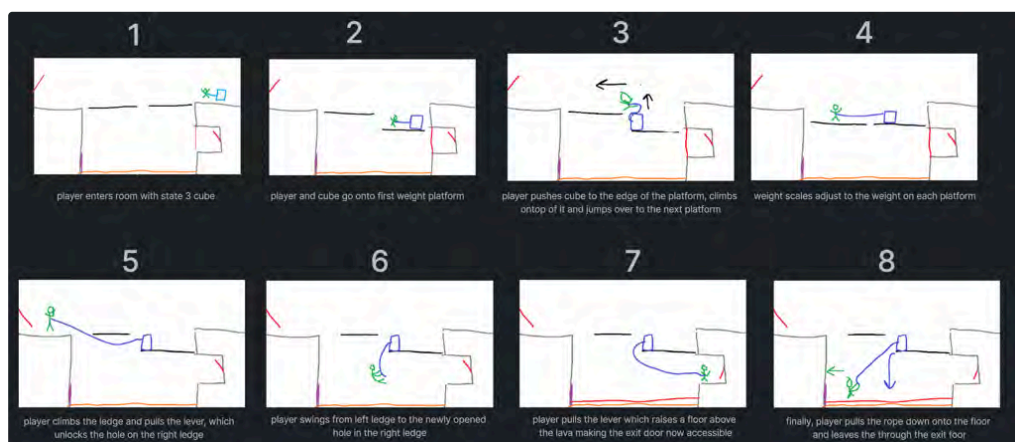


Player after jumping down into the elevator shaft and standing before the state 3 upgrade room

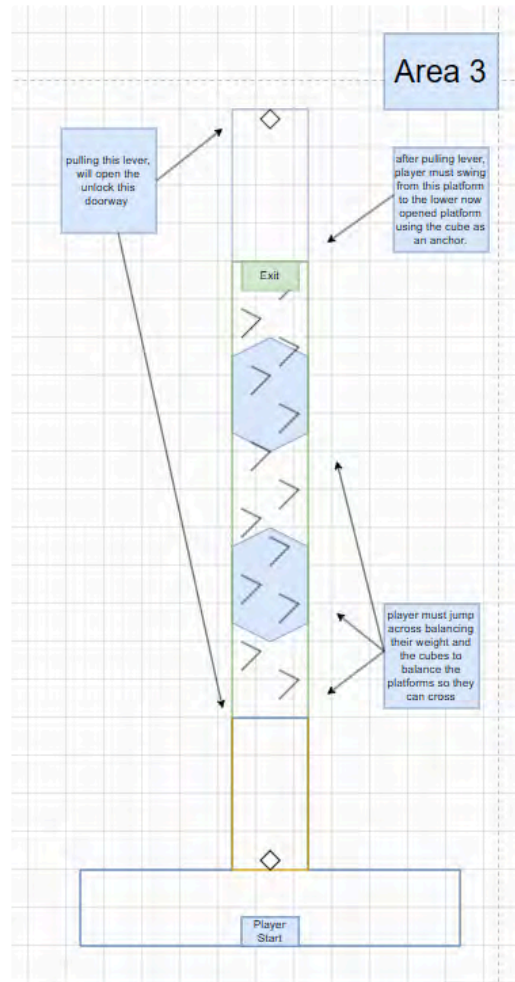
State 3 Puzzle Room Level Layout and Blockout Images:

All level layout images for the level 3 scene can be found by expanding the drop down below or via opening the [Flowchart Maker & Online Diagram Software](#) file found in the previous section:

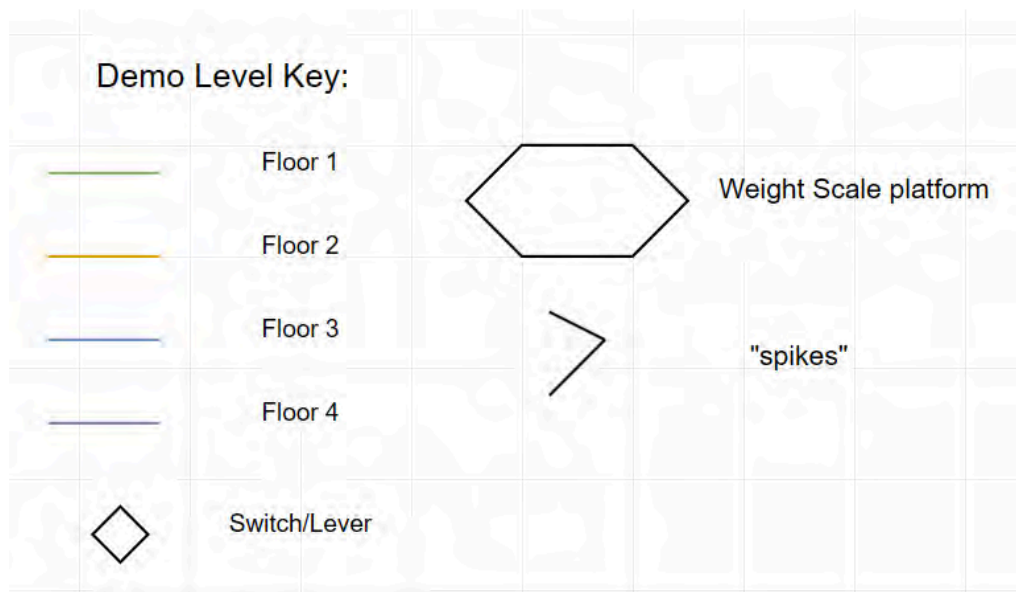
✓ Level 3 Layout Pictures:



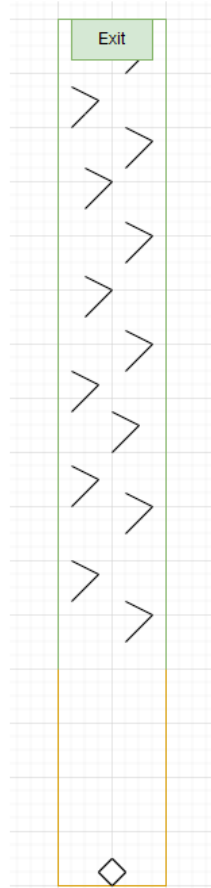
paper prototype of state 3 level



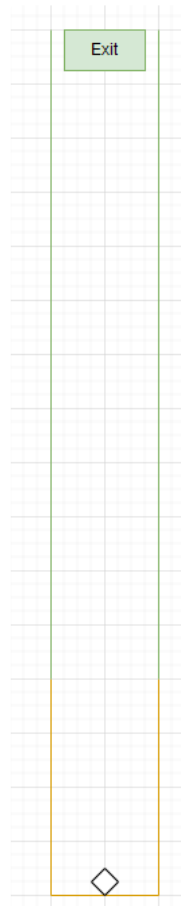
Original iteration of level 3 layout (cube state 3 level) (Floors 1, 2 & 3)



Demo level Key



Level 3 (floors 1 & 2)



Level 3 (after
bridge raised to
block spikes -
only level 1
showing)

All blackout images for the level 3 environment can be found below by expanding the drop down box

✓ Level 3 Blockout Images

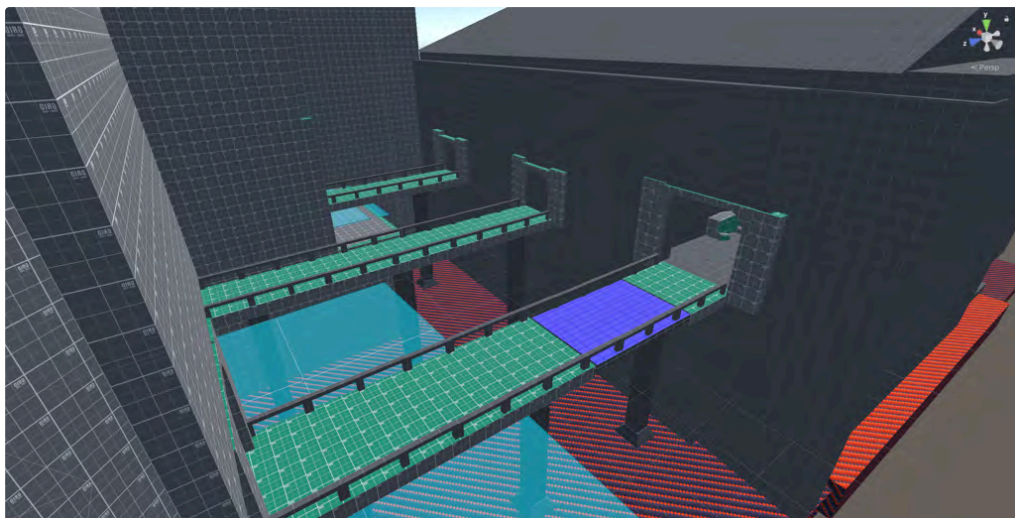


Image showing how level 3 connects to the hub room via a bridge

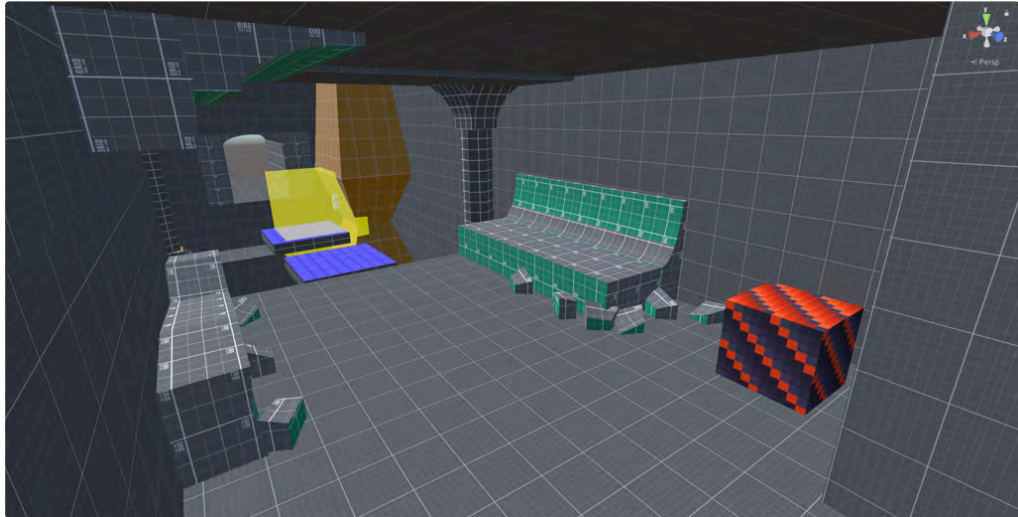


Image showing the first room of level 3



Image showing all of level 3 from one end of the hall

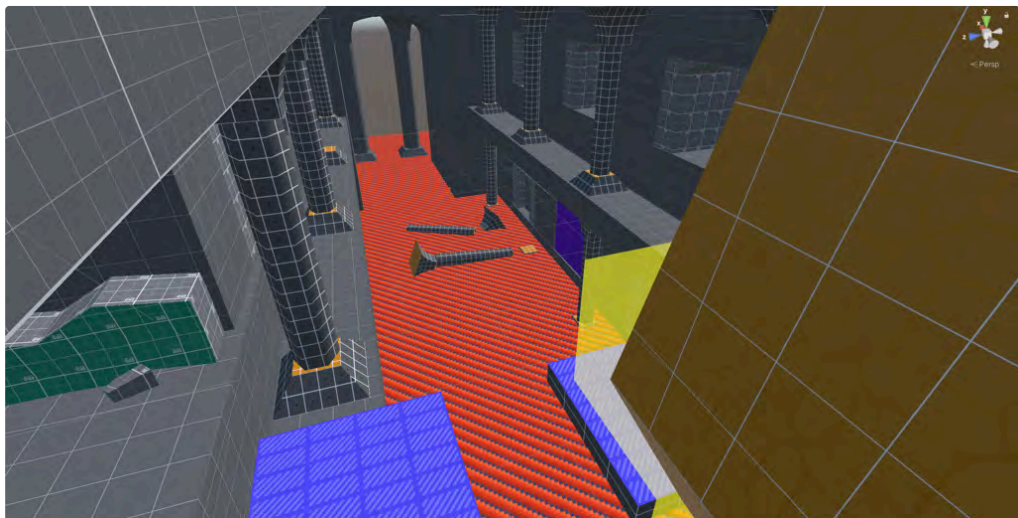


Image showing all of level 3 from the statue

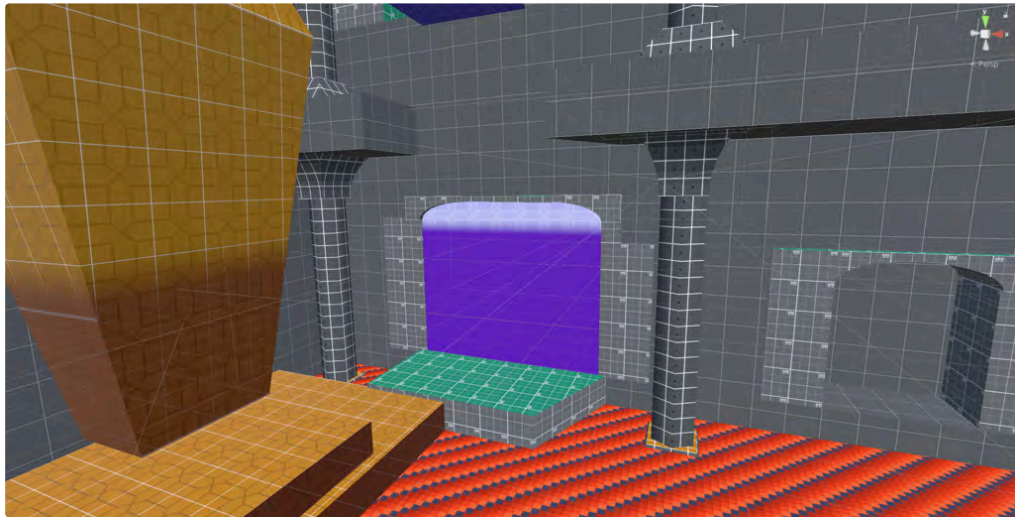


Image showing the players first objective

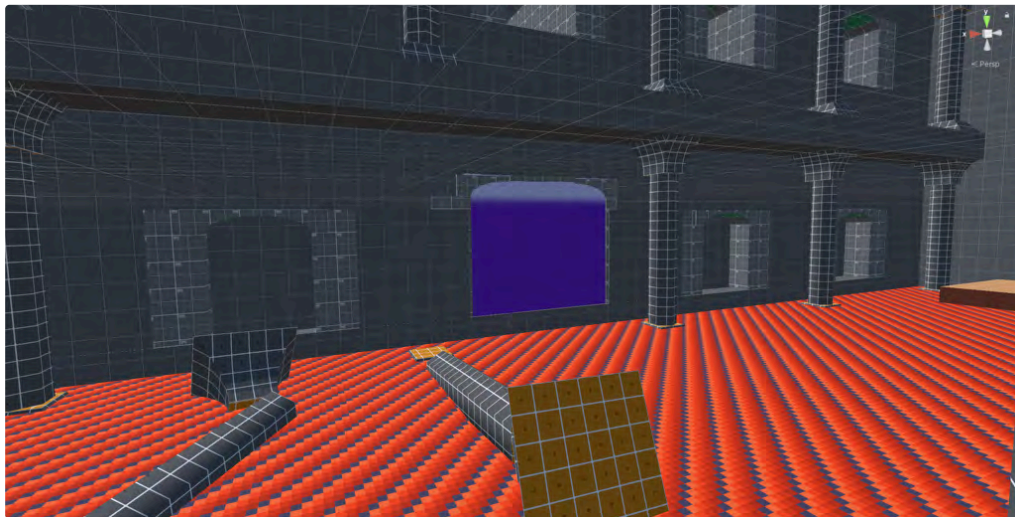


Image showing the players second objective

Hub Room Level Layout and Blockout Images:

All level layout images for the hub room scene can be found by expanding the drop down below or via opening the [Flowchart Maker & Online Diagram Software](#) file found in the previous section:

▼ Hub Room Layout Images:

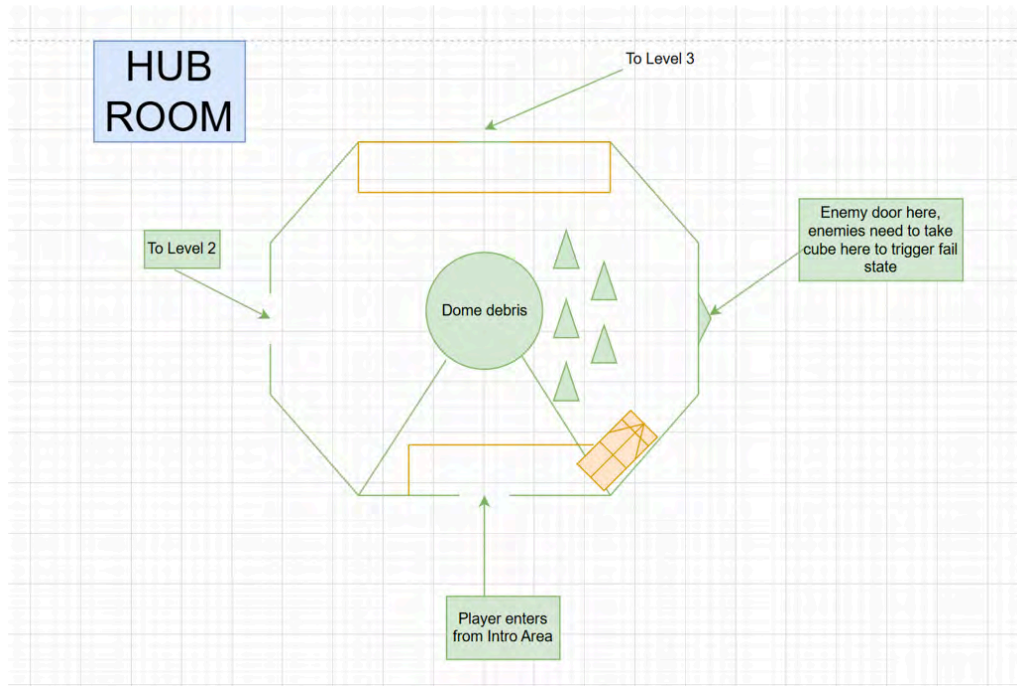


Image showing the entire hub room layout

All blockout images for the hub room environment can be found below by expanding the drop down box

✓ Hub Room Blockout Images:

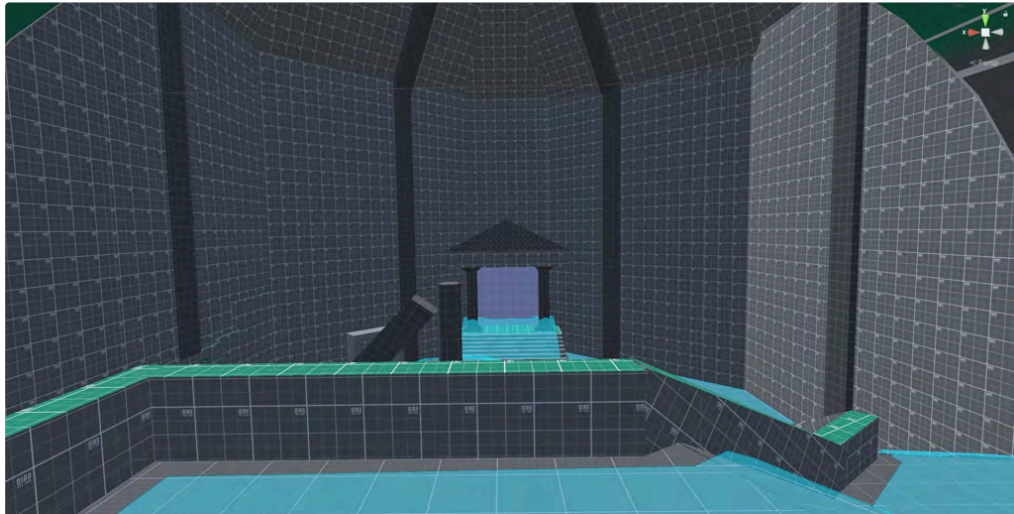


Image of the hub room entrance

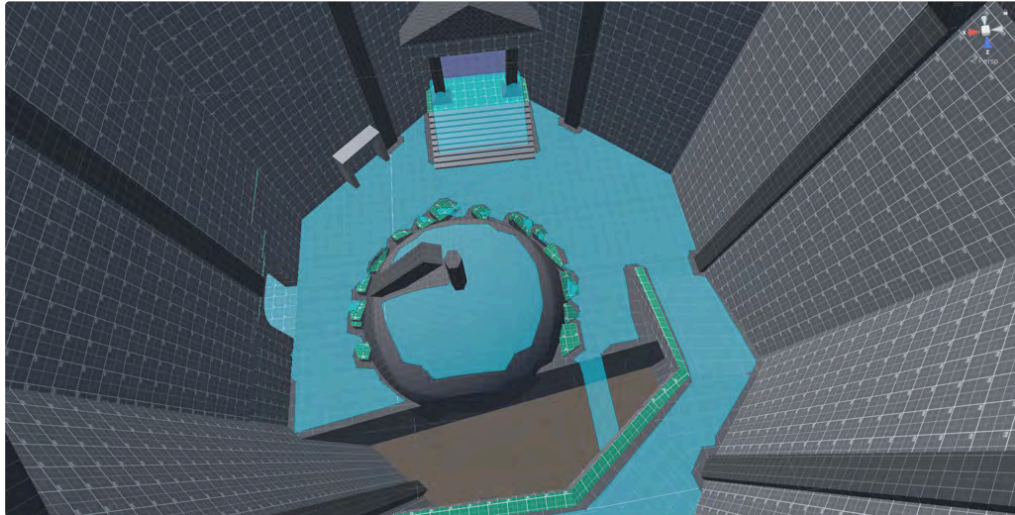


Image of the hub room blackout from above

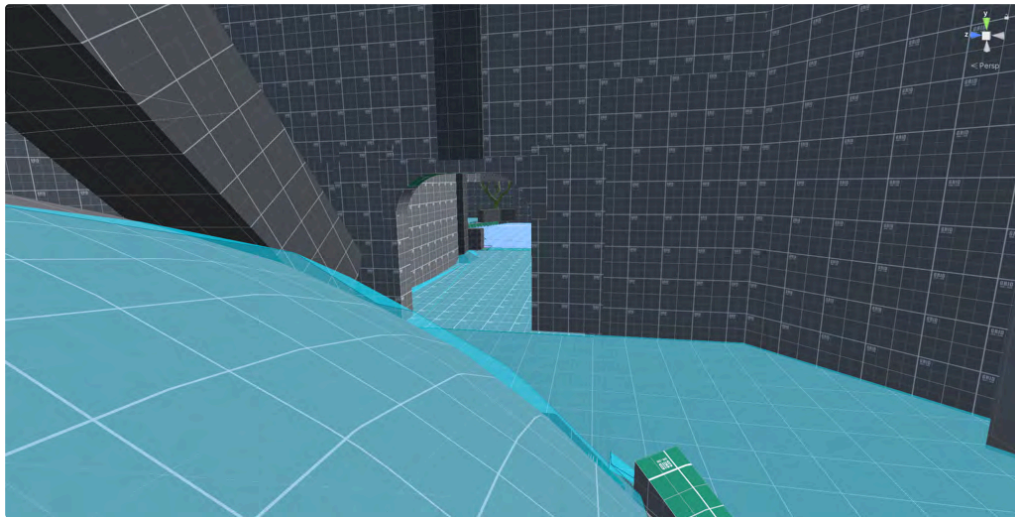


Image of the entrance to level 2 from the hub room

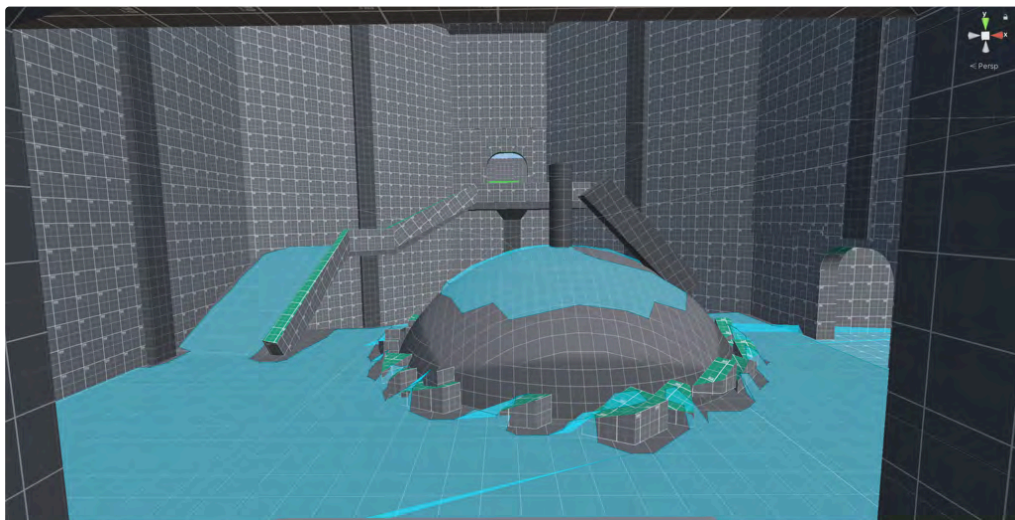


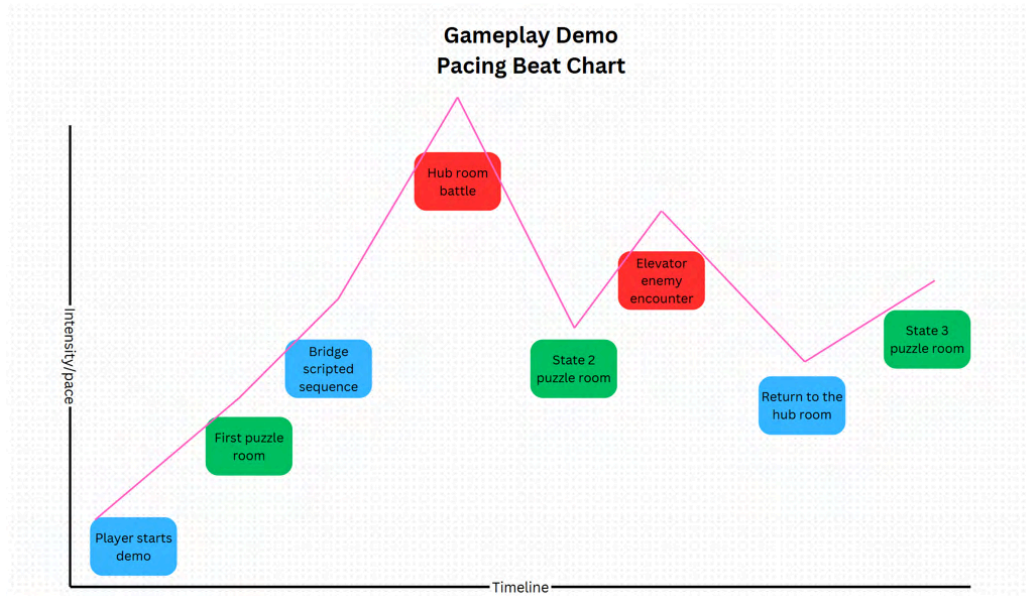
Image of the hub room from the locked door

Pacing:

Green - puzzle solving sequence

Red - combat sequence

Blue - environment exploration sequence



Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Due to [Don't] Let Go being a mostly hyper linear experience we use valves extensively throughout the gameplay demo to block and prevent the player from backtracking through environments or levels they have already completed or interacted with fully. The variety of methods and instances we do this in can be viewed below:

The Bridge:

As mentioned previously in the document, the player will need to cross a bridge early on in the gameplay demo. Whilst crossing the bridge we trigger a collapsing scripted set piece in which the middle point of the bridge collapses under the players feet. The bridge collapsing allows us to prevent players from backtracking to the intro environment thus preventing any confusion or navigational difficulty.

Hard Gates:

Hard gates are gameplay elements or mechanics that block the players progress completely until a certain condition is met. Due to [Don't] Let Go's focus on puzzle gameplay we also use

hard gates extensively throughout the gameplay demo which will be expanded on in the section below:

Bridge Access Door:

Before the player can access the bridge they will first need to get past a hard gate in the form of a normal door. The player must find the activation switch by solving the puzzle. Activating this switch enables the player to open the door and thus gain access to the bridge and continue progressing through the experience.

The Elevator:

During the state 2 puzzle the elevator acts as a major hard gate, preventing the player from accessing the ground floor and the state 3 upgrade. In order to get around this hard gate the player must activate the elevator using a switch found on floor 3. This moves the elevator upwards and allows the player to access the ground floor via jumping down the now openly accessible elevator shaft.

Statue puzzle room:

Inside the statue puzzle room, the player needs to get from one side to the other in order to leave and progress, here they will encounter 2 hard gates in the forms of doors which require the player finding accompanying switches around the room and activate these to unlock these doors. The next hard gate comes from the floor killing the player when they touch it so they need to find a way from one side to the other while using the environment as platforms to protect them. The player must activate the switch inside the first locked room, will cause the statue to fall the the floor and break in half, giving the player a bridge to parkour over to safely reach the exit of the building.

Soft Gates:

Soft gates are game elements used to temporarily slow the player down for both pacing purposes and gameplay purposes. Much like valves and hard gates we use soft gates extensively throughout [Don't] Let Go to provide the player with small tests and pacing slow downs.

Continuous Puzzles:

The first way we embed soft gates into the gameplay demo level design is through the usage of our continuous puzzle type. These puzzles are short and usually involve the player climbing or breaking an object to get past and continue progressing. We do this throughout the gameplay demo level, requiring players to break down doors/barricades to reach elevator switches and

forcing them to climb over small walls and pull the cube up before they can reach a new area or objective.

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Throughout the gameplay demo we do not use a specific or major landmark to guide players towards their next objective. This is primarily due to the gameplay demo's short duration and heavily linear environments, players will not need a clear landmark since the level has been designed in a linear and scripted fashion.

Hub Room Guidance:

The main form of guidance and environmental navigation offered to players comes in the form of the hub room and the overall gameplay demo's hub and spoke level design structure. All levels/areas featured in the demo are connected to the central hub room. This aids the player in navigating the environment due to the hub rooms central nature and its evolving state. As the demo progresses the hub room will change and new areas will be unlocked, helping the player find the next path towards their objective and the end of the demo.

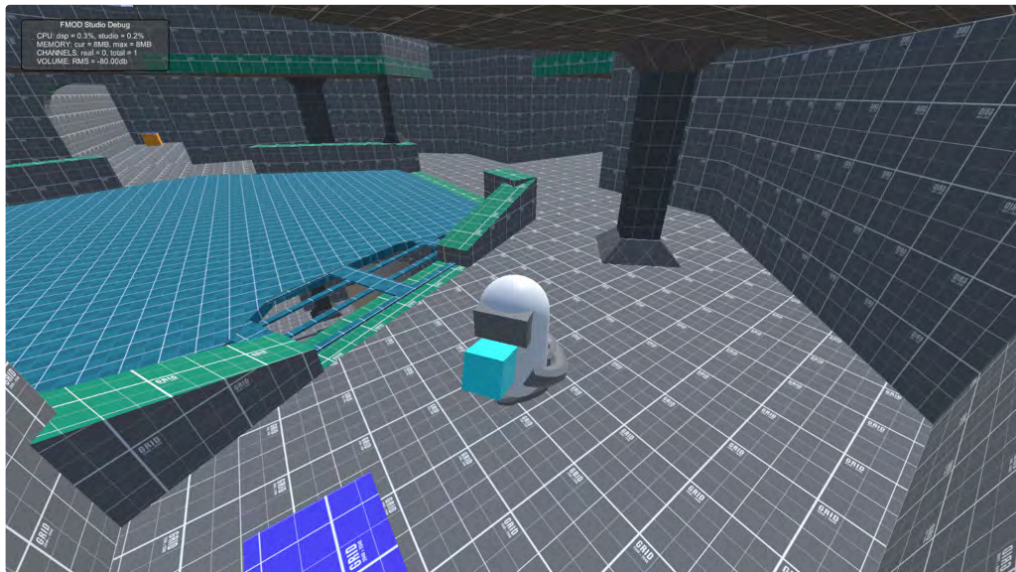
Visual Language:

Due to the gameplay demo being a simple demo the visual language found within the level is basic and does not represent what the finished product could look like in any capacity. However, throughout the demo we use colour as a primary visual language indicator enabling players to understand what certain aspects of the environment are and whether or not they are interactable. For example, within the demo orange coloured objects can be broken when the player throws the cube at them. Similarly, blue coloured switches will activate blue coloured doors or elevators.

Teasing/Breadcrumbs:

We take a teasing/breadcrumb approach to guiding the player towards secondary objectives and the solution to the puzzle environments they are in. This technique is primarily found within the state 2 puzzle room. Within this room the elevator noticeably has a crack/hole within it, teasing the state 3 upgrade and their objective to the player before they are able to access it. We do this to ensure players understand what their objective is whilst also providing them with a clearer understanding of what they need to do in order to get there, prompting and activating

their problem solving skills to create a more engaging gameplay and puzzle solving experience. An image of this teasing technique can be viewed below:



Players can catch a brief and mostly obscured glance at their objective through the hole in the elevator, increasing their curiosity and leveraging it to aid them in puzzle solving

Tutorial Tower Level Design

Level Name: Tutorial Tower

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

First tower on the far side of the crater, furthest distance away from the entrance to the crater

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Climbing
- Jumping
- Rope swinging and jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Lever locked doors
- Cube locked doors
- Breakable walls
- Environment cube interaction
- Rest points
- Pressure plates

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

- Player has been captured by enemies and must break free of the tentacles to start their journey of escape
- Player meets the cube

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Be taught the basic controls
- Be taught how to interact with environment elements
- Be taught how to climb on nodes and ropes
- Be taught how to use the cube
- Feel small through the intimidating environment
- Feel a sense of new found friendship and comfort once they connect with the cube

Player Primary Goals:

- Form their connection with the cube
- Find a way out of the tower

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 5 minutes

Golden Path - 8 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 12 minutes

Cutscenes:

Intro:

Before the player gains control over their character an introduction cutscene should play. The details for this cutscene can be found in the cutscene design document.

Cube connection:

Once the player opens the cubes cage and walks towards it the cube connection cutscene should play. The details for this cutscene can be found in the cutscene design document.

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Tentacle Escape:

Upon starting the game the player will be restrained by tentacle like entities whilst standing on a circular platform. The player must mash the X or A button (depending on the controller being used) to escape the tentacles grasp. Whilst the player is in this scripted sequence the camera should be locked in a specific view, placing the player on a third line and looking up at the large statue of the cube in front of them. The player should be made to feel small and weak through the camera perspective/angle. Upon escaping the tentacles the camera should transition back into its default 3D orbit mode, the player should also be given control over the camera at the same time.

Cube Cage:

This scripted sequence should be blended into gameplay, control should not be taken from the player except for the camera. Once the player enters the tower the camera should switch to focusing on both the player and the cube ensuring both are within the frame at all times. Whilst the cube is stuck in the cage it should flash and attempt to talk to the player. The cube “help” audio should be played as though the cube is asking the player for help and to free them from the cage. Once the player has opened the lever and connected with the cube the “help” audio should be stopped however the camera should still focus on both the player and the cube for the rest of the experience.

Credits:

Once the player reaches the bridge the credits sequence should be triggered. Here the camera should zoom out to a predetermined location, framing the player, cube and bridge on the left and leaving empty space on the right. Within this empty space the credits for the game should be shown detailing who made the game and what it is called. Music that emphasises feelings of triumph and exploration should be used here to help heighten the sequence and make it more memorable.

Bridge Collapse:

Once the credits end and the player passes a specific trigger box the part of the bridge should collapse behind them preventing them from returning to the tutorial tower. During this collapse event the player character should drop the cube by accident with it now dangling above the hole in the bridge, the camera should move to an overhead position to emphasise the height. The player must pull the cube up and then the event will end and the camera will switch back to normal

Puzzle Design:

Church Puzzle:

Being the first puzzle of the game the church puzzle is extremely basic. The player must find a lever and pull it to open the second floor door, this enables the player to advance through the level. More importantly, this puzzle teaches the player how to interact with environment systems like levers.

Cage Puzzle:

Similarly to the church puzzle the player must use a lever to unlock the cage that the cube is trapped within. Finding this lever should be slightly more difficult however this puzzle serves a more importance purpose of uniting the player and the cube, it should not be extremely complex, instead reinforcing how the player interacts with environment systems ready for the sections ahead.

Pressure Plate 1 and 2:

The two pressure plate puzzles are also extremely simple.

The first pressure plate puzzle teaches the player how the pressure plates work with them simply placing an environment cube on the pressure plate to unlock the gate and move forward.

The second pressure plate puzzle directly after that is more complex. Here the player will need to place the cube on a pressure plate, this will open a door back into the tower that the player can go through. However, due to the cube still being outside the player cannot advance.

Therefore, the player must stand on the pressure plate that is inside the tower to keep the door open, here they can then reel the cube in towards them enabling them to advance up the tower.

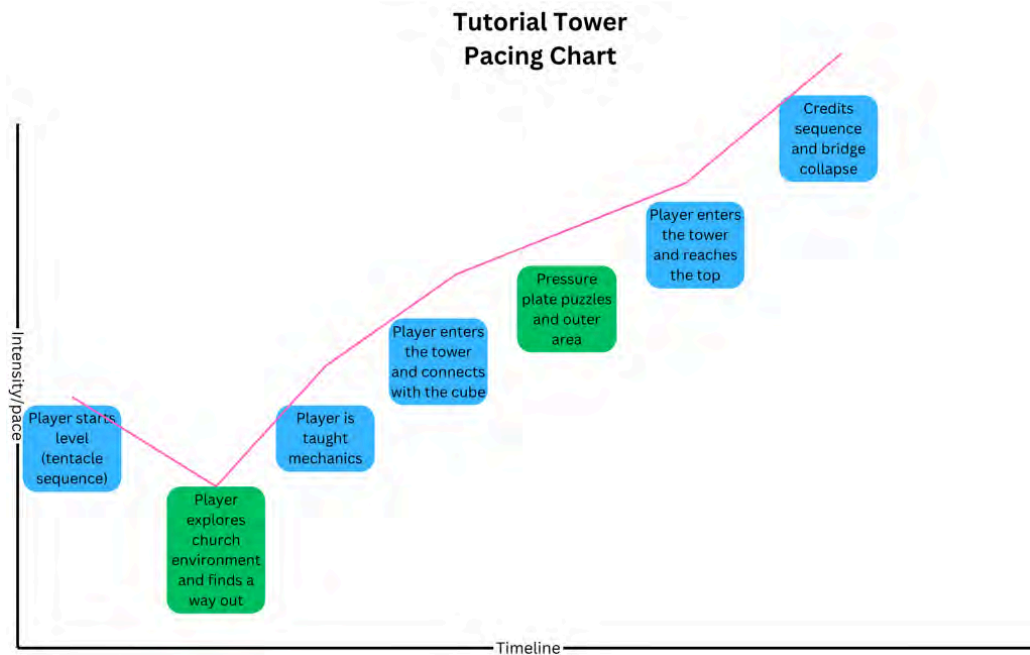
Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Pacing:

Green - puzzle solving sequence

Red - combat sequence

Blue - environment exploration sequence



Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Throughout the tutorial tower two valves are used. This ensures that the player gains an adequate sense of exploration and freedom whilst still being prompted to move in the right direction and progress through the game in the intended way. An brief explanation of the two valves we use can be viewed below:

Church Rope:

The first valve that is used within the tutorial tower is the church rope. Once the player has escaped the church environment they will jump onto a rope and climb down it, accessing the tower environment. However, the rope is placed high above the ground meaning the player will have to let go and drop down to the tower floor. The ropes height ensures the player cannot jump back onto it and climb up, leading them in the wrong direction and back into the church environment they just completed

The Bridge Collapse:

The bridge collapse is a major valve that we use at the end of the tutorial tower environment. Here the bridge behind the player will collapse once they make it over to the next tower. This ensures that when the player loops back around to this bridge they do not become confused and attempt to cross it and enter the tutorial area, preventing unnecessary backtracking and time wasting that could lead to frustration and detract from the intended experience.

Hard Gates:

Due to [Don't] Let Go's focus on puzzle solving we make consistent use of hard gates even during the tutorial. This ensures we adequately teach the player how to interact with our environment mechanics whilst introducing them to the types of puzzles they will need to solve throughout the rest of the experience. The hard gates that we use in the tutorial can be viewed below:

Church Door

Before the player can escape the church they must first open the locked door on the second floor. This hard gate prevents them from progressing unless they find the lever and pull it, ensuring the player is taught how to interact with environment elements before moving onto more complex areas and puzzles

Cube Locked Door

Similar to the church door the player must first connect with the cube before they can unlock the cube locked door. This ensures that the player cannot continue through the experience without the cube which will be essential as the player continues thus preventing any frustration or sequence breaking that leads to an experience that detracts from what we intend.

Soft Gates:

We make use of more general soft gates throughout the tutorial tower that come in the form of destructible walls. These soft gates allow us to slow the pacing down slightly forcing the player to interact with the cube due to the cube being the only thing that can destroy the destructible wall and allow the player to progress, thus improving and deepening their bond through a simple and mostly unnoticeable interaction with an environment element.

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Throughout the tutorial tower we make use of two different instances of a landmark/weenie to help guide the player forward and progress. These two instances are explained briefly below:

Cube Zen View:

Shortly after unlocking the second floor church door the player will be rewarded with a zen view that allows them to see into the tower. Furthermore, this zen view allows them to see the cube locked in a cage. This acts as the players objective and a landmark for them to reach providing

them with a goal that enables us to reward the player for achieving that goal later in the level. Near the zen view the player can also see a rope that ascends into the ceiling allowing them to piece together the puzzle and understand how they are meant to enter the environment, they must go above where they are currently to gain access to the rope.

Bridge

Upon exiting the tower the player will be able to very clearly see the bridge they need to climb up to in front of them. This ensures that the player is again given an objective to reach providing context as to why they are climbing the tower and a clear way that they can escape the environment and achieve their remaining primary goal. Furthermore, from this view the player should be able to catch a brief glimpse of the hub tower and the other two towers, hinting at their future objectives and environments that they will find themselves in.

Light:

Throughout the tutorial we use contrasting light heavily to guide the player however the main instance it is used in is to enable the player to see the cube. The cube should emit a blue tinted light contrasting the warm tones and shadows around it. This makes the cube stand out from the zen view mentioned in the previous section whilst also ensuring the player is unlikely to lose it during the experience. The blue light of the cube also contrasts the entirety of the environment, blue colouring is not used anywhere except for the cube making it more stand out more heavily linking back to our companionship themes and overall focus on the cube throughout the narrative.

Hub Area

Level Name: Hub Area and Bridges

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

Hub tower in the centre of the crater connecting the exit gate and the other three towers

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Climbing
- Jumping
- Rope swinging and jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Lever locked doors
- Cube locked doors
- Breakable walls
- Environment cube interaction
- Rest points
- Pressure plates
- Rest point

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

- Players escape from the crater is stopped by the tentacles giving them a clear objective and enemy to defeat before they can leave

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Be shown the main enemy
- Be shown their next objective/tower
- Feel a sense of intimidation due to the scale of the environment and the tentacles
- Feel a sense of exploration and familiarity as they continually return to the hub room to get to new areas of the map

Player Primary Goals:

- Witness the tentacles blocking the exit gate

- Make their way to the state 2 tower
- Make their way to the state 3 tower
- Escape the crater

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 10 minutes

Golden Path - 14 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 18 minutes

Cutscenes:

Tentacle Block:

When the player enters a trigger box on the main bridge a short cutscene should play where the tentacles block the players path. The camera should then pan to the state 2 tower showing where the player needs to go. After that the camera should switch to show the bridge in the hub room collapsing and creating a ramp to the next area. Once the bridge has collapsed the cutscene should end and revert back to the normal player camera view.

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Main Gate Door:

Once the player has solved the main gate puzzle the gate doors should slowly open. This should be done in a scripted sequence that is connected to the puzzle. This should look grand and intimidating, the gate should open slowly to help emphasise its weight and importance.

State 3 Tower Collapse:

When the player is in the connecting corridor they should be able to look out of the window to their left and see the state 3 tower collapsing. The tower should slowly fall down into the crater as if it were crumbling. Importantly, the camera should not focus on this, the player should be able to miss it if they do not look.

Enemy Encounters:

Encounter 1:

The first enemy encounter will be located in the first room. Here the player will need to fight a small number of standard enemies (no more than 3) since this also acts as the combat tutorial for the player

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
1	• Standard Enemies	3

Encounter 2:

The second enemy encounter will be spread between the bridge door room and the state 2 tower bridge. Here the player will also be introduced to the brute enemies upon stepping onto the bridge. This should be a large fight containing many standard and brute enemies that try to block the players path and prevent them from reaching the next church

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
3	• Standard Enemies	10 Standard
	• Brute Enemies	5 Brute

Encounter 3:

Encounter 3 comes at the very end of the game. When the player steps onto the main bridge with the state 3 cube they should enter encounter three. This should be a large combat encounter since it is the final part of the game.

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
2	• Standard Enemies	10 Standard
	• Flying Enemies	5 Brute
	• Brute Enemies	5 Flying

Puzzle Design:

First Room Puzzle:

Upon entering the hub area the player will need to solve a puzzle to open a door on the far end. To solve this puzzle the player will need to defeat enemies to reveal an environment cube. Upon doing this they must use the environment cube to weigh the seesaw down and reach the second floor. Here they can unlock the door by pulling the lever.

Main Gate Puzzle:

In order to open the main gate the player must also solve a more complex puzzle. They will need to place two environment cubes on two different pressure plates. One of the cubes is already next to the pressure plate however to get the other one they must climb to the second level. Once they have reached the second level they must push a large cube along the catwalk and down into the main area providing them with a way up to the second pressure plate. When on this second level the player must also break a wall to get the second environment cube they must put on the pressure plate. Once putting both cubes on the pressure plates and walking up to the main gate with the cube it should open.

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Hub Bridge collapse:

We use the hub bridge collapsing as a valve to prevent the player from going back to the first room before we want them to. Instead the hub bridge collapsing forces the player to enter one of the side rooms which then leads to the state 2 tower bridge.

Hard Gates:

Main Gate Puzzle:

We use the main gate as a hard gate preventing the player from progressing across the main bridge and triggering the main tentacle cutscene before we want them to. To pass this hard gate the player must solve the main gate puzzle which can be found in the puzzle section of this document.

First Puzzle Door:

We also use the first puzzle door as a hard gate preventing the player from skipping the combat tutorial or from skipping the introduction to seesaw puzzles and how they will work. Information on how the player will get past this hard gate can also be found in the puzzle section of this document.

State 2 Tower Bridge:

Before the player can reach the state 2 tower bridge the player must first pass the enemy based hard gate. In order to open the door the player must first defeat the enemies. Upon defeating the enemies the tentacle blocking the door should disintegrate and the door should slowly open revealing the bridge and tower ahead.

Soft Gates:

We make use of more general soft gates throughout the hub tower that come in the form of destructible walls. These soft gates allow us to slow the pacing down slightly forcing the player to interact with the cube due to the cube being the only thing that can destroy the destructible wall and allow the player to progress, thus improving and deepening their bond through a simple and mostly unnoticeable interaction with an environment element.

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Throughout the tutorial tower we make use of two different instances of a landmark/weenie to help guide the player forward and progress. These two instances are explained briefly below:

Central Hub:

The central hub acts as a landmark that continually guides the player to other areas of the game. The central hub is clearly made a landmark through its usage of bridges and its hollow tower design standing out against all other areas of the game. Its central nature in the environment also helps it act as a landmark providing the player with a much easier time when navigating the game world and memorizing the paths they need to take in order to reach their desired location.

State 2 Giant Chain Level

Level Name: Chain climb

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

Second garden connecting to the main garden, with a giant elevator with surrounding scaffolding. At the top of the elevator is a watch tower which is almost as high as the crater walls. A hole in the wall of the watch tower leads to the giant chain connected to the crater wall and holding up a nearby tower.

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Climbing
- Jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Elevator
- Levers
- Cube locked doors
- Environment cube interaction (chain break)
(vine break)
- Rest point

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

- Players escape to reach the heights of the elevator are stopped by vines, tentacles and enemies the player must destroy to progress to the zipline past the chain of the crater.

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Use the cube to clear vines to keep the elevator moving
- Manage stamina in large climbing segments to reach the top
- Feel a sense of intimidation due to the height and verticality of the level

- Feel a sense of exploration and awe as they enter the second garden and see the giant chain connecting to the side of the crater wall

Player Primary Goals:

- Ride the elevator
- Clear each obstacle which stops the elevator from reaching the top
- Climb to watch tower and leap down to the chain
- Destroy the chain link which collapses a tower and clears the path to the zipline.

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 5 minutes

Golden Path - 7 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 10 minutes

Cutscenes:

Break the chain:

When the player lands on the platform in front of the giant chain, they will be in touching distance of the rusty and damaged chain link, when the player throws the cube at the link it will break that link which will start the cutscene

The chain link will snap and a camera will then cut the tower collapsing and falling. Another camera will be placed on the other platform on the other side of the chain link. It will show the player the other platform swinging as that's the effect the chain snapping has had on this platform that was connected to the chain. On this platform is some boulders from the crater wall. As the platform swings, the boulders will roll off and through a hole on the fence, clearing a path for the player to cross.

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Elevator

The player enters this garden and steps on the elevator, they then throw the cube at the lever and the ride will start. The elevator is very scripted with specific stopped points which give the player extra space to solve the puzzle of clearing the path so the elevator can continue.

Chain link break:

On the platform in front of the giant chain, the player is blocked by a platform with boulders so the player needs to break the chain to start the chain of events which leads to the path clearing.

Once the player throws the cube at the chain and it hits, the chain link will snap in half and the cutscene will trigger

Boulders fall off platform:

Similar to the chain breaking, the player needs to throw the cube at the rusty chain link and when it hits the cutscene will trigger, causing the chain to snap which causes the tower it's connected to to collapse, and the platform the player is next to, to swing causing the boulders to roll off through the hole, clearing the path for the player to continue towards the zipline

Zipline:

When the player walks up to the zipline, a text prompt will appear informing the player which button to press in order to start the zipline. Once on this will be a scripted event where the player will be moved from point A to point B, this being the top of the zipline by the giant chain, to the tilted room by the hub. The player can't affect anything on the zipline, they have no control over it so it will act as a mini cutscene which showcases the environment and more importantly the destruction they have caused to the abandoned city during their journey so far.

Enemy Encounters:

Enemies in this level include:

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
• 1	• Standard Enemies	5 Standard
	• Flying Enemies	2 Flying

At the last elevator stop, the obstacle blocking the players path is a giant tentacle enemy spawner, Here the player is given a square platform of scaffolding which loop around the elevator giving the player extra room for the enemy encounter and a loop for them to strategize and make space either to take out enemies in the order they prefer or to try to regain some stamina.

Puzzle Design:

Elevator Stops Puzzle:

First Stop:

The player gets on the elevator and throws the cube at the lever to start it. The elevator will take the player directly up but stop when vines block the path. The player has two choices for destroying vines; they can throw the cube at vines to take them out, or they can slide into them to break them. At each stop the player can find scaffolding with climbing nodes and ledges they

can climb which give them a high vantage point to slide into and back on the elevator. Once all vines are destroyed the elevator will continue up.

Second Stop:

The elevator will get stuck again by vines, but this time the path to the high vantage point to slide from is much further and requires a lot of climbing placing heavy emphasis on managing stamina and strategizes each mini climb to a ledge for rest.

Final Stop (top of ride):

Finally, the elevator will reach the top and stop however, the players path this time is blocked by an enemy spawner, the player must defeat all the enemies which will clear the path.

Elevator fail safes:

To start the elevator the player must locate the lever on the floor near the elevator, stand on the platform and throw the cube and hit the lever to switch it on. This will make the elevator start. Should the player die, fall to the bottom or have the elevator go without them, they can return to the bottom floor and throw the cube at the lever to switch it off, this will make the elevator return to the ground floor meaning the player can always reset the elevator should they need to.

Climbing Puzzle:

During the Elevator stops, the player will face climbing segments, The first is a small optional continuous puzzle of climbing two nodes and 1 ledge to reach high ground. This will be simple and easy to see as it is intended to teach the player that they can reach a high ground and approach the vines from a different angle to make it easier and quicker to clear them all. This first stop shouldn't be about managing the stamina and there wont be any enemy threat so the player can focus on learning how the elevator can move again once the vines are cleared. This first stop shouldn't overwhelm the player but rather give them space and time to focus on the puzzle at hand.

The second stop is where the climbing takes centre stage, this is because the player needs to scale a giant wall to reach the high vantage point to clear the vines. The wall will be much harder to climb due to the player needing to manage stamina and make sure the rope length isn't pulled to the maximum so they can keep climbing up.

State 2 Tower Church

Level Name: State 2 Tower Church

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

The first upgrade church that enables the player to upgrade the cube. Far side of the crater, touching its wall.

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Climbing
- Jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Cube locked doors
- Cube Upgrade

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling
- Cube Upgrading

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

- Players will upgrade the cube to state 2 showing its increase in power. Players will also destroy the first tentacle that blocks the exit staircase they were previously at

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Upgrade the cube to state 2
- Be shown what happens when the player upgrades the cube and how that affects the tentacles blocking the door
- Feel a sense of agoraphobia from the size of the church environment and enemies within
- Feel an increased connection to the cube through its upgrade and new functionality

Player Primary Goals:

- Upgrade the cube to state 2
- Destroy one of the exit gate blocking tentacles
- Leave the church environment and progress

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 5 minutes

Golden Path - 8 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 10 minutes

Cutscenes:

Cube Upgrade and Tentacle Destruction:

This cutscene should be triggered when the player stands on the pedestal. First the player should be shown a cutscene of the cube being upgraded and increasing in size. After that the player should be shown the tentacle wrapped around the statue being destroyed. The camera should follow this tentacle as it is being disintegrated all the way back to the main gate/staircase exit from the crater showing how it has been destroyed and signalling to the player what they need to do next to destroy the other tentacle.

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

There are no scripted events in this portion of the game

Enemy Encounters:

Encounter 1:

The only enemy encounter in the church level will take place immediately after the cube upgrade cutscene has been played. Here a medium size of enemies will be spawned from two different points, one that blocks the door and another that blocks the destructible pillar so players cannot ignore the combat encounter. Players will need to fight a mixture of brute and standard enemies. Upon defeating them the player should be able to see the destructible pillar that was obscured by the enemy tentacles.

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
• 2	• Standard Enemies	5 Standard
	• Brute Enemies	2 Brute

Puzzle Design:

There are no discrete puzzles within the church environment.

There is one basic continuous puzzle in which the player will need to climb over a pillar and pull the cube over however this is not a complex puzzle.

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Cube Upgrade Cutscene and Church Door:

After the cube upgrade cutscene has finished playing the church door the player entered through should lock and prevent the player from going backwards. This could be shown through part of the church collapsing and blocking the door from being used.

Hard Gates:

Door Blocking Tentacle:

The door blocking tentacle acts as a hard gate in the church environment that prevents the player from progressing without upgrading the cube to state 2. To get past this hard gate the player must go to the podium in the church and upgrade the cube. Upon doing this the hole the player needs to climb through to reach the garden will be accessible.

Soft Gates:

There are no soft gates within the church environment

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Due to the linear and enclosed nature of the church environment there is not an explicit landmark that guides the player towards anything. The cube statue within the church could be considered a landmark however it does not help the player much, just providing them with narrative significance.

State 2 Tower Garden

Level Name: State 2 Tower Garden

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

This level is located in outdoor garden attached to the state 2 tower and the church within

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Climbing
- Jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Breakable Pillars
- Lever locked doors

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

- This level does not have a link to the overall narrative it is simply a space for the player to move through on their way to state 2 tower chain that they need to destroy

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Feel a sense of freedom from the open environment that contrasts the interior environments they have been in
- The player should be introduced to the flying enemy type
- The player should be tested on their understanding of breakable pillars

Player Primary Goals:

- Defeat the enemies blocking their path
- Find the lever that opens the door to the chain level

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 3 minutes

Golden Path - 5 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 7 minutes

Cutscenes:

There are no cutscenes within the garden environment

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Scripted Camera Movement:

When the player enters the garden tunnel there should be a scripted camera sequence. The camera needs to frame and highlight the chain above them which can be found in the next level. This allows us to guide the player towards their next objective far easier, ensuring they are not confused during the level.

Enemy Encounters:

Encounter 1:

The only enemy encounter players will face in the garden environment will be used as a way to introduce them to the flying enemies. These flying enemies should be supported by standard enemies to ensure the fight remain tense and the player can be taught how to deal with multiple enemy types at once. Basic information on the encounter can be found below:

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
• 1	• Standard Enemies	2 Standard
	• Flying Enemies	2 Flying

Puzzle Design:

Lever locked door:

The only puzzle in the garden environment contains both a lever locked door and destructible pillars. Players must throw the cube at three destructible pillars which upon breaking creates a ramp for players to walk up. Walking up this ramp and onto the raised platform the player can pull a lever and open the door on the platform opposite. Once this door has been opened the player will be able to enter the next level

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

There are no valves present in the garden level

Hard Gates:

Lever Locked Door:

The lever locked door puzzle mentioned in the previous section acts as a hard gate that prevents the player from progressing into the next level before they solve the puzzle.

Soft Gates:

There are no soft gates within the garden environment

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

The primary landmark we use throughout the garden level is the large chain that connects the state 2 tower to the crater wall. Within the scripted camera sequence mentioned within this document we place emphasis on the tower chain, ensuring the player notices it and recognises it as an objective they need to work towards. This allows us to push the player forward through the garden environment before they reach the puzzle they must solve.

Alongside the chain we use basic signposting in the form of paths on the ground. These paths are used to help guide the player in the right direction, providing them with something to follow instead of being dropped into the environment without any direction.

Bell Tower Level

Level Name: Bell Tower

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

This level is located above the state 3 tower church. Players will find themselves in a large room with a bell in the middle that is connected to three pillars.

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Climbing
- Jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Breakable Pillars
- Bell collapse sequence
- Cube proof walls

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

- This level does not have a link to the overall narrative it is simply a space for the player to move through on their way to the state 3 tower church

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- The player should be challenged with a complex puzzle that utilises multiple mechanics

Player Primary Goals:

- Break the pillars that hold the bell and create a way down into the state 3 church

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 3 minutes

Golden Path - 5 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 10 minutes

Cutscenes:

There are no cutscenes within the bell environment

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

Bell Collapse Sequence:

Once the player solves the puzzle within the bell tower environment a short scripted event should play. Here the camera should move to a predetermined and static location, the player should not be able to control it. Once the camera has moved to the position the large bell in the middle of the environment should fall through the floor creating a hole that acts as a way down into the state 3 church environment. Once this scripted event is over a rope should be spawned allowing the player to descend into the state 3 church.

Enemy Encounters:

There are no enemy encounters within the bell tower level.

Puzzle Design:

Break the Bell Puzzle:

The players objective for this puzzle is to break the three destructible pillars spread throughout the environment. Once these are broken the bell in the middle of the room will fall allowing the player to reach the state 3 church below. The first pillar should be easy to destroy with the player simply needing to throw the cube at it, this teaches the player what happens when the pillars are broken allowing them to understand their objective.

To break the second pillar the player must leave the cube behind a set of bars, slipping inbetween them alone. Once on the other side the player must pickup an environment cube and place it on a pressure plate, this will open the set of bars allowing the player to grab the cube and throw it at the pillar to break it.

By putting the environment cube on the pressure plate the door to the third pillar is opened. Here the player will simply need to walk through the door and use the cube as a platform to jump onto. Once on the cube the player will have enough height to reach the ledge and pull themselves up to where the third destructible pillar is. Once destroying this pillar the bell scripted sequence will play and the player will be able to progress into the next level.

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

There are no valves present in the garden level

Hard Gates:

Bell Collapse:

The bell mentioned in the puzzle section of the document acts as a hard gate preventing the player from progressing until all of the pillars are destroyed.

Soft Gates:

There are no soft gates within the garden environment

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

The bell within the bell tower room acts as a basic landmark. It allows the player to orient themselves within the large room and establishes what their objective is, subtly guiding the player and aiding them in understanding how to progress to the next level/room/area.

State 3 Church

Level Name: State 3 Tower Church

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

The final upgrade church that enables the player to upgrade the cube to state 3.

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Rope Climbing
- Jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Cube locked doors
- Cube Upgrade
- Enemy Encounters locking doors
- Death Timer Starts

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling
- Cube Upgrading
- Cube Tentacle Attack

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

Players will upgrade the cube to state 3 showing its increase in power. Players will also destroy the second tentacle that blocks the exit staircase which causes the city to collapse giving the player a short amount of time to escape

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Upgrade the cube to state 3
- Be shown what happens when the player upgrades the cube and how that affects the tentacles blocking the door
- Feel a sense of agoraphobia from the size of the church environment and the hoard of enemies that attack the player after upgrading cube
- Feel an increased connection to the cube through its upgrade and new functionality
- Feel more powerful in combat due to the cubes new ability and strength.
- Start to feel the effects of the cube weighing the player down

Player Primary Goals:

- Upgrade the cube to state 3
- Destroy the second tentacle blocking the exit gate
- Fight huge hoard of enemies in church
- Start City destruction death timer
- Leave the church environment and progress

Length Estimates:

Critical Path - 10 minutes

Golden Path - 12 minutes

First Time Playthrough - 14 minutes

Cutscenes:

Cube Upgrade and Tentacle Destruction:

This cutscene should be triggered when the player stands on the pedestal. First the player should be shown a cutscene of the cube being upgraded and increasing in size. After that the player should be shown the tentacle wrapped around the statue being destroyed. The camera should follow this tentacle as it is being disintegrated all the way back to the main gate/staircase exit from the crater showing how it has been destroyed and signalling to the player that they can now head towards the exit gate as both tentacles blocking the path have been destroyed. The camera should then focus on the spawners to show multiple enemies spawning surrounding the player.

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

There are no scripted events in this portion of the game

Enemy Encounters:

Encounter 1:

The only enemy encounter inside the church level will take place immediately after the cube upgrade cutscene has been played. Here a large size of enemies will be spawned from three different points, one on either side of the alter where the player upgrades the cube and one near the exit door. The two spawners either side of the alter should be close enough to make the enemies who spawn quickly surround the player once the cutscene ends, this should make the

player feel overwhelmed and limit their space to move around safely which also forces them to react fast

Players will need to fight a mixture of brute and standard enemies. Upon defeating them the door will unlock, allowing the player to leave the church and head back towards the hub tower.

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
• 3	• Standard Enemies	4 Standard
	• Brute Enemies	1 Brute

Puzzle Design:

There are a couple basic continuous puzzle in which the player will need to climb over a pillar and pull the cube over however this is not a complex puzzle.

Furthermore, due to the tentacles, that were holding up the structures of the city, being destroyed, the city has started falling and collapsing which means the player needs to react quickly to holes forming in the floors while running away.

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Cube Upgrade Cutscene and Church Door:

The main church door is locked as the player enters through a pipe connected to the top floor, once the player upgrades the cube and defeats the enemies the main door will unlock allowing the player to move to the entrance room which is connected to the bridge.

Hard Gates:

Door Blocking Tentacle:

The door blocking tentacle acts as a hard gate in the church environment that prevents the player from progressing without upgrading the cube to state 2. To get past this hard gate the player must go to the podium in the church and upgrade the cube. Upon doing this the hole the player needs to climb through to reach the garden will be accessible.

Soft Gates:

There are no soft gates within the church environment

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Due to the linear and enclosed nature of the church environment there is not an explicit landmark that guides the player towards anything. The cube statue within the church could be considered a landmark however it does not help the player much, just providing them with narrative significance.

State 3 Bridge back to hub

Level Name: State 3 Tower Church

Pre Production:

Narrative Location:

Player will fight enemies with newly acquired state 3 cube and start running for the exit gate as the death timer has now begun.

Mechanics List:

Movement Mechanics:

- Walking
- Rope Climbing
- Jumping
- Dodging/slide tackle

Environment Based

Mechanics:

- Holes forming
- Cube Upgrade
- Enemy Encounters locking doors
- Death Timer Starts

Cube Based Mechanics:

- Cube throwing
- Cube holding
- Cube dropping
- Cube pulling
- Cube Upgrading
- Cube Tentacle Attack

Level narrative and link to overarching story:

Players will have levelled up the cube to be strong enough to clear the tentacles blocking the exit to the city. The ancient tentacles being destroyed causes the city to start to collapse with every building around falling apart, breaking and collapsing. The player has a limited amount of time (indicated by a giant UI timer on screen counting down the seconds) left until the city collapses and the player dies as a result.

Experience Goals:

In this level the player should:

- Use the state 3 cubes new ability to kill enemies blocking the path to the bridge
- Have the option to fight or run from enemies
-

Player Primary Goals:

-

Length Estimates:

Critical Path -

Golden Path -

First Time Playthrough

Cutscenes:

Set Pieces/Scripted Events:

There are

Enemy Encounters:

Encounter 1:

The

<u>Enemy Spawners:</u>	<u>Enemy Types</u>	<u>No. of Enemies (wip).</u>
• 3	• Standard Enemies	4 Standard
	• Brute Enemies	1 Brute

Puzzle Design:

Level Layouts and Blockmesh:

Hard Gates, Soft Gates and Valves:

Valves:

Hard Gates:

Soft Gates:

Navigation:

Landmarks/weenies/signposting:

Camera Design

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Perspective/Camera Type:

Player and Camera Relationship:

Camera Movement:

Camera environment interaction:

Scripted movements:

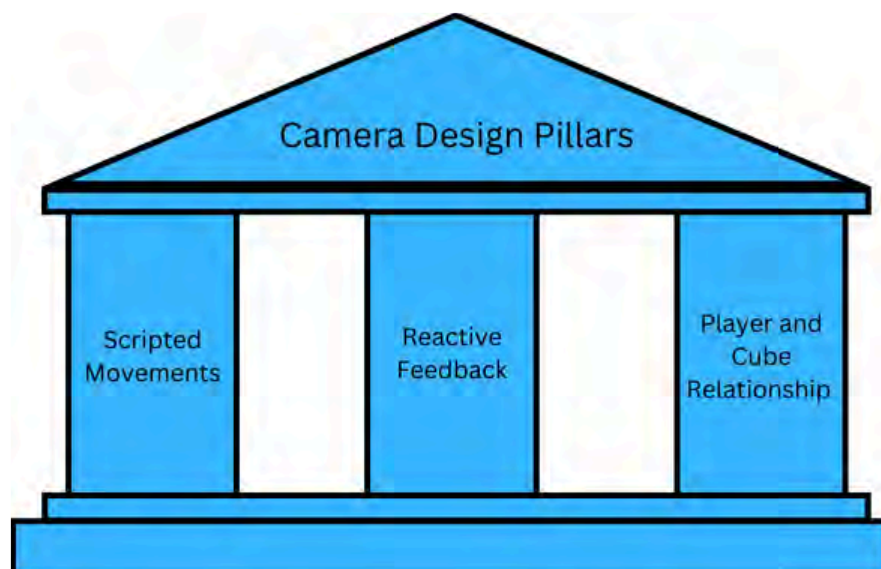
Additional mechanics:

Design Philosophy:

Our primary design philosophy regarding the camera system found within [Don't] Let Go is an emotion centric one with the overall goal of exploring and further expanding upon the player and cube relationship. The camera should use intentional framing, compositional theories and real cinematography practises to make the player feel small and weak in comparison to the growing power and intimidation of the cube at all times throughout the experience. Alongside this, the camera in [Don't] Let Go should be used to heighten and explore specific short term emotions like tension, fear and excitement through its design and implementation in order to create an engaging and high-quality experience.

A secondary philosophy/focus of the camera system should be on providing players with feedback via the camera and its reaction to the actions players take in order to create a grounded experience and improve the overall user experience through understandable and noticeable feedback.

Design Pillars:



Reactive Feedback:

As outlined in the design philosophy section, [Don't] Let Go's camera system should react to the players movements and actions consistently. This helps the team create an experience that feels responsive and offers understandable feedback to the player, avoiding typical static camera systems in favour of one that feels more dynamic and alive. This in turn helps improve the overall user experience the player will have enabling the team to create a higher quality product that achieves the overall goals outlined in the Goals and Objectives page (linked here:

[Overall Project Goals:](#))

Player and Cube Relationship:

Another central pillar of the camera systems design is its focus on further demonstrating and expanding upon the player and their relationship to the cube. This should be achieved through intentional framing and cinematography techniques to show the player as being smaller or weaker than the cube especially as its size and weight increases.

Scripted Movements:

The final camera design pillar is scripted movements. Throughout [Don't] Let Go the camera should move into predetermined or scripted sequences with the goal being to expand upon or elicit a specific emotion within that scripted sequences. Furthermore, the scripted camera movements can be used to show or highlight important game elements to the player such as their next objective or enemies swarming the room they are currently in. This system should work similarly to its implementation in other games of the action adventure genre such as Journey and Ico.

Perspective/Camera Type:

A 3D orbital camera will be used across [Don't] Let Go's runtime exclusively, the camera and its type should not switch at any point across the experience.

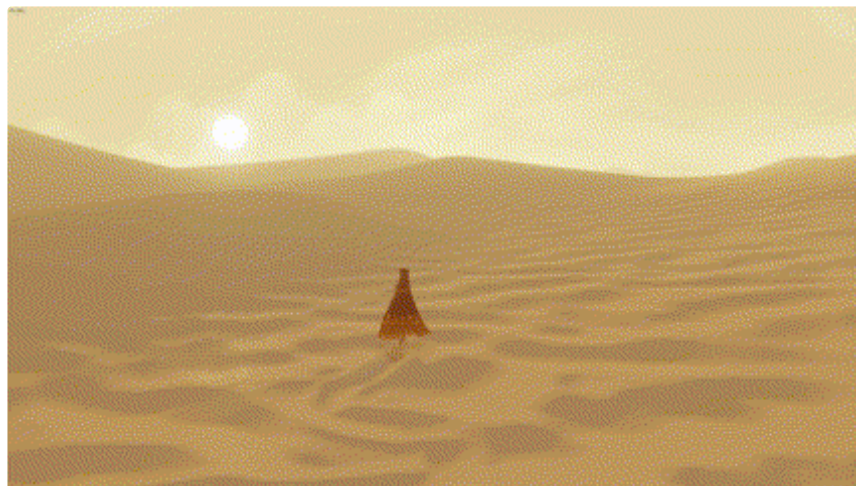
Much like Journey, the camera system in [Don't] Let Go should be further away from the player, providing a more orbital view of the character instead of a close and over the shoulder view. This orbital view ensures that the player feels distant and small. Furthermore, the orbital camera should emphasise the environment just as much as it does the cube and player, exploring the characters relationship with the environment around them and its powerful undertones in order to create feelings of oppression and insignificance within the player.

Player and Camera Relationship:

The camera should feel distant from both the player and the cube framing them as being small and insignificant compared to the rest of the environment. However, the camera system should also change its relationship with the player based on the actions they are completing.

When the player is moving the camera should centre the player character within the frame enabling players to see what they are controlling easily as well as the environment around them.

However, when the player is idle the camera should subtly and automatically reorient itself around the player, framing them on the nearest third line and not in the centre. This allows the team to create a more satisfyingly composed image whilst further exploring the character and their relationship with the environment. An example of this mechanic can be seen below:



A video demonstrating the Journey camera subtly moving to frame the players character on a third line when the player stops moving the camera

Finally, the camera system should also react to the cubes increasing states. Each time the player upgrades the cube and its size increases the camera should zoom/move back further. This should be done for two reasons:

The first reason is to ensure a smooth and high quality user experience. As the cube increases in size it will get difficult for the player to see both it, their character and the environment around the cube. In order to avoid any disorientation and a poor gameplay experience the camera should be zoomed out subtly each time.

The second reason we do this links to our overall camera design philosophy. Each time the camera zooms out it should frame the player getting smaller each time. When compared to the large size of both the cube and the environment the camera zoom out allows the team to further the overall goal of making the player appear small expanding upon the preestablished feelings of weakness and oppression via the camera system and its relationship with the player alone.

An example of this slight camera zoom out can be seen below:



The image above demonstrates the standard Death Stranding camera zoom



The image above demonstrates the zoomed out Death Stranding camera that frames both Sam and the cargo carrier

Camera Movement:

Much like other camera systems in the action adventure genre players can control the orientation of the camera using the right joystick on their controller. The camera will move in an orbiting motion around the player with their character always being centred, acting like an anchor point for the camera. When moving the camera there should not be any acceleration meaning it should move at a set speed continually.

However, when the player looks up there should be some restrictions placed onto the camera system. In order to prevent players from becoming disoriented the cameras vertical movements should be limited to 160 degrees, preventing the player from looking directly upwards. Furthermore, when the player looks upwards or downwards the camera should stay consistent to its orbital perspective moving near the players heels when looking upwards and moving above the players head when looking downwards. The players character model should always be visible even when the camera is near it, a dithering effect should not be used at all however if the players view is obscured when looking upwards or downwards the automatic third line camera framing system can be used to prevent disorientation and annoying camera positioning. The diagram below can be used to help understand this system:



The image above is a diagram outlining how Journey handles similar vertical movements. This system was further explained in the linked GDC talk: [50 Game Ca](#)

[mera Mistakes](#)

The camera should also react automatically to the players movements in order to provide satisfying feedback for all of the actions they may take. For example, when the player character jumps the camera should follow them upwards and bounce once the character hits the floor. This system should be subtle as to not disorient the player or cause any motion sickness issues to arise. A similar approach to camera reactivity should be applied to the following game mechanics to maintain camera feedback consistency:

- Throwing
- Rolling
- Swinging
- Falling from heights
- Pulling the cube cord
- Picking up the cube

Camera environment interaction:

The camera system and its interaction with the environment is another crucial aspect of its design that will be explored and expanded upon below:

Firstly, when the player character is backed into a tight corner the camera should react to this confinement. It should not clip through the wall instead acting as if it were a real object within the game world. In order to prevent disorientation in this scenario the camera should move upwards and pan downwards as it gets closer to the corner, utilising the vertical axis it orbits the camera on. This should prevent the camera from clipping into the character or the outer environment. Furthermore, this camera movement should give the player a wider view of the

environment, allowing them to see enemies or potential hazards easier, importantly the player should still be able to see their character model at all times.

Similarly, when the camera hits an environment object that causes a line of sight break between the player and their character (like a pillar) the camera should automatically and quickly phase through the object, it should not be able to stay within the pillar or the obstructive object.

Importantly this should only happen when the camera is close to the pillar or touches it as to avoid any camera based disorientation. However, if the player stops moving and enters an idle state whilst the line of sight to their character model is broken the camera should automatically pan around the obstruction to show where the player model is, the automatic rule of thirds system could be used here instead of a bespoke system to save development time.

In addition, the camera should act like a real world object in order to prevent it from clipping through walls and allowing players to see the environment outside of the level, it should have basic collision to prevent this.

Finally, due to the setting of [Don't] Let Go many of its environments may be tight and claustrophobic corridors. In order to ensure the camera does not disorient players or lead to a worse user experience during these sequences it should be zoomed in being closer to the character model and similar to a standard over the shoulder view. This should help to emphasise the claustrophobic feelings of the tight environment whilst also ensuring the camera system is usable and non obtrusive to the players experience.

Scripted movements:

Scripted movements or sequences are another major pillar of the camera system found in [Don't] Let Go. At specific points in a level and depending on the emotion the designer wants to elicit or the gameplay scenario they want the player to be in, the camera should move into a scripted and predetermined position. This transition should be extremely clear and blended with the players normal camera movements as to ensure there is no disorientation or janky movement that will decrease the quality of the user experience. When within these sequences the camera should move into a predetermined/scripted location. Once in this location it should move in an on rails fashion, following a set track of predetermined points. Furthermore, when within these scripted sequences the player should not be able to control the camera at all as to ensure the sequence does not break or lead to any disorientation. This should lead to a more cinematic experience that allows the designer to emphasise and explore specific emotions. For

example, the sequence from Ico below uses scripted camera movements to emphasise the danger Yorda is in when the bridge collapses:



A video demonstrating the scripted camera movements found in Ico

Alongside the example above the scripted camera movements in [Don't] Let Go can be used to emphasise gameplay elements such as a level landmark or the players next objective, aiding in moving the player forward and providing them with a way to navigate the level ahead. An example of this can be found in Journey below:



A video demonstrating the scripted camera movements found in Journey

Alongside the scripted movements above the camera should also react to enemy encounters. When the enemies first spawn and each time an enemy grabs the cube the camera should automatically lock onto that enemy or spawn location, centring it in the frame for 3-5 seconds. This ensures the player is notified of the enemy's spawn location and/or attack on the cube and can react accordingly. This transition should be smooth with the camera panning to look at the enemy instead of teleporting.

Additional mechanics:

Cube Lock On:

In addition to the scripted movements above, the player can trigger a scripted movement during gameplay by holding L1 or the left bumper depending on their control scheme. Whilst L1 or the left bumper is being held the camera should smoothly lock onto the cube, framing it in the centre of the screen in a similar fashion to the way the camera focuses on the enemies when they spawn. This ensures players can find the cube easily when they are separated during specific gameplay sequences. Once the player releases L1 or the left bumper it the camera should slowly transition back to the standard orbital camera perspective.

Shader Colour Changing:

Furthermore, when the player is a distance from the cube the in game impressionist shader should change colour slowly becoming more greyscale and washed out as the players distance from the cube increases aiding in demonstrating the strong relationship between the player and the cube. Similarly, as the player gets closer to the cube the impressionist shader should gain its colour back, transitioning from a grey to vibrant colours the closer they are to the cube.

Cube Environment Occlusion

Alongside the other additional mechanics the camera in [Don't] Let Go should have an occlusion or dithering function. This dithering should be used when the cube is being dragged within an object or when the cube is on the other side of a wall to the player. This allows the player to see the cube even when they are separated. This mechanic will help to increase the players bond with the cube whilst also ensuring the player cannot lose the cube thus helping to mitigate any confusion the player may feel.

Narrative Design

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Narrative Summary/Plot Synopsis:

Primary Narrative Theme:

Secondary Narrative Themes:

Setting:

Characters:

Player Character Objective:

Ending:

Cutscenes:

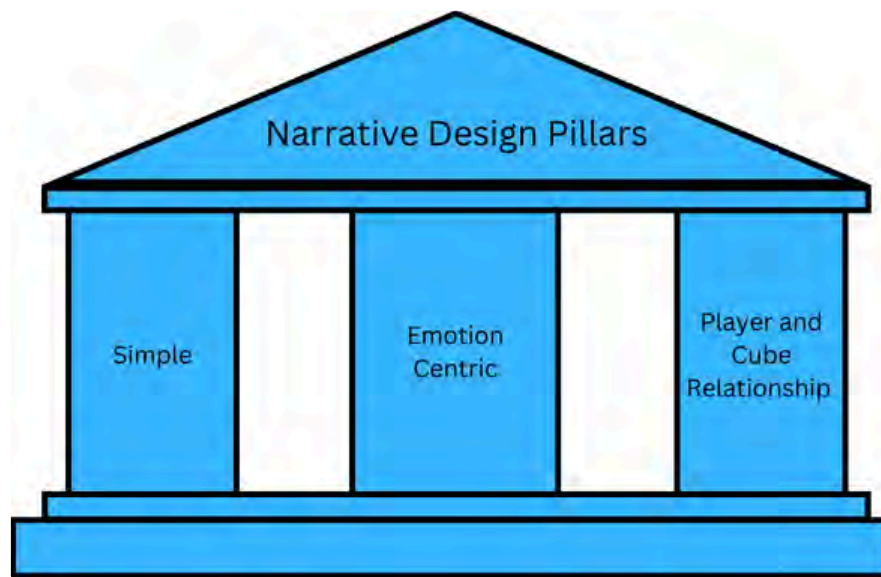
Narrative Structure:

Exploration of Narrative Themes Through Gameplay:

Design Philosophy:

The main approach/philosophy we take towards narrative design is an emotion centric one. The narrative of PROJECT CUBE should focus on the emotional bond that players form with the cube through gameplay and other elements like music and environment art. As such, the narrative should be extremely simple from a plot point of view, placing more focus on the player and cube bond and allowing that to take centre stage within the experience with the narrative design being similar to adjacent experiences like Journey, Ico, Shadow of the Colossus and Inside. Furthermore, the narrative should be simple as to adhere to the overall “design by subtraction” philosophy we adopt as well as ensuring the project stays within an achievable scope.

Design Pillars:



Simple:

The first pillar “simple” refers to how the narrative should be designed regarding scope and the projects overall feasibility. The narrative design needs to remain simple as to ensure players understand the plot and story events whilst also allowing the team to place more emphasis on the emotion centric aspects of the narrative adhering to the overall narrative design philosophy/approach. Furthermore, the story should remain simple to follow the projects overall “design by subtraction” philosophy and maintain project feasibility.

Emotion Centric:

The second pillar “emotion centric” refers back to the overall approach the team wants to take regarding the plot/narrative of PROJECT CUBE. The narrative should focus more on the players emotions focusing on that more so than a complex plot with many twists and turns. The narrative should elicit certain responses from players via utilising foundational player psychology and specific theories like loss aversion and the tend and befriend theory. Players should feel the impact and weight of the narrative rather than simply seeing and understanding it.

Player and Cube Relationship:

The final pillar “player and cube relationship” is a consistent one across the entire project. Similar to other aspects of the game, this pillar refers to the focus the narrative design should place on the players relationship to the cube. Ensuring that the player forms a strong emotional bond with the cube throughout the PROJECT CUBE experience via the way it is reinforced and tested through the basic plot and specific narrative gameplay instances and elements such as audio design.

Narrative Summary/Plot Synopsis:

In PROJECT CUBE the player and the small expedition they are apart of discover an ancient underground city thought to be lost to legend. Upon entering the small group is wiped out by an omnipotent wave of death and malice, leaving the player alone and without a clear way to escape. Aiming to find a way out, players will encounter a mysterious cube that latches onto them forming a rope like connection. The two must work together, utilising their unique strengths and weaknesses to find a way out of the underground city by destroying the three tentacles blocking the exit. However only the player is fated to leave this cursed place.

Primary Narrative Theme:

The primary narrative theme of PROJECT CUBE is letting go of a friend. Throughout the game players should experience the progressing stages of a friendship, meeting and befriending the cube in the beginning, experiencing relationship turbulence in the middle and finally letting go of the cube at the end of the game. Across its runtime PROJECT CUBE should explore the emotional difficulties of letting go, demonstrating to the player how hard it is to initially move on from a friend and the consequential grief many feel. This should be demonstrated to players in a resonant and intrinsic way, making the player feel as though they are losing a friend and not simply just showing their character losing the friend they made in the form of the cube.

Secondary Narrative Themes:

Alongside the main theme PROJECT CUBE should also explore the secondary themes below in order to create an experience that players can relate to through multiple avenues and to provide greater emotional depth to the overall narrative and gameplay:

- Companionship
- Loneliness
- Weakness
- Anthropomorphism
- Reliance on someone or something

Setting:

PROJECT CUBE is set in an underground city, home to a long forgotten civilisation. This city is heavily inspired by Roman, Mesopotamian and Khmer architecture in order to give the setting a

mystical and oppressive tone in order to make the player feel weaker and rely more on the cube. The underground city should be intimidating in every aspect of its design to further this idea. The city should be mostly in ruins, reflecting an age of prosperity long past.



The underground city should appear similar to Angkor Wat and elicit the same emotions of mystery, power and worship



The underground city should also appear similar to Roman ruins by using similar architecture that looks worn and ancient

Narrative wise, the city was sealed underground many centuries before the player and their expedition ever found it, with the city often being remembered through folk tales and legend, not through history or passed down knowledge. It was sealed in order to prevent the cube from escaping after it consumed the vast majority of the city's inhabitants, preventing the cube from escaping and consuming other villages/towns and growing in power. To further ensure the cube could not escape three tentacle like entities were created to guard and seal the main entrance, holding down and locking its grand door.

Characters:

PROJECT CUBE contains a small cast of characters in order to adhere to the projects overall design by subtraction approach and ensure the project is feasible. A list of the characters as well as a brief description of who they are can be viewed below:

The player - The players character is unnamed and lacks a defined personality. This allows players to project their own feelings and personality onto the character, aiding in creating a deeper emotional bond between them and the cube. However, the player character should appear weak, fragile and small through the models design and animations.

The Cube - The Cube is the players best friend, aiding them in their escape of the underground city by growing in power and defeating enemies. However, the cube hides a much more sinister secret, its goal is to use the player to grow its strength and continue its quest to consume life once the duo escape the city.

The Enemies - The enemies in PROJECT CUBE are faceless husks shrouded in mist. Their sole purpose is to prevent the player from escaping with the cube, understanding its sinister plan and intending to put a stop to it before it can even begin. The enemies could be the men and women that inhabited the city and were consumed by the cube many centuries ago

The Death Wave - The Death Wave is an omnipotent creature birthed after the cubes attempt to escape the city was denied and it was sealed underground. The Death Wave periodically triggers, spreading throughout the entire city, killing any living creature the cube could use to grow its power thus preventing its escape until the player arrives.

Door Tentacles - The Door Tentacles are another creature that was created to keep the cube imprisoned in the underground city. There are three tentacles that work together to hold down the grand door that permits entry into and out of the city. Across the many centuries they have grown weak and dormant, allowing the player and their expedition to enter the city. Upon realising the cubes awakening at the hands of the player the tentacles quickly go back to carrying out their duty, blocking the player and cube from leaving until the player finds a way to destroy them.

Player Character Objective:

As mentioned in the plot synopsis, the players main objective is to escape the underground city. Whilst this is the main and overarching narrative objective players must first achieve the three secondary narrative objectives before they can escape the city. These objectives can be viewed below:

- The player must upgrade the cube to state two
- The player must upgrade the cube to state three
- The player must find the cube after being separated

Furthermore, each time the player achieves one of the objectives above they will. Upon completing these three objectives players will be able to move onto achieving the overall objective of escaping the underground city.

Ending:

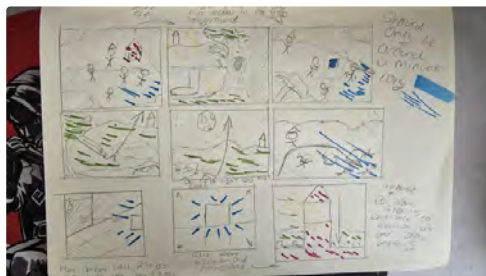
The ending of PROJECT CUBE should be the most emotional narrative moment with the player being forced to cut the cord that joins the cube and themselves together in order to finally escape the underground city. This final action must be completed through gameplay with the player pressing the right and left triggers to slowly cut the cord using a nearby sword. During this

moment the cube should attempt to talk to the player, flashing and beeping alarmingly in a similar manner to when it is picked up by the enemies in normal gameplay. The player should find it extremely difficult to let go of the cube in this moment through the emotional bond they have forged with the cube as well as the usage of other game elements like music during these final moments to create a more impactful experience and ending.

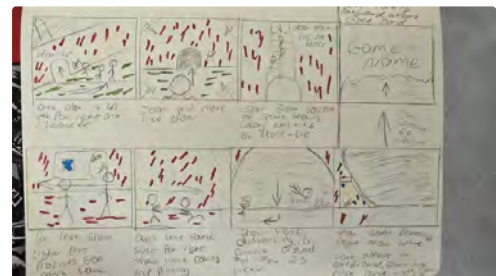
Upon finally cutting the cord the player should be free to leave the city, playing the final cutscene and bringing the experience to a close.

Cutscenes:

Due to the project currently being in the prototyping stages, not much focus nor consideration has been placed on cutscenes and their design. However, two cutscenes (one introduction and one ending) could be used to ease players into the narrative experience and provide an impactful ending. Furthermore, cutscenes will aid the project in appearing more professional and high quality, achieving one of the teams overall goals. Whilst not much consideration has been put into cutscenes and their design a basic storyboard sketch can be viewed below however please keep in mind this is a work in progress and is likely to be changed completely:



The first image of the introduction cutscene storyboard



The second image of the introduction cutscene storyboard

Narrative Structure:

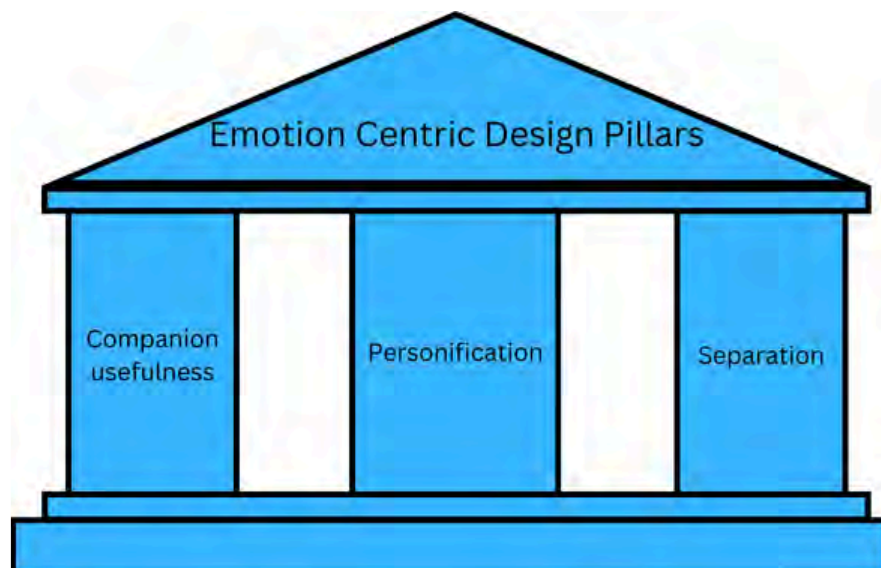
The diagram below shows an outline of the narrative structure used throughout PROJECT CUBE. The game should be split into 5 different acts that coincide with different points throughout the games levels. Overall the game should be approximately an hour long with each act (as seen below) having a target length, emotion and experience goal.



TEMP NARRATIVE OUTLINE

Exploration of Narrative Themes Through Gameplay:

Due to PROJECT CUBES emotion centric story, the way its themes are explored through gameplay is extremely important in ensuring players are provided with the teams intended experience and feel a strong connection to the cube and the overall product. Before exploring how we do this through gameplay the teams emotion based pillars can be found below, they outline what is the most essential elements in creating an impactful emotional connection between the player and the cube:



An explanation of the gameplay mechanics that aid in furthering PROJECT CUBES themes can be viewed below:

Desaturation of the Impressionist Shader and Audio Muffling:

Throughout PROJECT CUBE a graphical shader that mimics the style of impressionist paintings is used to create a painted like world. However, this shader is also used to express and convey the importance of the cube to the player, subconsciously ensuring the player cares for the cube. When the player is far from the cube the impressionist shader should become desaturated, transitioning from a vibrant hue to black and white. This feature subtly furthers the player and cube relationship through making sequences or areas where the players lacks the cube feel depressing via the environments washed out and dull appearance. Alongside this, any audio such as background music or foley sound effects should gradually become more and more muffled as the player gets further from the cube.

Cube Essentiality:

As mentioned in the **Cube Design page** (linked here: [Cube Design](#)) the cube should be an extremely essential aspect of the game, requiring players to interact with it consistently across the experience in order to complete puzzles, defeat enemies and progress through the game. This in turn places more emphasis on the cube in the players subconscious mind, further deepening their relationship.

Cube Visual Design:

As mentioned in the **Cube Design page** (linked here: [Cube Design](#)) the cube and its corners should change as its states increase. In state one the cubes corners should be rounded and appear soft in order to communicate feelings of companionship and safety. However, each time the player upgrades the cubes state these corners should become sharper with the state 3 cube having normal cube corners to communicate feelings of danger and demonstrate the cubes subtle personality shift with each state.

Cube Separation:

During specific sequences and acts within PROJECT CUBE the player will be separated from their companion, making completing puzzles and overcoming challenges/hazards like enemies much more difficult. Through this separation and spike in difficulty we hope players will understand how important the cube is to them and their quest thus aiding in furthering deepening the players relationship with the cube once they are reunited. These separation sequences should take advantage of psychological theories/phenomenon's like loss aversion and the endowment effect in order to further develop the players relationship with the cube.

UI Design

Design Philosophy:

Our main philosophy/approach to the user interface and its design within PROJECT CUBE is one of extreme minimalism. User interface elements should be used sparingly and preferably not at all. PROJECT CUBE does not contain any explicit systems such as player health that need to be shown to the player, therefore there should not be any UI for it. The user interface and its design should follow an approach similar to Journey and Ico, removing user interface elements to create an immersive experience that adheres to the overall design philosophy of subtraction and minimalism.

Design pillars:

- The design pillars as well as an explanation of each pillar should be here

UI Needed

- Main Menu
- Options
- Load Game
- Yes/No to load game, quit game and new game
- Overwrite file screen
- Title Screen/splash screen
- Loading screen
- Save Screen
- File save select
- Pause UI
- Pause options

Wireframe of each menu

Wireframe of Main Menu, main menu options and main menu load file:



Image of the Main Menu User Interface



Image of the options menu

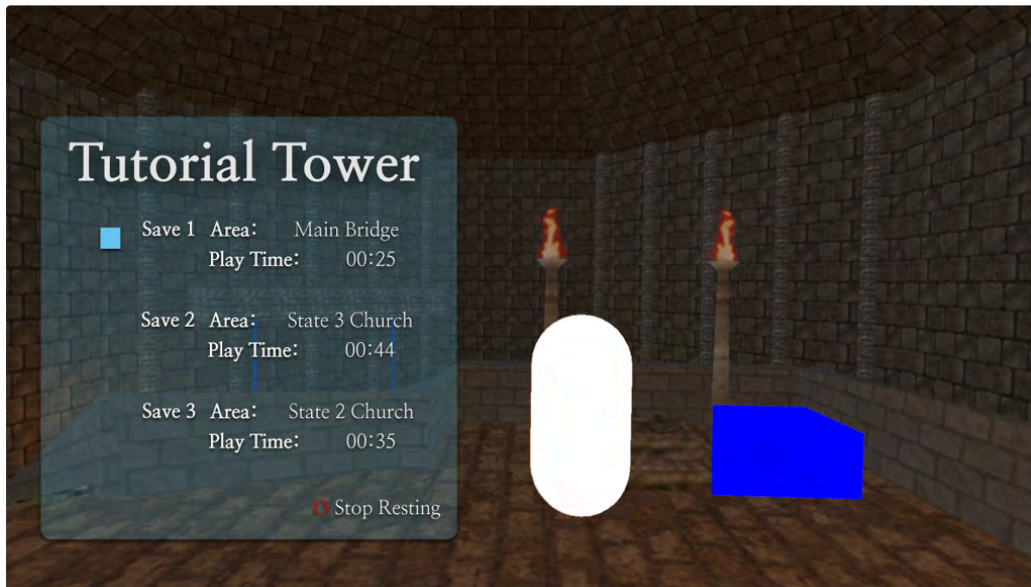


Image of the load game/file screen

Wire Frame of the rest UI:



Image of the rest UI menu



Save game in Rest UI screen

Iterations of each menu/interface

- changes made to the wireframe above should be here

Final version of interface (expand on changes)

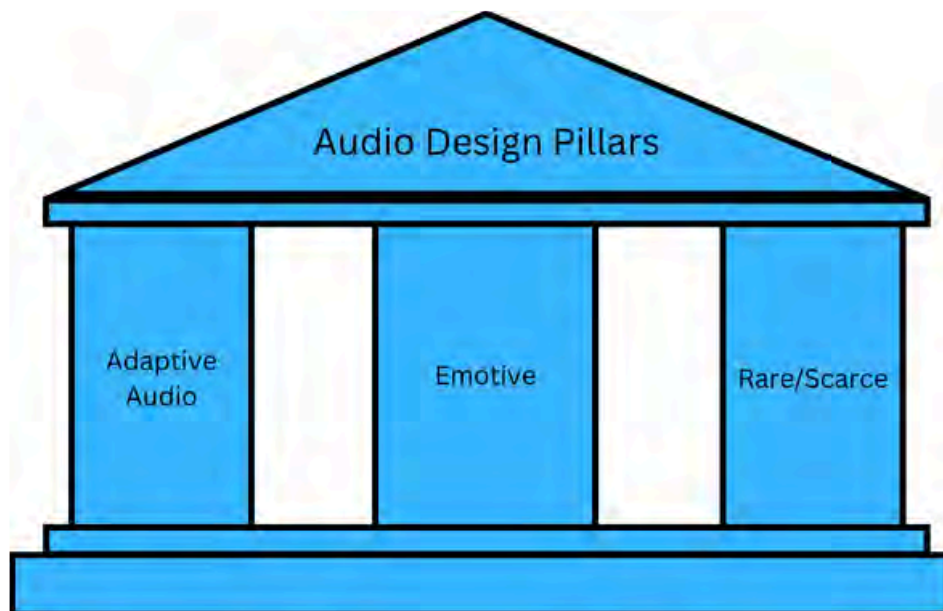
- The final version of the user interface systems should be here (preferably use in game screenshots here)

Music and Audio Design

Design Philosophy:

Our main design philosophy regarding audio and music design is to elicit and emphasise player emotions. We want to use audio in specific and intentional ways to provide impactful and memorable moments to the player, thus creating a more engaging and emotionally investing experience. Furthermore, as with all other aspects of the game the audio and music design should be used as a way to further the players relationship with the cube through specific cube sound effects and musical moments such as when the player loses the cube.

Design Pillars:



An image of the Audio Design Pillars

Adaptive Audio:

Throughout [Don't] Let Go we want the audio to be dynamic and adaptive, specifically designed to transition smoothly between areas to create a seamless and engaging gameplay experience with minimal silence.

Emotive:

Our main goal with music in [Don't] Let Go is to create and elicit strong emotions within the player through our usage of certain tracks. Music should be used at specific and intentional moments to emphasise or create the emotion that we desire. For example, when the player

loses the cube melancholic and depressive audio should be played to help emphasise the emotion that the player feels.

Rare/Scarce:

Finally, we want to use music scarcely across our environment. Music should be a special and impactful break from the lonely ambience the player will feel in order to make moments with music far more memorable and engaging. To do this we want to focus more on ambient tracks during normal gameplay sequences.

Sound Effects:

- List all sound effects used throughout the game and where

Music Used:

- Here list all of the music that we use at specific points or game states
- For example: Main Menu Music - track 1 and track 2

Early experiments (scrapped)

(BRADLEY WROTE THE INFORMATION BELOW)

 Demo 1.mp3  Demo 2.mp3

The idea behind these was to get a feel for creating the ambience and setting the tone of the world, experimenting with creating ambient ideas for any cutscene or world areas that would have a constant theme. Music takes a bit of a back step in the gameplay, with a focus on sounds and foley when it comes to what the player will experience. That being said, it was still important to nail

down the core foundation for how any tracks would sound to make sure the player is exposed to music and soundscapes that work. The first idea was inspired by the shrine music from BoTW, a game that has been looked at a lot for how it handles its soundscapes and sound direction. The second idea was an early experiment of the idea of using instruments that have altered sounds. The second idea features a guitar-like sound which is actually a synth, but is designed to emulate a guitar sound.

 Battle.mp3  Cube Theme.mp3

The early ideas for the cube theme revolved around a hopeful orchestral-like theme for the cube. The reasoning for this was to help establish a mysterious vibe since the game takes place in forgotten ruins, with a focus on an eerie, unfamiliar atmosphere to reflect this. This was scrapped in favour of the more darker and emotional approach, to help with the bond between the player and cube and to help invoke emotion in the player. Emotion is a core component of the sound design for the music for Project Cube, serving as a vital foundation for themes that relate to the cube. That being said, there is still room to explore other options such as more playful melodies as suggested by the designers (brainstorm board). This cube theme is also reflected in the early battle theme idea which includes a reference to the cube theme. The initial plan was to have the cube have a theme that is somewhat reflected throughout the OST often, and as a result it would often be in other audio tracks. With the battle music being something that the player comes across often potentially, and the fact that the player and cube work together, early inspiration for battle music was to have it center around the cube theme and therefore reference it. In the end, most early drafts were scrapped, apart this version which was pitched alongside the early cube theme to designers. The reference to the cube theme is to inspire the player, give them hope and also remind them of the cube. This is to further help establish the bond, as the player will hopefully think about the cube as they hear the reference in the soundtrack. Ultimately, these 2 ideas were scrapped and helped pave the way for better ideas for the team.

The cube

 Cube 1.mp3  Cube 2.mp3  Cube 3.mp3  Cube 4.mp3  Cube 5.mp3

This batch was created after going through research documentation and ideas proposed from the designers about how to approach the cube and any themes that relate to it. Using choir-like sounds was suggested, as well as more darker and emotional approaches.

Cube 1 - This a slow, emotional piano idea that is supposed to help invoke an emotional feeling in the player.

Cube 2 - This is a more upbeat and playful melody, but the contrasting dark strings inspired from strings heard in Ocarina of Time serve as a counter to the more playful melody. Unsettling, yet emotional with the counter melody that comes in later, this idea is a more overall darker feel than the previous idea.

Cube 3 - This idea is another emotional track like Cube 1, with a focus on invoking emotion, with a bit of a mysterious touch to it.

Cube 4 - For this idea, choir sounds as suggested were used to help create an unsettling and darker tone.

Cube 5 - The final idea in this batch, an eerie choir sound serves as the foundation with synth bells that add an emotional and hopeful touch.

Cutscene Design

Cutscene List:

- **Intro** - brief intro showing the player entering the environment and being captured. Should expand on the cube and its relevance to the lost civilisation
- **Escape Church Tentacle** - short cutscene of the cube breaking the tentacles the player is stuck in using a beam of light, this frees the player and allows them to start the tutorial
- **Cube connection** - short cutscene showing the player and the cube becoming connected to one another
- **Tentacle block** - Cutscene showing the tentacles blocking the players exit from the crater, tentacle should say something to the player to make this more clear, bridge in the hub needs to collapse and the camera needs to show the player where to go (state 2 tower)
- **Cube upgrade to state 2** - Short cutscene showing the cube getting upgraded and the first tentacle being destroyed
- **Tower collapse** - short cutscene showing the state 2 tower collapsing
- **Cube upgrade to state 3** - Short cutscene showing the state 3 upgrade and the last tentacle being destroyed, should also establish that the environment is now collapsing
- **City collapse** - once the player reaches the main bridge a short cutscene should play showing the entire city crumbling
- **Cube connection cut** - short cutscene showing the cube falling down the stairs once the player has cut their connection with it
- **Credits** - short screen after the player reaches the ending trigger box that shows the credits (could have the picture the player gets shown here too or just after the credits end as a final shot before end)

Cutscene Basic Information:

- **Intro** - This cutscene will be triggered once the player presses play in the main menu
- **Escape Church Tentacle** - short cutscene of the cube breaking the tentacles the player is stuck in using a beam of light, this frees the player and allows them to start the tutorial

- **Cube Connection** - This cutscene is triggered when the player is stuck in the church tentacles at the beginning of the tutorial
- **Tentacle Block** - This cutscene should be triggered when the player gets close to the exit gate
- **Cube upgrade to state 2** - This cutscene should trigger when the player stands on the podium with the cube
- **Tower collapse** - This cutscene should trigger when the player breaks the large chain connecting the state 2 tower to the crater wall
- **Cube upgrade to state 3** - This cutscene should trigger when the player stands on the state 3 tower church podium
- **City Collapse** - This cutscene should trigger when the player reaches the main bridge for the last time (after the player has reached state 3)
- **Cube connection cut** - This cutscene should trigger when the player has finished the “save the cube” quick time event
- **Credits** - This cutscene should be triggered when the player reaches a specific trigger box found within the forest

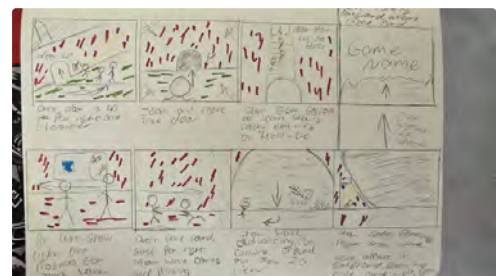
Storyboards:

It is important to note that only the specific and bespoke cutscenes have been storyboarded. Cutscenes that happen during gameplay have not been storyboarded due to our ability to test and make them quickly within engine.

First Draft of the Intro Cutscene:



The first image of the introduction cutscene storyboard



The second image of the introduction cutscene storyboard

Second draft of the intro cutscene:

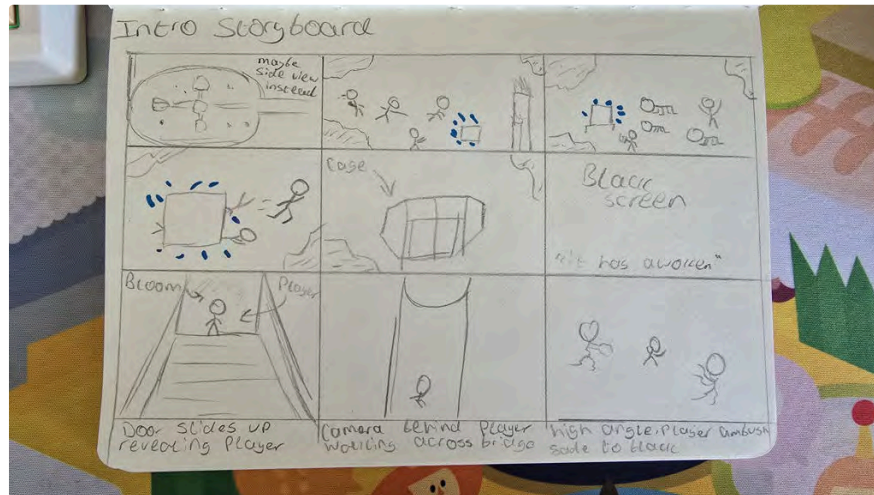
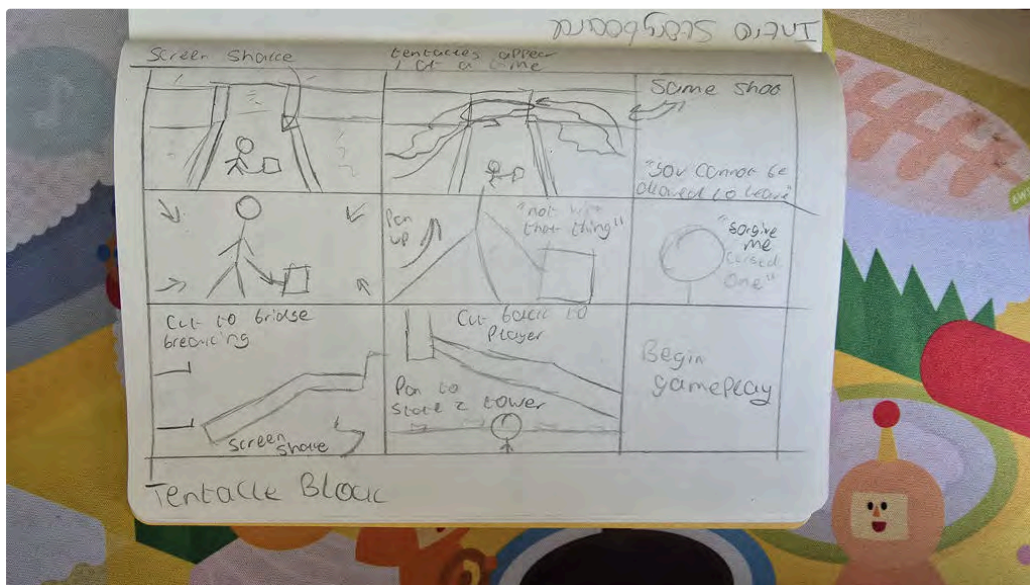


Image of the second draft of the Intro cutscene storyboard (more information on this can be found in the brainstorming whiteboard)

Tentacle Block Cutscene Storyboard:



An image of the Tentacle Block Storyboard

Cube Connection Cutscene Storyboard:

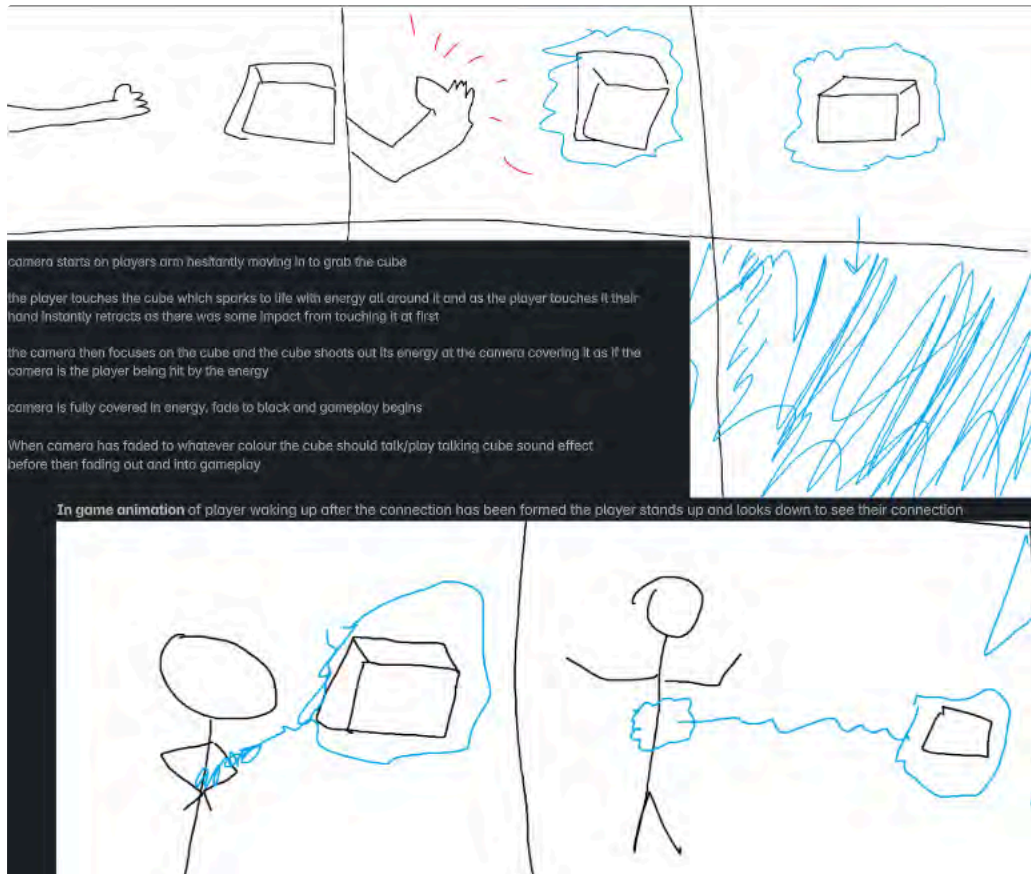


Image of the cube connection cutscene initial storyboard

Tower Collapse Cutscene Storyboard:

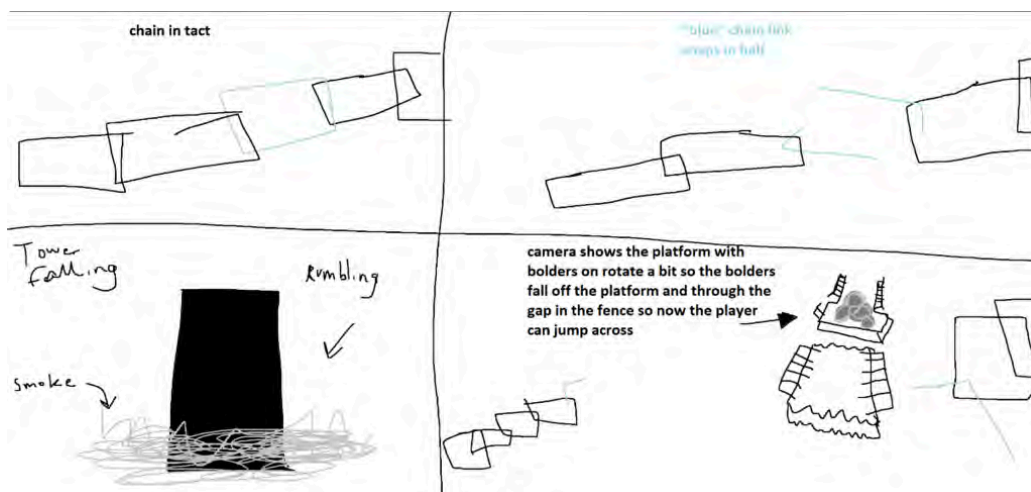
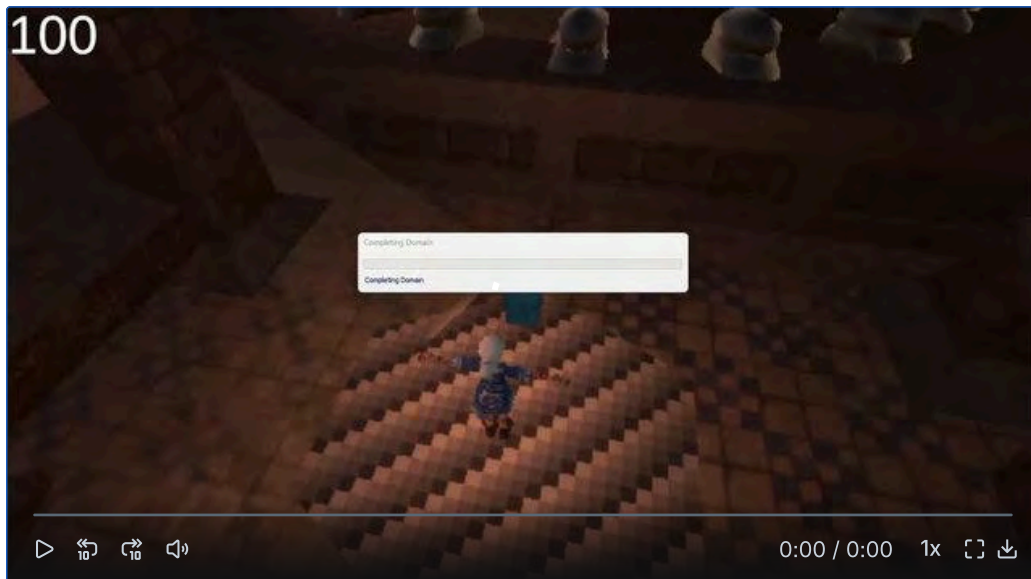


Image of the Tower Collapse initial storyboard

Blockout/first draft of cutscene:

Intro Cutscene first draft:



A video of the first draft for the Intro Cutscene

Finished Cutscene:

- The final cutscene used within the game should be here

Cutscene Audio:

Intro Cutscene Audio:

- Tentacle talking
- Player footsteps
- Enemy attack sounds
- Player hit sounds
- Background music
- Door opening
- Cube beam

Tentacle Block Cutscene Audio:

- Tentacle talking

- Bridge collapsing audio
- Background music/ambience

Cube Connection Cutscene Audio:

- Cube talking
- background music/ambience

Tower Collapse Cutscene Audio:

- Tower collapse audio
- Chain break sound effect
- Background music/ambience

Custom Assets Needed for each Cutscene:**Intro Cutscene:**

- Main exit door sliding upwards
- Cave painting images
- Cube beam

Tentacle Block:

- None

Tower Collapse:

- None

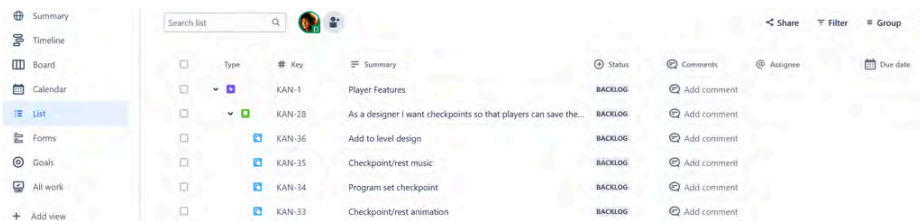
Cube Connection:

- None

Epics and User Stories

All epics and user stories can be found by following the link to the PROJECT CUBE Jira page here: [Project-Cube-Link](#) | [List](#)

To find the epics and user stories, click on the “list” button found on the left. Individual epics and user stories can then be accessed by clicking on the drop down boxes in the centre of the screen. An example of what this interface looks like can be found below:



An image of the Epics and User Stories page found on the PROJECT CUBE Jira

Game states

List of Game States:

Free Gameplay State - player is free to move around and interact with environments as normal

Climbing State - player is climbing or interacting with a climbable surface/node

Rope Climbing State - player is interacting with a rope based climbing node/surface

Cube Cord Pulling State - Player is pulling the cube cord and bringing the cube closer to them

Cube Carrying State - Player is holding the cube

Cube Pushing State - Player is pushing the state 3 cube

Cube Grabbed by Enemy State - Cube is being held by an enemy and dragged to a death point/fail state trigger

Resting State - Player is interacting with the rest point/safe point

Death Wave Chase State - The death wave is active and the player is being chased by it

Combat State - Player is in combat with enemies, importantly the cube has not been grabbed yet and they are free to move around

Interaction State - Player is interacting with a level, button or another environment element

Fail State - Player is dead or within a fail state

Main Menu State - Player is in the main menu interface/has not entered gameplay yet

Art

Welcome to the Art hub page, links to the more specific art pages can be found below:

- [Art outline](#)
- [Assets](#)
- [Art Backlog](#)
- [Animation Backlog](#)

Art outline

Art Style:

Due to our team lacking an artist the art style/direction is still largely undefined. However, the environments should be low poly favouring simplicity over high detail in order to link to our overall design philosophy whilst also ensuring the art scope is brought down to an achievable state.

The environments and art style should take inspiration from games like Ico with the environments being quite drab and repeatable allowing us to further our themes of loneliness and isolation whilst also ensuring the environments link.

Overall, [Don't] Let Go should have a visual or art style reminiscent of classic PS2 games such as Ico. The models, textures and lighting should reflect this aiming to achieve an authentic feeling PS2 experience.

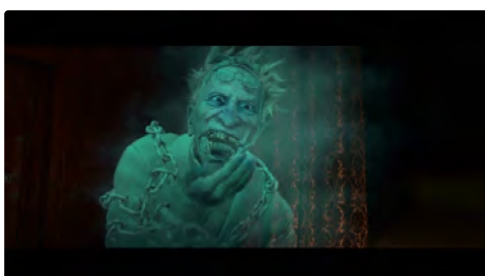
Artistic Shaders:

None have been decided yet and thus not documented here however any shader that we do use must complement the PS2 style and aid in furthering that artistic direction.

Visual Effects:

To further our themes of the cube changing and becoming something more evil we want the cube to suck colour out of the environment or anything else that it touches. To do this we should use a visual effect showing the cube sucking the colour out of the environment and into itself before then permanently changing the environment material to be grey scale/black and white.

Alongside this the cord attaching the player to the cube should utilise some sort of visual effect to create a ghostly and mystical appearing chain. The visual effect should help to make the chain look less “chain like” and realistic, adding a fantastical flair that matches the cubes visual style to further connect the two. Imagine the chain appearance mixed with the mist like appearance of the two images below:





However, beyond this feature the visual effects we want to use have not been discussed heavily due to the project being in the prototyping stages and visual effects being an irrelevant aspect for this current phase.

Visual Design of Individual Game Elements:

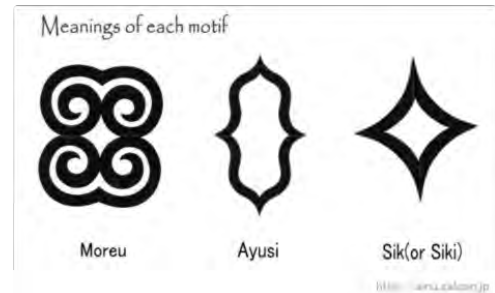
Player Visual Design:

In order to further our focus on making the player feel weak the visual design of the player character should serve that theme. The player character in [Don't] Let Go should appear more child like in both appearance and animations, moving with inexperience and a lack of precision. The character should also reflect feelings of loneliness and anxiety, appearing cowardly and small through both animations and visual design/character model. In order to match our PS2 art style the character model should be low poly and reflect character model techniques used during the PS2 generation of game development. This ensures we do not waste time developing high quality assets, stay in line with our minimalist approach and ensure that the character fits with the PS2 art style and the rest of the environment. The player character should have a human like silhouette, allowing players to recognise and sympathise with the character whilst still retaining feelings of abstraction.

Concept art and inspiration images can be found on the mood board by following this link: [Mo](#)

[od board/art style ideas](#)

Alongside this the player model should aid in creating a mysterious and fantastical feeling atmosphere. The main way we will do this is through the tattoos found on the character model. The tattoos should be reminiscent of Ainu textile patterns. This helps increase the players curiosity, making them question where the main character is from and what their society looks like. Examples of these patterns/tattoos can be viewed below:



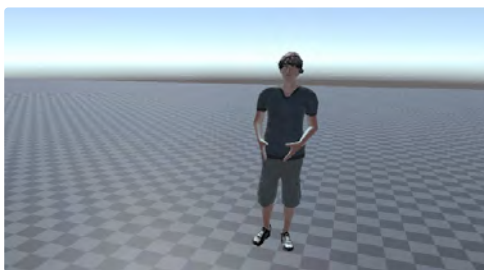
The concept images above provide an accurate depiction of what the player characters 3D model could look like in its most basic form however in order to fit within [Don't] Let Go the 3D model needs to be made adhering to the PS2 inspired art style that is used throughout the experience.

Alongside this the players character model should progressively change throughout the experience in tandem with the cube and their relationship to it. As the player progresses the cubes black colour should slowly start to overwhelm the player, appearing to corrupt their player model each time the player increases or upgrades the cubes state. Simultaneously, the cube should gradually become more colourful as though it was sucking the colour from the player and consuming it. A similar mechanic can be found in Shadow of the Colossus, pictured below:

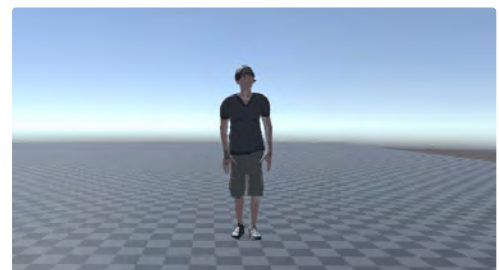


Image detailing the changes in the Wander player model as the game progresses [Shadow of the Colossus]

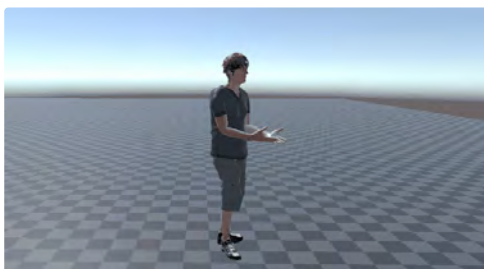
Motion capture test animations can be seen below outlining a basic view of how we want the animations to appear in game



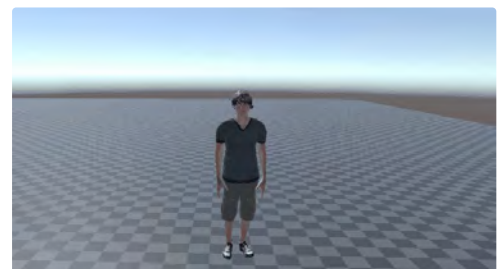
Animation showing player character sitting on the cube and standing up again



Animation showing the player throwing the cube



Animation showing the player struggling to carry the cube whilst walking



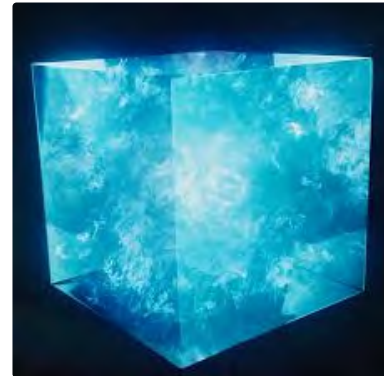
Animation showing the player character jumping

Cube Visual Design:

Similarly to the player characters visual design, the cube should also be extremely simple and reminiscent of a PS2 game. This ensures that our art style stays consistent throughout the game. The cube should start as a primarily black object with a mist or smoke like appearance within it similar to the concept images below:



An image of the Palantir from Lord of the Rings



An image of the Tesseract from Avengers

As the game progresses this black mist within the cube should slowly transfer from the cube and onto the player, demonstrating its life sucking effect on the player and their relationship. Alongside this, when the cube is touching the environment it should suck the colour out of whatever it touched. For example, when the cube is in state 3 and pushed across a large distance it should leave behind a line of black and white in an otherwise colourful environment, appearing similarly to the trail left behind by a snail. At the same time the inner mist should transition from a black colouring to being more colourful, reflecting the environment it has been dragged over.

Whilst the cube should not contain fine details as to ensure compatibility with the PS2 art direction the cube should be designed in a way that takes advantage of the pareidolia effect. The pareidolia effect is a commonly experienced psychological phenomenon that makes people see faces in ordinary objects, an example of this effect can be viewed below. The cube should be designed in a way that takes advantage of this effect, allowing players to form a stronger bond to the cube through personifying it despite it still being an object. Furthermore, as the game progresses the cubes perceived “face” should change in emotion, going from weak and desperate in state 1 to angry and intimidating in state 3.



An example of the pareidolia effect



An example image showing how a persons eyes can communicate the emotion they are feeling. The cube should utilise a similar approach being more implicit and vague than explicit

To further personify the cube it should flash each time it “talks” to the player. This offers the player visual feedback whilst also allowing them to build a stronger connection to the cube via its attempted communication and subsequent personification. Each time the cube flashes it should do so in an off white hue in order to contrast its normal black appearance and stand out to the player.

In addition, the cube and its corners should change as its states increase. In state one the cubes corners should be rounded and appear soft in order to communicate feelings of companionship and safety. However, each time the player upgrades the cubes state these corners should become sharper with the state 3 cube having normal cube corners to communicate feelings of danger and demonstrate the cubes subtle personality shift with each state.

Enemy Visual Design:

The enemy visual design should follow a similar approach to the cube and player visual designs to ensure [Don't] Let Go has a consistent artstyle throughout the experience, preventing breaks in immersion. The enemies should also be minimal in their asset detail, instead being more like vague silhouettes and solid colours. The enemies should be a solid black colour with minimal greys used as highlights or when the enemy is near a light source. Importantly, this colour should not change with enemies remaining a solid black for the entire experience. We use black for the enemy visual design due to its connotations with death and destruction, outlining the destructive nature of the enemies immediately which is then reinforced by its gameplay mechanics.

Alongside its basic colour being similar to the player, the enemy's visual design should be humanoid like in a similar vain to the players visual design. However, where the two differ is in the enemy visual designs Lovecraftian and Alien inspirations. The enemy models should appear to have sharp, claw like appendages as well as multiple intimidating tentacles that attach to the models back. This should be done to create a model that feels intimidating and otherworldly, striking fear into players through its unnatural design. Example inspiration images can be viewed below:



Examples of lovecraftian creature silhouettes



Example of the Alien's visual design, notice its sharp appendages and threatening design

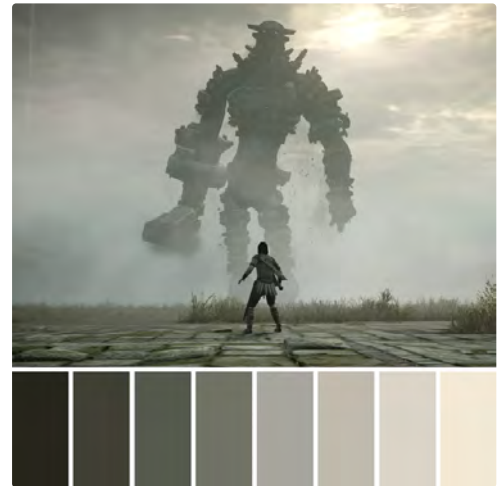
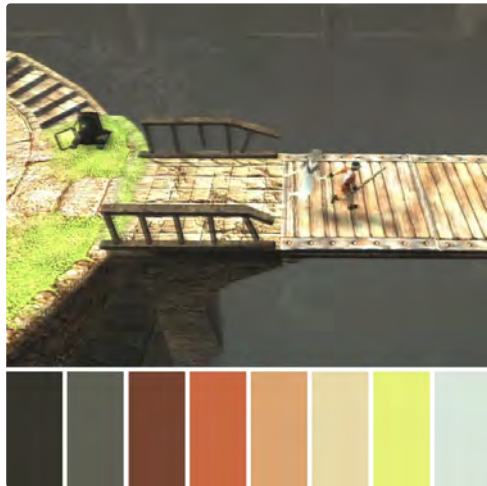
Concept Art/Images:

All of our concept art images can be found by following the link here: [🔗 Mood board/art style id](#)

[eas](#)

Colour Pallet and Mood:

Due to our lack of an artist the colour palette has not been considered heavily or expanded upon. However, we are aiming for a colour pallet that is more muted in reference to things like walls and architecture but bright in reference to things like greenery and vegetation. Overall our mood should be melancholic and lonely, these two feelings should be reinforced through the colour pallet and the usage of colour throughout the environment. Examples of the kind of colour pallet we are going with can be found below:



Lighting:

Due to the project being in the prototyping stage we have not considered what the lighting should specifically look like however it should be bright and contain a strong bloom effect to bring the game more in line with something like Ico and Shadow of the Colossus. The lighting should reflect a classic PS2 title using similar lighting styles and techniques.

Feedback

any feedback, criticisms, notes goes in here and of course take full notes of feedback during the weekly presentations and post it here :)

[Week 1 Presentation Feedback \(20/3/25\):](#)

[Week 2 presentation feedback \(27/03/2025\)](#)

[Week 4 Presentation Feedback \(10/04/2025\)](#)

[Week 5 Presentation Feedback \(01/05/2025\)](#)

Week 1 Presentation Feedback (20/3/25):

notes:

- From sion we got about puzzle vocabulary, have 4-6 repeatable puzzles that we can change how they look and work the same, sprinkle unique one time puzzles around them
- shape of the architecture needs to be right in order to sell it
- Substance designer, mainly used for textures
- cel plus slow blur equals jagged edges plus hue and colour equals ghibli style brush strokes
- think in terms of colour and study impressionist paintings
- Use mystical colours for fog and environment detail
- for next presentation, rushed into the product, rushed x razor and elevator statement
- Use numerical indexes on slides and images
- Put WIP under prototype images and videos
- hour to hour should be changed to session to session
- reactive tethered camera might be worth looking into
- experiment, listen to the game
- abstract individualism, research
- dont get complacent or cocky/ego
- have fun :DD
- production slide is too vague
- risks were vague and could be explored more, we seemed chill
- Capture cool moments and accidents now, catalog and document everything
- Stay resilient to feedback

- Look into UI

what went well:

- Project was greenlit
- Zuby and Sion liked the game idea and presentation

what needs to be changed:

- Need to index images and slides
- Need to spend more time explaining X statement, Razor statement and elevator statement
- Put WIP under prototype images and videos

Next steps:

- Focus on puzzle design and creating reusable puzzle instances
- Focus on motion capture and testing animations
- Focus on researching impressionist paintings and shader

Week 2 presentation feedback (27/03/2025)

Notes:

Zuby Feedback from teams:

- Maybe get professional images of yourselves for the team intro
- Annotations missing
- Don't overlay the Numerical indexing on the images: use the term 'Fig1'
- Also WIP is missing
- Cognitive Load chart: how did you get the axis decided upon?
- Superb level of theoretical engagement
- Would be good to get an idea of what you perceive your risks are at this stage

Andy's notes:

Sion:

- two triangles evolving into a cube, how does this impact life, society and architecture
- Look into Zelda and cubelet terror hawks



- Have fun with existential questions
- size and mass should play a part in puzzles, maybe more heavily
- maybe add more mechanics or changes to the cube and rooms, balloon, gravity, elasticity

Dan:

- death stranding and cargo as a hinderence, research
- Bevel shaders on cube could change cube interaction with environment
- Kuwahara filter (blurs and rebuilds post process)
- Look intro french architecture
- claude monet painting changes based on emotion, from very vibrant to depressive paintings with mundane colour pallete
- When player is further from cube change colour and music
- Be unobvious, subtle with themes
- Abstract or more gothic, maybe cube is the only abstract that
- Research van gogh and stary night
- When building architecture use randomizer to affect shapes and randomness

Zuby:

- overall a level 6 post graduate presentation, good feedback
- Look into chained together and other similar products
- second to second gameplay be careful with making the cube and rope gameplay frustrating
- mess around with parameters of the cube and world
- Explain axis on graphs
- Risks every week

What went well:

- Post graduate level presentation
- Continued green light
- Academic rigour

What needs to be changed:

Next steps:

Week 4 Presentation Feedback (10/04/2025)

Notes:

- Rule of thirds was good
- Could experiment with the cybe being in the middle or on the third line
- Fibanachi sequence and magic spiral for camera, might help with scale and UI
- Use word areas instead of levels
- Hub is good 👍
- Key art is good but explain why we chose it
- Death wave - need to consider if we actually need it, make it a triggered event
- Make gameplay demo/build, make a level to showcase mechanics

What went well:

- key art was good
- hub room was good
- presentation structure wsa good

What needs to be changed:

- change levels to “areas”

Next steps:

- create gameplay demo
- Expand on death wave design

Week 5 Presentation Feedback (01/05/2025)

Notes:

- 10/10 no negative notes on the demo

- linked the cube to a vacuum, gets snagged on everything allows us to use this in level design as a way to show the cubes personality
- can increase playtime by making the player do busy work
- cannot go back in levels due to the size of the state 3 cube and doorways (nice way to introduce valves organically)
- smoothing average filter for the cube velocity may be worth looking into
- playstation one art direction instead of impressionist may work better
- minecraft, doom or quake textures might work well and can be made relatively easily by us
- filter looks very noisy and granular, the noise map filter may be too small

What went well:

- Lecturers liked the demo
- Architecture was good and showed the direction we wanted to go

What needs to be changed:

- Potentially the shader and the art direction we want to go in

Next steps:

- Discuss art direction changes

Death Wave Design

THIS IS AN OUTDATED DESIGN DOCUMENT, THE DEATH WAVE NO LONGER EXISTS WITHIN THE GAME

Design Philosophy:

Design Pillars:

Death Wave Visual Design:

Death Wave Spawning:

Death Wave Movement:

Death Wave Fail State:

Death Wave Safe Points:

Death Wave and Cube Interaction:

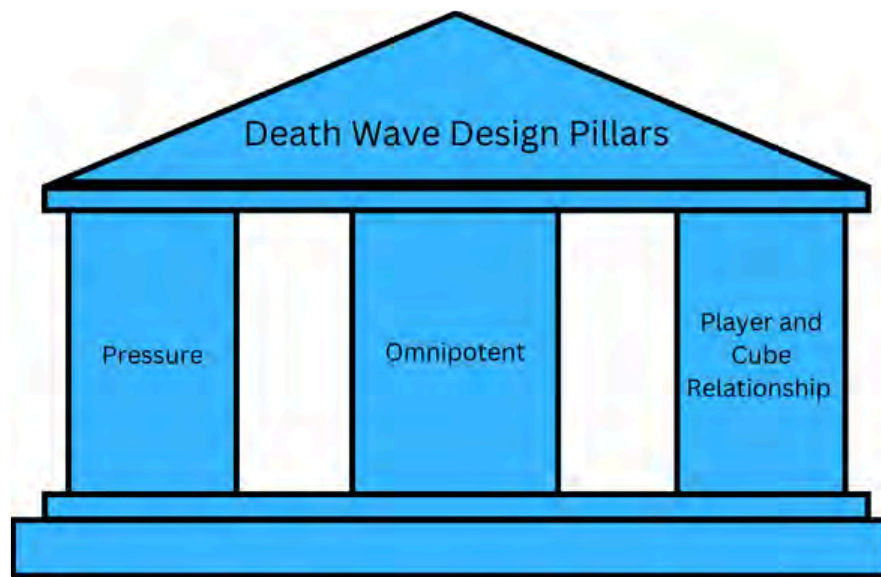
THIS IS AN OUTDATED DESIGN DOCUMENT, THE DEATH WAVE NO LONGER EXISTS WITHIN THE GAME

Design Philosophy:

The main philosophy/approach we take towards the death wave and its design is similar to the one that we apply to the enemy's design. The Death Wave should act as a tool that is used to both develop the players bond with the cube and elicit feelings of weakness within the player. Players should feel powerless in the face of the death wave, placing a heavy amount of pressure on them to escape before it consumes the entire environment. They should feel as though the Death Wave cannot be beaten, acting as a constantly returning enemy that limits the players progress.

Alongside this, the death wave should be used as a way to introduce unique gameplay sequences, being used as a pacing tool. The Death Wave should break up slow paced gameplay sequences with fast paced and pressuring action in order to keep players engaged and create a more interesting and varied experience.

Design Pillars:



Player and Cube Relationship:

Much like other aspects of PROJECT CUBE, a core pillar of the Death Wave and its design should be to continue furthering and testing the players relationship with the cube. This should come from the joint peril and powerless feelings the player and cube should feel when the death wave is active. Additionally, the strength of the player and cubes relationship should be shown through the death wave and the cubes resistance to it in state 3.

Omnipotent:

The second pillar “omnipotent” refers to how powerful the Death Wave should be in the eyes of players. The Death Wave should make the player feel extremely weak through its consuming of the environment, limiting the areas the player can move to. This limiting of movement options directly affects the players ability to survive by removing a fundamental aspect of the game (traversal of the environment) aiding in making the player feel weak and bolstering the Death Waves strength.

Pressure:

The final pillar “pressure” refers to how the player should feel during the Death Wave sequences. Players should feel heavily pressured due to the dwindling movement options and the rapidly approaching Death Wave. These sequences should be extremely tense for the player, increasing overall game pacing.

Death Wave Visual Design:

The Death Wave should also follow a similar artistic style to the player, enemy and cube with it being quite a basic model with a lack of detail and one solid colour.

The Death Wave should appear similar to something like the Fortnite Storm mixed with Venom and Lovecraftian creatures. It should appear as though it is alive, clawing at the floor and slowly consuming it with its goo like body. The Death Wave should contain a motion texture to simulate the Death Wave goo moving and appearing to breath. The Death Wave could look like the BT goo in Death Stranding. The images below serve as inspiration for the Death Wave and what it could potentially look like:



Death Stranding BT Goo



Example of Venom's distinct tendrils



Examples of tendrils found on Lovecraftian creatures

Death Wave Spawning:

The Death Wave should not be an enemy players can find within the environment, it should only spawn when triggered. This trigger could be linked to an in world event or interaction like when the player switches a lever or it could simply be a trigger box that activates the Death Wave once the player steps into it. Importantly, the Death Wave should not be spawned immediately upon activating this trigger. There should be a brief delay of 3-6 seconds before the Death Wave spawns. In this time the Death Wave audio track should be played to increase tension and anticipation for the Death Wave in a similar fashion to how tension is built in Steven Spielberg's Jaws.

Once this delay has ended the Death Wave should be spawned in the players location when they activated the trigger. Once it has been spawned the Death Wave should appear to consume the environment whilst it is chasing the player, blocking off paths the player could use whilst still chasing them. In this way the Death Wave is similar but still distinct from linear systems like the Fortnite storm.

Death Wave Movement:

During this prototype stage the Death Wave and its movement speed has not yet been solidified however it should move at a similar speed to the player and enemies, ensuring it is not faster than either.

Regarding movement behaviour, the Death Wave should move in an almost random and unpredictable way. It should consume the environment methodically like the Fortnite storm however this movement should not be linear like the Fortnite storm and similar systems. The Death Wave should move sporadically around while blocking off paths, and covering the area quickly to elevate the tension the player should feel during these segments and make each encounter different.

Death Wave Fail State:

When the player is within the Death Wave's proximity/goo their movement speed should be decreased and the player should slowly sink into the goo. If the player does not move or escape from the goo quickly their character and the cube should be consumed by the Death Wave and a fail state should trigger. Players can escape the Death Wave by attempting to move and wade through the goo, to move faster and slow their sinking the player can jump. Each time the player jumps their character should escape the get closer to escaping the goo whilst also moving forward slightly. This system could be similar to the cube pulling progress bar system, the player will need to rapidly press the jump button to prevent a progress bar from reaching zero, if it does reach zero the Death Wave fail state should trigger.

Death Wave Safe Points:

In order to survive and escape the Death Wave players will need to quickly find a rest/safe point in the environment. The rest points are the only areas of the levels that cannot be consumed by the death wave, thus protecting players and the cube from a fail state. The rest points should protect the player from the death wave once they enter its proximity however this will not remove/de-spawn the death wave. In order to reset the death wave and allow players to leave the rest point without dying they will need to interact with the rest point, this will send the player into a "resting" game state and thus the death wave will disappear and players are granted the ability to leave the rest area and continue progressing through the level. The rest/safe points will be spawned in specific areas of a level prompting players to remember its location and testing them on their spatial awareness and navigational skills once the Death Wave is activated.

Death Wave and Cube Interaction:

Before the cube reaches state three it should not have any interaction with the Death Wave as to ensure it remains intimidating and threatening, the player should have no way to defeat it.

However, when the cube reaches state three it should protect the player from the Death Wave in a similar manner to the rest points. When the player is within the proximity of the state three cube it should emit a bubble like shield, protecting the player from the Death Wave as long as they remain inside of it. From here the player will need to push the cube to a rest point thus allowing them to reset/despawn the Death Wave.

Project Overview

[Don't] Let Go:

Do you have the strength to sever your only connection



Meet the Team:

Our goals for the project:

Game Name:

X Statement:

Razor Statement:

Elevator Statement:

Expected Project Completion:

Genre:

References/Inspiration:

Core Concept:

Game Summary:

Unique Selling Point:

Target Audience:

Platform:

Tech/Software used:

External Links:

Meet the Team:



			
Andrew McKenna	Dylan Rose	Loki Rogers	Liam Burden
Lead Producer Designer	Lead Designer Producer	Programmer	Programmer

Our goals for the project:

A list of the teams overall goals for the project can be found by following the link here: [Overall](#)

[Project Goals:](#)

Game Name:

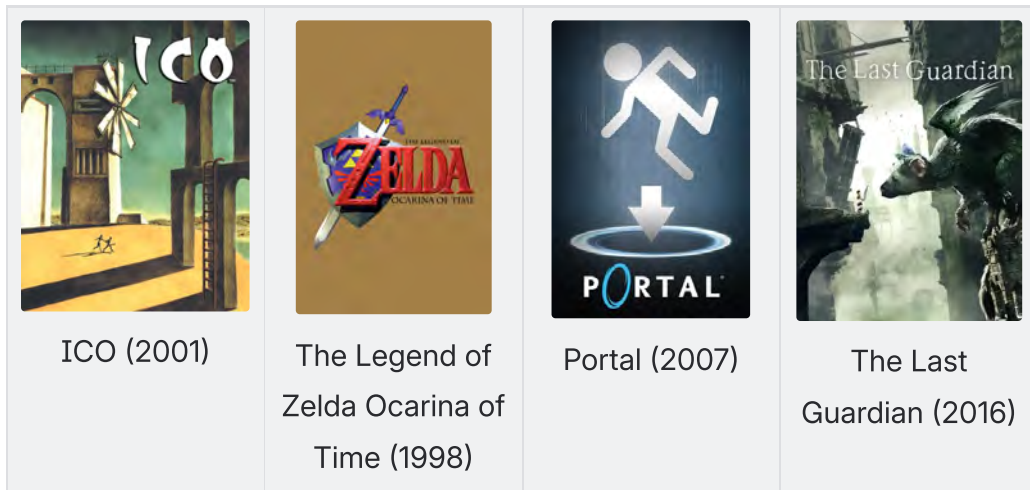
[Don't] Let Go

X Statement:

Do you have the strength to sever your only connection?

Razor Statement:

[Don't] Let Go is a mix of the emotional impact of Ico and The Last Guardian with the puzzle and level design of Portal and Ocarina of Time



Elevator Statement:

[Don't] Let Go is an action-adventure game centring around the players relationship with a mysterious cube. Together the unlikely duo must escape an abandoned city hidden deep within a crater, solving its many enigmas and avoiding ancient omnipotent threats.

Expected Project Completion:

20th August 2025

Genre:

3D Puzzle Action Adventure

References/Inspiration:

[Don't] Let Go utilises a wide plethora of inspirations that aid in creating the developers desired experience. The full list of inspirations can be seen below:

Gaming related inspirations:

- Ico
- The Last Guardian
- Shadow of the Colossus
- Journey
- The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time

Other inspirations:

- Fallen Angels (Wong Kar-Wai, 1995)
- In the Mood for Love (Wong Kar-Wai, 2000)
- Impressionist paintings
- Princess Mononoke
- Parasite: the Maxim (2014)
- Roman and Khmer architecture

Core Concept:

The core concept of [Don't] Let Go is the focus on and exploration of the emotional connection that players form with a seemingly ordinary cube like object. The game aims to explore and utilise fundamental player psychology in order to create this deep connection between the player and cube that rivals similar feelings of companionship players have to characters in games such as Ico and The Last Guardian. [Don't] Let Go aims to explore the emotional difficulties this close relationship may cause when the two parties (the player and the cube) grow apart and must separate with the concept of letting go being a central theme throughout every aspect of the experience.

Game Summary:

Players will venture to an ancient and mostly abandoned city located deep within a crater on a journey to see whether the forgotten city is inhabitable for their wandering tribe. Here the player will find a mysterious cube that latches onto them forming a rope like connection between the two, players must use this cube to escape the city by solving its many puzzles and allowing the cube to grow. However, all is not as it seems as the cube will start to slowly act like an anchor, weighing the player down and making their escape almost impossible. In the end, the player is forced to make the difficult decision to sever the connection with their only friend and escape the city in a focused approximately one-hour long experience

Unique Selling Point:

Our main unique selling point and primary focus of the game is the connection players will form with the cube from both a gameplay and emotional point of view. Starting with the emotional aspects of our unique selling point what makes the cube in our game unique is the strong emotion players will form with a seemingly ordinary cube through the focus on their relationship that is reinforced via other game elements such as puzzle sequences, levels and combat encounters. From a gameplay point of view the player will form a strong connection to the cube due to its essentiality towards the players progress, aiding them in solving puzzles, defeating enemies and overall escaping the underground city alongside being the only way players can save their progress, applying greater meaning to the cube through game elements outside of the gameplay loop.

Target Audience:

Our main target audience for [Don't] Let Go is primarily fans of games like Ico, Shadow of the Colossus and The Last Guardian due to the similarities [Don't] Let Go has with those games through avenues like narrative design and level design.

[Don't] Let Go will be a PEGI 7 rated game. This is due to the lack of graphic violence, foul language or depiction of drugs.

Whilst we aim for a PEGI 7 rating we believe the target audience for our game will range from ages of 12-16+. We believe this due to the games focus on the intrinsic and resonant meaning behind the games theme. Whilst young players will be able to understand the theme and narrative of our game we feel it will resonant much more with older players who may have a similar life experience, making for a more engaging and resonant experience that achieves our goals.

Platform:

PC: [Itch.io](https://itch.io) and Steam

Tech/Software used:

Design Centric Software

- Jira
- Confluence
- [Draw.io](https://draw.io)
- PowerPoint
- Canva

Development Centric Software

- Unity (2022.3.21f1)
- GitHub
- Fmod
- Cinemachine
- Navmesh
- URP (Universal Render Pipeline)
- Pro-Builder
- New Input System

External Links:

- Link to Games Website:
- Link to Final Release Trailer:
- Link to Games TIGA trailer: [📺 \[Don't\] Let Go - Alpha Build Trailer](#)
- Link to Games Gameplay walkthrough:

Overall Project Goals:

Welcome to the goals and objectives page, below information on what we as a team want to achieve through this project can be seen as well as our goals for what we want players to experience throughout our game.

What the team wants to achieve:

- Create a polished and high quality portfolio piece ready for industry applications
- Create a 1 hour long experience with a definitive and bare minimum start middle and end
- Create an experience that is considered high quality enough to be published onto Steam
- Achieve a presentation slot during the summer showcase in order to show our game to the industry guests
- Clearly demonstrate and showcase all members of the teams skills and proficiency in their chosen discipline
- Fun experience working together as a team that is as stress free as possible in order to enjoy our final modules at University
- Create effective design documentation akin to that of industry standards

Experience goals:

- Create a strong emotional connection between the player and the cube through intrinsic and minimalist means
- Develop a short but memorable and impactful experience

Game Design Overview

Overall Design Pillars:

Overall Design Philosophy:

Core Gameplay Loop:

Primary Game Mechanics:

Climbing:

Throwing:

Carrying/holding:

Meta Critical Breakdown:

Player Objectives/Goals:

Overall Objective:

Continuous Objectives:

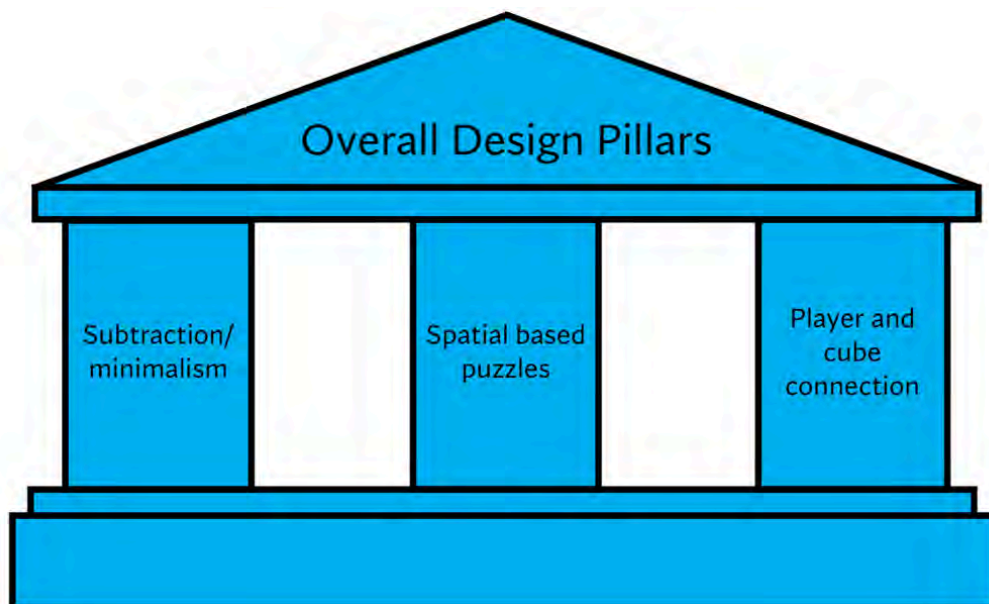
Controls:

Narrative Summary:

Primary Narrative Theme:

Secondary Narrative Themes:

Overall Design Pillars:



Overall Design Philosophy:

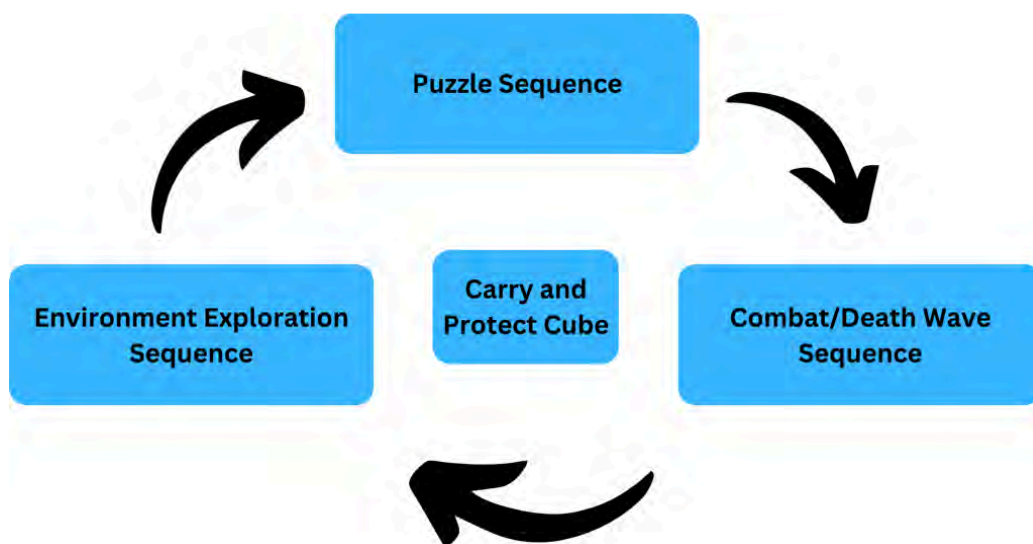
Throughout each and every aspect of [Don't] Let Go we utilise a design by subtraction or minimalist design philosophy. The design by subtraction philosophy was popularised by Fumito Ueda and his team at genDESIGN. The philosophy states that any game element that does not link to or further the main theme of the game should be removed as to keep the game minimal and focused. Design by subtraction enables the development team to place a heavier emphasis on critically analysing whether mechanics serve the main theme of letting go and

companionship, if they do not it is essential that they are cut in order to adhere to our philosophy. This is for the two reasons found below:

The first reason is due to the projects scope. Managing and limiting the projects scope is a major focus due to the small size of the [Don't] Let Go's development team which can be found on the project overview page [[Project Overview](#)]. Adopting a minimalist approach allows the team to limit the projects scope and create a higher quality product further linking to the teams overall goals found on the goals and objectives page [[Overall Project Goals:](#)]

The second reason the team adopts a design by subtraction approach is due to its suitability regarding creating emotion based and artistic gaming experiences. The subtraction approach provides the team with a framework that aids in the creation of a focused experience centring around [Don't] Let Go's main themes of letting go and companionship, allowing the team to cut non-essential content much easier. Success in this regard has been demonstrated through games like Journey, Ico and Shadow of the Colossus which all demonstrate an artistic usage of the video game medium and emotion centric design to leave players with an engaging and unique experience which links to the overall project goals the team aims to achieve through [Don't] Let Go which can be found on the goals and objectives page [[Overall Project Goals:](#)]

Core Gameplay Loop:



An image of the core gameplay loop found within [Don't] Let Go

The core gameplay loop of [Don't] Let Go can be viewed above. The experience should be split into three different sequences or states those being the puzzles, combat and exploration sequences. Each of these will provide the player with a different challenge, testing a fundamental player skill with those being the following:

- Puzzle sequences will challenge the players problem solving skills
- Combat sequences will challenge the players positioning and reflexes
- Exploration will challenge the players navigation and mental map skills.

The structure of these gameplay sequences should not be rigid or completely identical to the gameplay loop, their order can be changed in order to provide more engaging and less predictable gameplay. The diagram below demonstrates an example of this loop changing concept:



A visual demonstration outlining how the order of gameplay loop sequences can be altered to create less predictable gameplay whilst still retaining a structured approach

Across each sequence of the loop the player needs to continually protect, carry and navigate the environment with the cube. This is the only aspect of the gameplay loop that follows a rigid structure and cannot be changed. Consequently, the cube affects each sequence of the loop differently, it should provide players with unique and increasingly difficult challenges to overcome alongside the pre-existing challenges of the sequence they are already in.

Primary Game Mechanics:

There are three primary mechanics the player will be utilising throughout [Don't] Let Go. These three mechanics are: climbing, throwing and carrying. All three of these mechanics or verbs link directly to the cube which is the primary focus of the game. An explanation of what these mechanics are and how the player interacts with them can be found below:

Climbing:

In [Don't] Let Go players have the ability to climb different game elements throughout the underground city, aiding in their traversal of the environment and eventual escape. Players will be able to climb holes in walls, ropes, the cube's cord and ledges. These mechanics function similarly to games like Ico and Uncharted, allowing players to jump from node to node in a mostly linear fashion. Alongside climbing the environment, players will also be able to climb onto the cube when it has reached the third and final state, enabling players to gain access to new areas and protect themselves from enemies

Throwing:

Throwing is another essential mechanic that not only relates to the cube but also to other environmental props like barrels and crates. Players will be able to pick up the cube and other props, enabling them throw the object at their chosen target. This target is decided by what the

player is locked onto. Players are able to throw the objects they pick up at enemies, distant platforms or other environmental elements like fragile pillars. These objects combined with the throwing mechanic provides players with a way to defeat enemies and solve [Don't] Let Go's many puzzles.

Carrying/holding:

The final core mechanic is the carrying mechanic. Similar to throwing, the player will have the ability to pick up the cube and other props, however this mechanic is primarily useful for aiding the player in traversing the environment with the cube. Players will find that carrying the cube is much easier than dragging it by the cord, enabling them to make progress much faster and decreasing the tedium of pulling the cubes weight especially as it increases. Players will need to carry the cube through, around and over different environmental challenges like large walls, deep pits and the death wave. Players can carry the cube by walking over to it and pressing and holding the pickup button.

A diagram outlining all of the players verbs and mechanics can be found on the player design page [[Player Design](#)]

Meta Critical Breakdown:

Second to Second:

- Carry and protect the cube from enemies
- Navigate the level
- Overcome cube based navigational puzzles

Minute to Minute:

- Upgrade the cube to the next state
- Solve environmental and discrete puzzles
- Avoid the death wave

Session to Session:

- Escape the city (complete the game)

The diagram above outlines the meta critical breakdown of gameplay in [Don't] Let Go showing exactly what the player will be doing across the experience. Due to the projects small scope and one hour playtime an hour to hour gameplay loop is unnecessary. Therefore, a session to session loop has been displayed instead to better showcase exactly what the average players experience will look like.

Player Objectives/Goals:

The players objectives are split into two different categories across [Don't] Let Go, these being overall objectives and continuous objectives.

Overall Objective:

The primary and overall objective players will be working towards is escaping the underground city and from a gameplay point of view, finishing the experience. However, before the player can achieve this overall objective they must first achieve all of the continuous objectives.

Continuous Objectives:

Continuous objectives can also be viewed as secondary objectives however they are essential to the players progress, they are continuous due to their constantly evolving (thus continuous) nature. Players will need to achieve 5 different continuous objectives before they are able to achieve their overall goal of escaping the city and completing the game. These 5 objectives are split between each act of the game and can be viewed in the diagram below:

Continuous Objective 1:

Players must learn the basic controls of the game and beat the tutorial sequence

Continuous Objective 2:

Players must find a way to upgrade the cube to state 2

Continuous Objective 3:

Players must find a way to upgrade the cube to state 3

Continuous Objective 4:

Players must find their way back to the main hall, exiting the city

Players must sever their connection to the cube

Controls:



Image of the PlayStation control scheme



Image of the Xbox control scheme

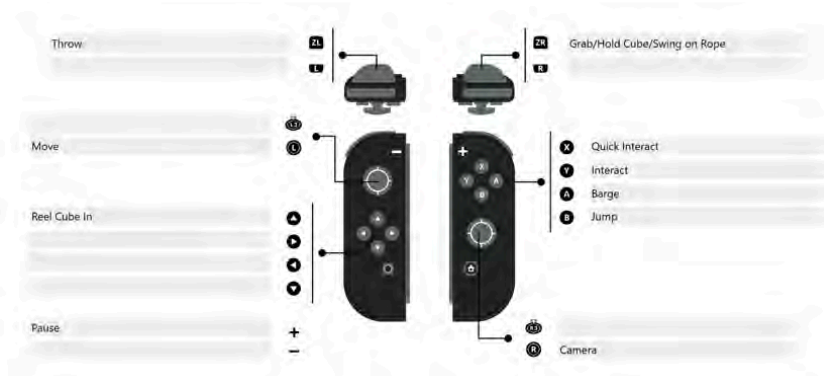


Image of the Nintendo Switch control scheme

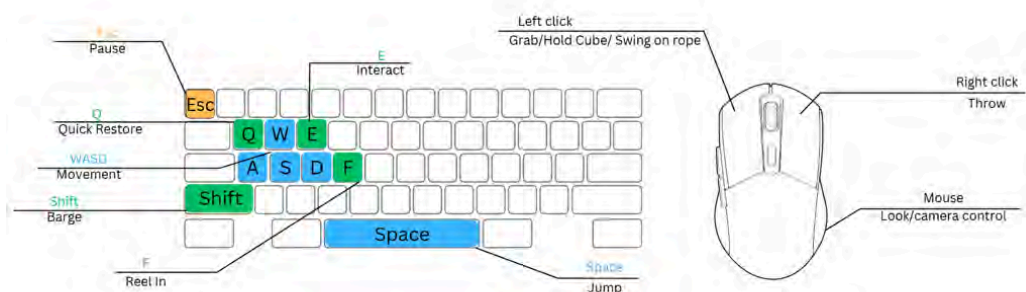


Image of keyboard control scheme

Narrative Summary:

In [Don't] Let Go the player and the small expedition they are apart of discover an ancient underground city thought to be lost to myth and legend. Upon entering the small group is wiped out by an omnipotent wave of death and malice, leaving the player alone and without a clear way to escape. Aiming to find a way out, players will encounter a mysterious cube that latches onto them forming a rope like connection between the both of them. The two must work together, utilising their unique strengths and weaknesses to find a way out of the underground city however only one is fated to leave this cursed place.

Primary Narrative Theme:

The primary narrative theme of [Don't] Let Go is letting go of a friend. Throughout the game players should experience the progressing stages of a friendship, meeting and befriending the cube in the beginning, experiencing relationship turbulence in the middle and finally letting go of the cube at the end of the game. Across its runtime [Don't] Let Go should explore the emotional difficulties of letting go, demonstrating to the player how hard it is to initially move on from a friend and the consequential grief many feel. This should be demonstrated to players in a resonant and intrinsic way, making the player feel as though they are losing a friend and not simply just showing their character losing the friend they made in the form of the cube.

Secondary Narrative Themes:

Alongside the main theme [Don't] Let Go should also explore the secondary themes below in order to create an experience that players can relate to through multiple avenues and to provide greater emotional depth to the overall narrative and gameplay:

- Companionship
- Loneliness
- Weakness
- Anthropomorphism
- Reliance on someone or something